Project 2 – Acme Analytics Linux Platform

Complete report so far · Days 1–3 · 13–17 October 2026

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Goal	A hardened, observable and recoverable Linux platform for a small analytics company, built by hand in VMware
Servers	gw01 192.168.60.1 (gateway) · app01 .10 (application) · stor01 . 20 (storage) · svc01 .40 (service desk)
Repository	github.com/muhammadbilaljaved684-dotcom/Linux-Platform

Where the project stands

Phase	Topic	Status
0	Know the system: kernel, boot, targets	🟡 gw01 done
1	Network foundation: static IPs, routing, NAT, names, SSH, users, inodes	✅ complete – snapshot `20-Network`
1A	Service desk: GLPI tickets and inventory	🟡 svc01 built, GLPI in Docker, agent inventory of all 4 servers – snapshot `25-service-desk`
2	Storage: LVM, NFS, backups, snapshots	⏳
3	Automation: systemd services and timers	⏳
4	Processes, signals, cgroups	⏳
5 / 5A	Logging · monitoring and alerting	⏳
6 / 6A	Security hardening · WireGuard VPN	⏳
7 / 7A	Publish the web service · Ansible	⏳
8	Acceptance tests and disaster drill	⏳

Contents

Part	What is inside
Day 1 – 13 Oct	The Acme story · Phase 0 baseline (kernel, drivers, memory, boot, server mode) · Phase 1 part 1: static addresses, gw01 as router with NAT and firewall
Day 2 – 15 Oct	Steps 1.5–1.9: SSH keys, hard and soft links, inodes, users and groups, service account · Linux NAT vs cloud NAT · end of Phase 1
Day 3 – 16–17 Oct	Phase 1A: why a service desk · svc01 settings and install · LVM disk growth · the network story · Docker + GLPI · VMnet2 host adapter · GLPI agent inventory

Next

1. Disable GLPI’s default accounts and demo data.
2. First Change ticket: *Introduce GLPI service desk and asset inventory*.
3. Step 1A.3: entity, categories, SLAs, users, knowledge base.

Day 1 – 13 October 2026

The story · Phase 0: know the system · Phase 1: network foundation (part 1)

Project 2 – Acme Analytics Linux Platform: the Day 1 story

Build story and history · Day 1 · 13 October 2026 · Muhammad Bilal Javed

> The same story as a document to download: Project-2-Day-1-story.odt. The detailed technical reports are part 1 and part 2.

How to read this document

This is the story of the first day of building a small company's Linux platform in a home lab. It follows the order in which the work really happened, including the mistakes. Every chapter answers four questions:

- **Where are we?** The situation before the step.
- **What did I do, and why?** The commands, with a plain-language explanation.
- **What does the screenshot prove?** The real output from my lab.
- **Why do we go to the next step?** What this step made possible, or what problem it revealed.

You do not need to know Linux to follow it. Technical words are explained when they first appear, and a short glossary is at the end.

The story in one paragraph

Acme Analytics is a small company whose server setup has grown messily: nobody controls what reaches the internet, nothing is documented, and nobody could rebuild a server the same way twice. My job is to build a clean, controlled platform. On Day 1 I first **recorded how the servers looked** before touching anything. Then I built the **network foundation**: every server got a fixed address, the two internal servers lost their own internet connection, and the gateway server gw01 became the **one and only door** to the internet. At the end of the day, app01 – a server with no internet card of its own – could reach the internet through gw01, the outside world saw only gw01's address, and the servers could find each other by name. Along the way I hit and solved ten real problems.

Chapter 0 – The plan and the machines

Where are we?

The goal is the platform shown below. It is built in phases (P0, P1, …); Day 1 covers Phase 0 and most of Phase 1 – the boxes **gw01**, the **VMnet2 lab network**, **app01** and **stor01**.

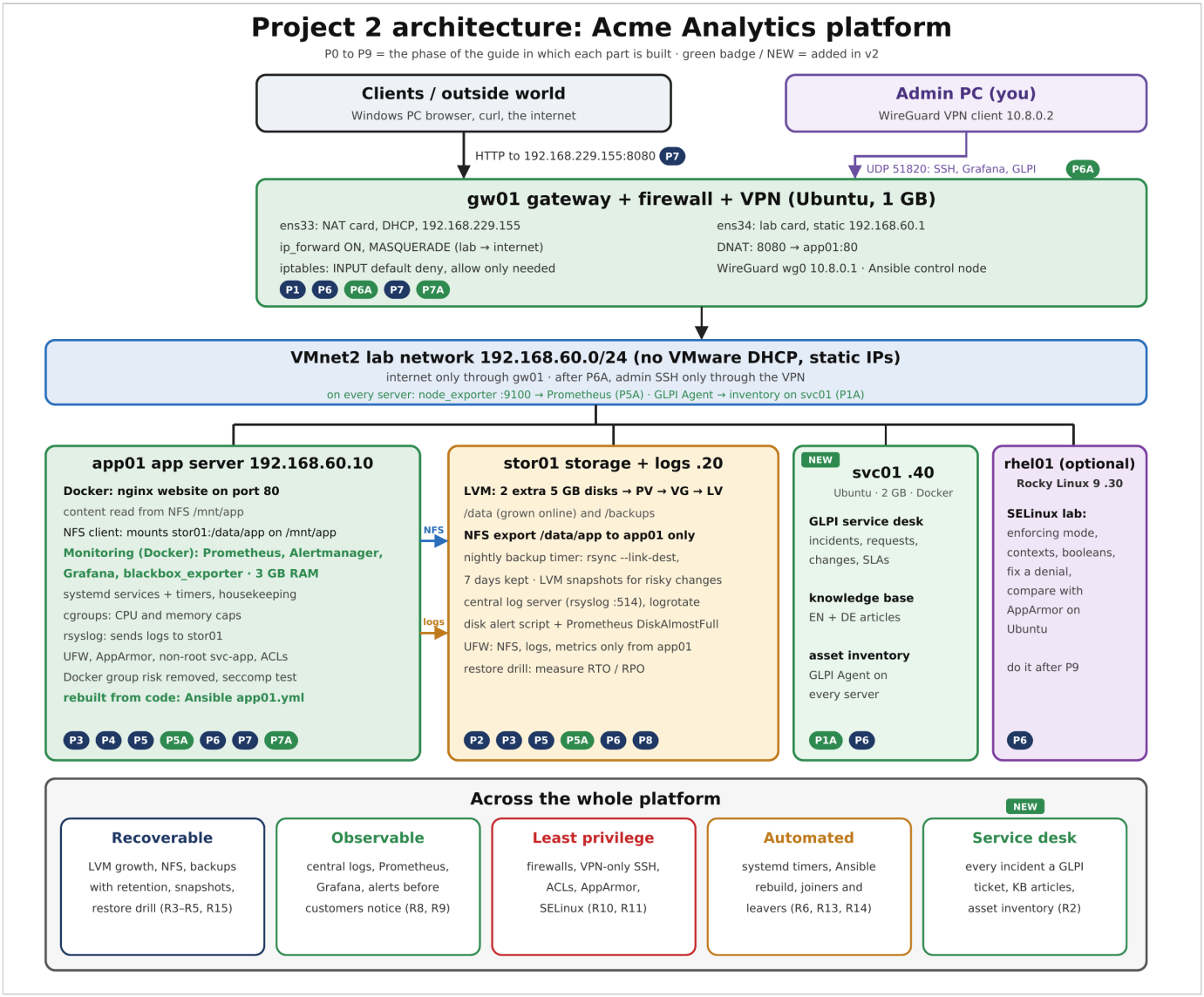


Figure 1 – Target architecture of the whole project. Day 1 builds the gateway, the lab network and the addresses of app01 and stor01.

Instead of buying servers, I run three **virtual machines** (computers simulated by software) in VMware. Think of them as three employees with different jobs:

Server	Job in plain words	Job in technical words
gw01	The gatekeeper – the only door to the internet	Gateway: router, NAT, firewall, later VPN
app01	The shop window – will run the website	Application server
stor01	The archive room – files, backups, logs	Storage and log server

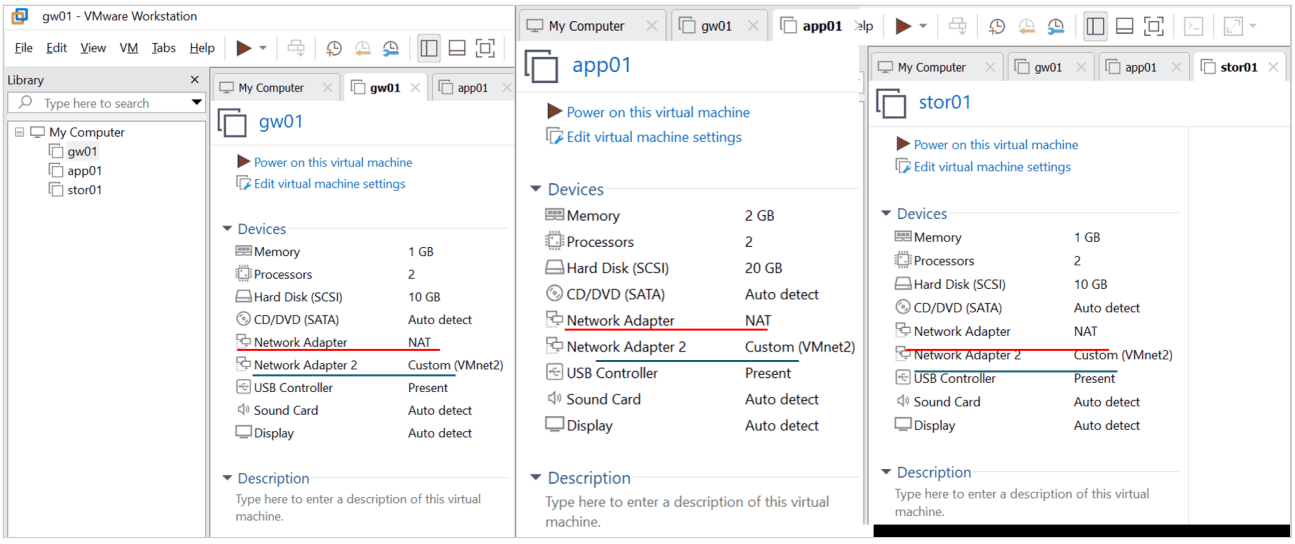


Figure 2 – The three VMs in VMware. Each has two network cards: “Network Adapter” (NAT = internet through Windows) and “Network Adapter 2” (VMnet2 = the private lab network).

Why do we go to the next step?

Before changing anything, a good engineer writes down how the system looks *now*. Otherwise, when something breaks later, there is nothing to compare against.

Chapter 1 – Know the system (Phase 0)

Step 0.1 – Engine, drivers and memory

What I did and why. The **kernel** is the engine of Linux. **Modules** are drivers – small add-ons that let the engine use hardware. I recorded the engine version, the loaded drivers, the memory, and one important switch: whether gw01 may pass traffic between networks.

```
uname -r                    # kernel version only
uname -a                    # everything: name, kernel, build date, CPU type
cat /proc/version           # the kernel's own description (compiler, build)
lsmod | head                # first 10 loaded drivers
free -h                     # memory and swap, in human-readable units
sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward  # may this machine route traffic? (0 = no, 1 = yes)
```

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ uname -r
5.15.0-198-generic
bilal_001@gw01:~$ uname -a
Linux gw01 5.15.0-198-generic #208-Ubuntu SMP Fri Sep 4 10:22:38 UTC 2026 x86_64 x86_64 x86_64 GNU/L
inux
bilal_001@gw01:~$ cat /proc/version
Linux version 5.15.0-198-generic (buildd@lcy02-amd64-040) (gcc (Ubuntu 11.4.0-1ubuntu1~22.04.3) 11.4
.0, GNU ld (GNU Binutils for Ubuntu) 2.38) #208-Ubuntu SMP Fri Sep 4 10:22:38 UTC 2026
bilal_001@gw01:~$ lsmod | head
Module                  Size  Used by
vsock_loopback         16384  0
vmw_vsock_virtio_transport_common    40960  1 vsock_loopback
vmw_vsock_vmci_transport    32768  1
vsock                  49152  5 vmw_vsock_virtio_transport_common,vsock_loopback,vmw_vsock_vmci_tran
sport
intel_rapl_msr         20480  0
binfmt_misc            24576  1
vmw_balloon            24576  0
intel_rapl_common      40960  1 intel_rapl_msr
rapl                   20480  0
bilal_001@gw01:~$ free -h
               total        used        free      shared  buff/cache   available
Mem:           1.9Gi       299Mi       1.3Gi       1.0Mi       331Mi       1.4Gi
Swap:          1.3Gi          0B       1.3Gi
bilal_001@gw01:~$ sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward
net.ipv4.ip_forward = 0
bilal_001@gw01:~$ _
```

Figure 3 – Baseline of gw01: kernel 5.15.0-198, VMware drivers loaded, 1.9 GiB memory, and ip_forward = 0.

What the screenshot proves.

- Kernel `5.15.0-198-generic` – the standard Ubuntu 22.04 engine.
- Drivers `vmw_vsock`, `vmw_balloon` – the system knows it is a VMware virtual machine.
- Memory: 1.9 GiB, only 299 MiB used – plenty for a gateway.
- **`ip_forward = 0`** – gw01 is still an ordinary computer, *not* a router. Remember this number: changing it to 1 is the turning point of the afternoon.

Step 0.2 – How the machine starts

What I did and why. Starting a computer is a relay race: firmware → bootloader (GRUB) → kernel → systemd (the manager) → services → login. I measured how long it takes and saved the details to files as evidence.

```
systemd-analyze                           # total boot time
systemd-analyze blame >> boot-gw01.txt    # time per service, saved to a file
journalctl -b | head -15 >> journal-gw01.txt  # first log lines of this boot, saved
ls /boot                                  # the files used to start Linux
```

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ systemd-analyze
Startup finished in 17.022s (kernel) + 21.095s (userspace) = 38.117s
graphical.target reached after 19.809s in userspace
bilal_001@gw01:~$ systemd-analyze blame >>boot-gw01.txt
bilal_001@gw01:~$ journalctl -b | head -15 >>journal-gw01.txt
bilal_001@gw01:~$ ls /boot
config-5.15.0-198-generic       initrd.img.old                  vmlinuz-5.15.0-198-generic
grub                            lost+found                      vmlinuz.old
initrd.img                      System.map-5.15.0-198-generic
initrd.img-5.15.0-198-generic   vmlinuz
bilal_001@gw01:~$ _
```

Figure 4 – Boot takes 38.1 s (17.0 s kernel + 21.1 s services). /boot holds the current kernel and the previous one as a fallback.

What the screenshot proves. The machine boots in **38.1 seconds** and ends in `graphical.target` (desktop mode). `/boot` keeps an **older kernel (`vmlinuz.old`) as a safety net** if an update fails.

Step 0.3 – Server mode instead of desktop mode

What I did and why. Linux can start in different modes, called **targets**. A desktop (`graphical.target`) is wasted on a server nobody sits in front of. Server mode (`multi-user.target`) runs everything needed – network, services, logins – without the desktop: faster, lighter and with fewer things an attacker could abuse.

```
systemctl get-default                          # which mode now?
sudo systemctl set-default multi-user.target   # switch to server mode
systemctl get-default                          # check
```

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ systemctl get default
Unknown command verb get.
bilal_001@gw01:~$ systemctl get-default
graphical.target
bilal_001@gw01:~$ sudo systemctl set-default multi-user.target
[sudo] password for bilal_001:
Created symlink /etc/systemd/system/default.target → /lib/systemd/system/multi-user.target.
bilal_001@gw01:~$ systemctl get-default
multi-user.target
```

Figure 5 – gw01 switched from graphical.target to multi-user.target. The first line shows my typo "get default" (the command is get-default).

Why do we go to the next step?

I now know how gw01 looks. The next question is: **how are the three machines connected?** That is the network – and without a working network nothing else in the project (storage, monitoring, VPN, automation) can work.

Chapter 2 – The starting point of the network

Where are we?

Before configuring anything, I looked at each machine's network cards (`ip -br a`) and disks (`lsblk`).

```
hostname    # which machine am I on?
ip -br a    # network cards: name, state, address (brief form)
lsblk       # disks and partitions
```

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ hostname
gw01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            UP             192.168.229.155/24 metric 100 fe80::20c:29ff:feac:fa08/64
ens34            DOWN
bilal_001@gw01:~$ lsblk
NAME                      MAJ:MIN RM  SIZE RO TYPE MOUNTPOINTS
loop0                       7:0    0 63.9M  1 loop /snap/core20/2318
loop1                       7:1    0 63.8M  1 loop /snap/core20/2922
loop2                       7:2    0   87M  1 loop /snap/lxd/29351
loop3                       7:3    0 38.8M  1 loop /snap/snapd/21759
loop4                       7:4    0 44.7M  1 loop /snap/snapd/28254
sda                         8:0    0   10G  0 disk
├─sda1                      8:1    0    1M  0 part
├─sda2                      8:2    0  1.8G  0 part /boot
└─sda3                      8:3    0  8.2G  0 part
  └─ubuntu--vg-ubuntu--lv 253:0    0  8.2G  0 lvm  /
sr0                        11:0    1    2G  0 rom
bilal_001@gw01:~$ _
```

Figure 6 – gw01 at the start: ens33 (internet side) has 192.168.229.155; ens34 (lab side) is DOWN with no address.

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ hostname
app01
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            UP             192.168.229.152/24 metric 100 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59c4/64
ens34            DOWN
bilal_002@app01:~$ lsblk
NAME                      MAJ:MIN RM   SIZE RO TYPE MOUNTPOINTS
loop0                       7:0    0  63.9M  1 loop /snap/core20/2318
loop1                       7:1    0  63.8M  1 loop /snap/core20/2922
loop2                       7:2    0    74M  1 loop /snap/core22/2955
loop3                       7:3    0    87M  1 loop /snap/lxd/29351
loop4                       7:4    0 115.2M  1 loop /snap/lxd/40911
loop5                       7:5    0  38.8M  1 loop /snap/snapd/21759
loop6                       7:6    0  44.7M  1 loop /snap/snapd/28254
sda                         8:0    0    20G  0 disk
├─sda1                      8:1    0     1M  0 part
├─sda2                      8:2    0   1.8G  0 part /boot
└─sda3                      8:3    0  18.2G  0 part
  └─ubuntu--vg-ubuntu--lv 253:0    0    10G  0 lvm  /
sr0                        11:0    1  1024M  0 rom
bilal_002@app01:~$ _
```

Figure 7 – app01 at the start: it ALSO has its own internet address (192.168.229.152) on ens33; the lab card ens34 is DOWN.

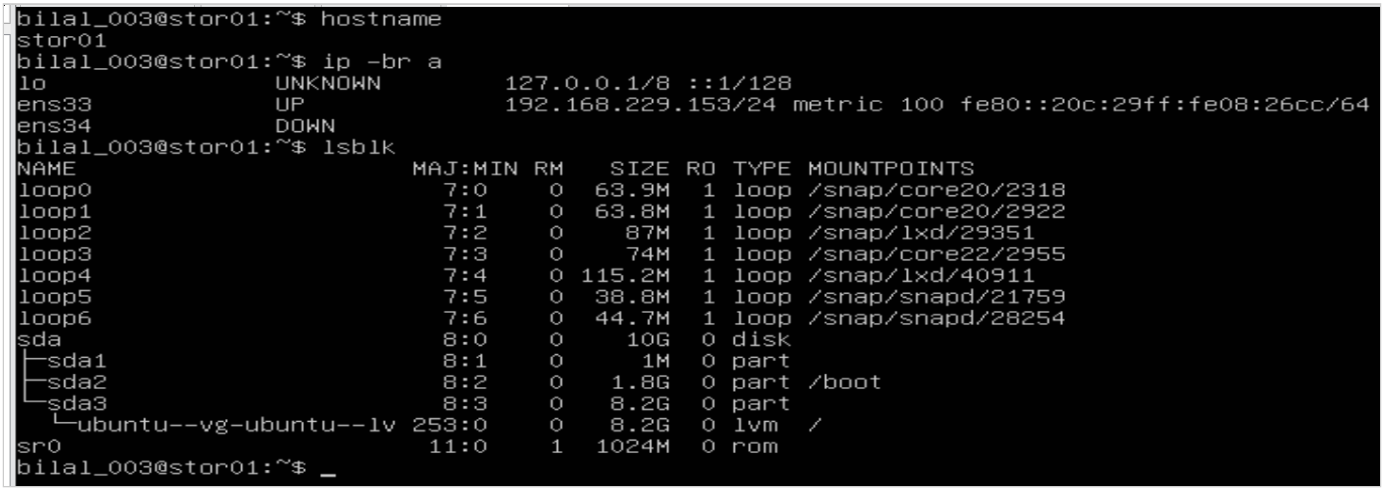


Figure 8 – stor01 at the start: its own internet address (192.168.229.153), lab card DOWN, and only one disk (sda) – the two extra data disks are missing.

What the screenshots reveal – three problems

What I saw	Why it is a problem
ens34 is **DOWN** on all three machines	The lab network is unused – the servers cannot talk to each other
app01 and stor01 have their **own internet address** on ens33	Breaks the design: every server has its own uncontrolled door to the internet
stor01 has only **sda**	The storage phase needs two extra empty disks

`lo` (loopback) is the machine talking to itself and is always there – it can be ignored.

Why do we go to the next step?

The servers need **fixed addresses** on the lab network, like permanent desk-phone numbers. Every later part of the project – firewall rules, file sharing, monitoring, automation – refers to these numbers. If they changed, everything would break.

Chapter 3 – Fixed addresses for every server (Step 1.1)

The method (same on every server)

On Ubuntu, network settings are stored in a small text file in `/etc/netplan/`. The safe method has six moves:

1. **Find the file** – `ls /etc/netplan`
2. **Back it up** – `sudo cp … ~/netplan-backup.yaml`, so I can always go back.
3. **Stop cloud-init from overwriting it.** `cloud-init` is a helper that configures the network at first boot – and may silently *rewrite my file* at a later boot. I tell it "network: hands off".
4. **Write the new settings** in the file. The format is **YAML**, where indentation (spaces) is part of the meaning.
5. **Apply with an automatic undo** – `sudo netplan try`. It applies the change and **undoes it after 120 seconds** unless I press Enter. If I can still type, the change works.
6. **Reboot and check** – a setting that disappears after a restart is worthless.

3.1 gw01 – the gatekeeper gets its inside address

```
ls /etc/netplan                                                  # -> 50-cloud-init.yaml
sudo cp /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml ~/netplan-backup.yaml  # backup
echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg
```



Figure 9 – gw01: the real file is 50-cloud-init.yaml, backed up, and cloud-init's network handling disabled.

First surprise: my guide expected a file called `00-installer-config.yaml`. The real file is `50-cloud-init.yaml`. Lesson: *check, don't assume.*

The new settings for gw01: the internet card keeps getting its address automatically; the lab card gets the fixed address **192.168.60.1**. gw01 needs no gateway on the lab side – it *is* the gateway.

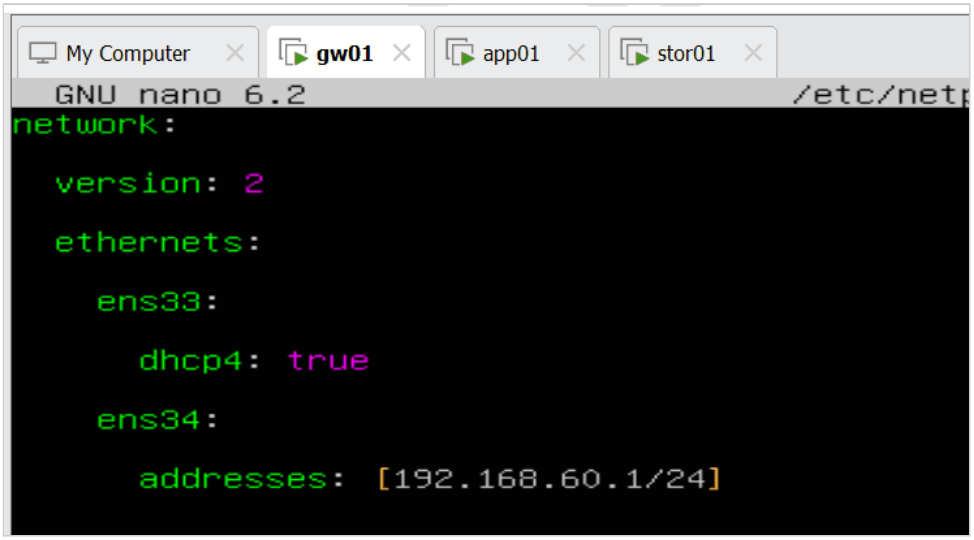


Figure 10 – gw01's netplan file, typed in the nano editor.

```
sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml   # only the administrator may read/write it
sudo netplan try                                 # apply with automatic undo; Enter = keep
ip -br a                                         # check
```



Figure 11 – netplan try accepted; ens34 on gw01 now has 192.168.60.1/24. The Open vSwitch warning is harmless (that software is not installed).

Result: gw01 now has two addresses – one facing the internet, one facing the lab.

3.2 app01 – the shop window, and an unplugged cable

app01 gets the fixed address **192.168.60.10**, and a **default route**: "for any address you don't know, ask gw01 (192.168.60.1)". It also gets DNS servers (1.1.1.1 and 8.8.8.8) – the internet's phone book, which turns names into numbers.

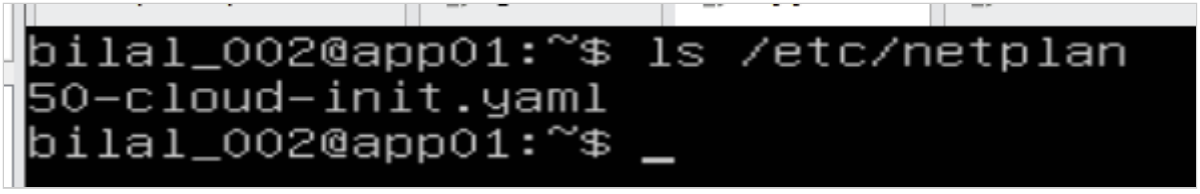


Figure 12 – app01 also uses 50-cloud-init.yaml.

```
50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo cp /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml ~/netplan-backup.yaml
bilal_002@app01:~$ echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-n
etwork-config.cfg
#network: {config: disabled}
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo cat /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
network:

  version: 2

  ethernets:

    ens34:

      addresses: [192.168.60.10/24]

      routes:

        - to: default

          via: 192.168.60.1

      nameservers:

        addresses: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo netplan try
WARNING:root:Cannot call Open vSwitch: ovsdb-server.service is not running.
Do you want to keep these settings?


Press ENTER before the timeout to accept the new configuration


Changes will revert in 119 seconds
Configuration accepted.
```

Figure 13 – app01: backup, cloud-init line, the new settings (192.168.60.10, default route via gw01, DNS servers) and netplan try. Note the "#" at the start of the cloud-init line – a typing slip that turns the line into a comment.

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            UP             192.168.229.152/24 metric 100 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59c4/64
ens34            UP             192.168.60.10/24 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59ce/64
bilal_002@app01:~$ ping -c 3 192.168.60.1
PING 192.168.60.1 (192.168.60.1) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=10.8 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=0.755 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=3 ttl=64 time=1.33 ms

--- 192.168.60.1 ping statistics ---
3 packets transmitted, 3 received, 0% packet loss, time 2035ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 0.755/4.287/10.779/4.596 ms
bilal_002@app01:~$
```

Figure 14 – app01 can now reach gw01 (3 of 3 replies) – the lab network works. BUT ens33 still has its own internet address 192.168.229.152.

Second surprise. The lab network worked, but app01 still had its own internet line. Configuring Linux alone was not enough: the **virtual cable was still plugged in** in VMware. The real fix is to unplug it in the VM's settings – untick **Connected** and **Connect at power on**.

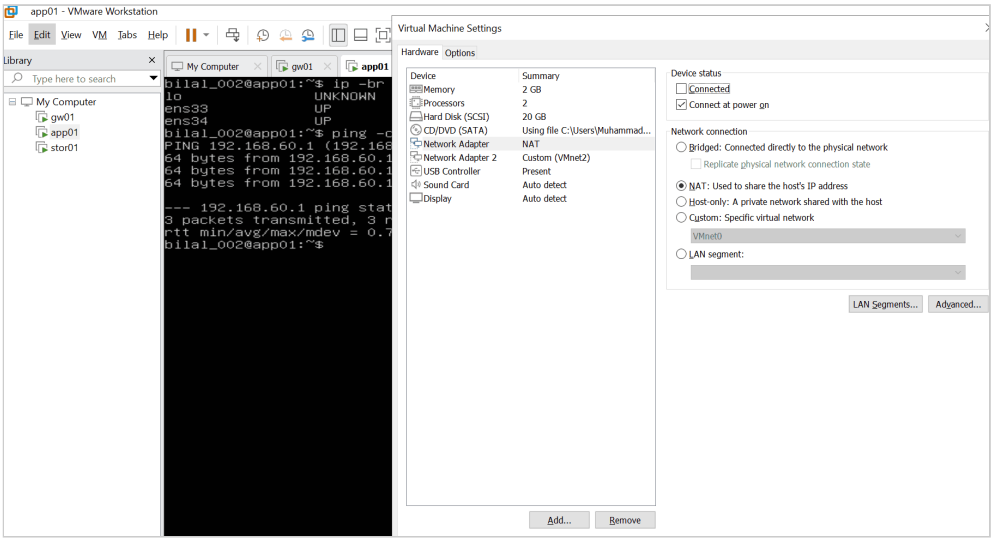


Figure 15 – Unplugging app01's internet adapter in VMware (Connected unticked).

Before rebooting I also checked the cloud-init file, because of the # seen in Figure 13. It now reads correctly, without the #:

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo cat /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg
[sudo] password for bilal_002:
network: {config: disabled}
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo reboot_
```

Figure 16 – The cloud-init file is correct: "network: {config: disabled}", no "#".

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            DOWN
ens34            UP             192.168.60.10/24 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59ce/64
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip route
default via 192.168.60.1 dev ens34 proto static
192.168.60.0/24 dev ens34 proto kernel scope link src 192.168.60.10
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo cat /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg
network: {config: disabled}
```

Figure 17 – app01 after reboot: ens33 DOWN (unplugged), ens34 = 192.168.60.10, default route via gw01, cloud-init file still correct.

What Figure 17 proves:

Line	Meaning
`ens33 DOWN`	The private internet line is gone
`ens34 UP 192.168.60.10/24`	The fixed address survived the reboot
`default via 192.168.60.1`	Everything not local is sent to gw01

A note on VMnet2. The lab network VMnet2 does not appear in VMware's Virtual Network Editor (only VMnet1 and VMnet8 are listed). That is correct: VMnet2 is used as a **private, isolated switch** – no connection to Windows and no automatic address service. The lab is closed; only gw01 connects it to the outside.

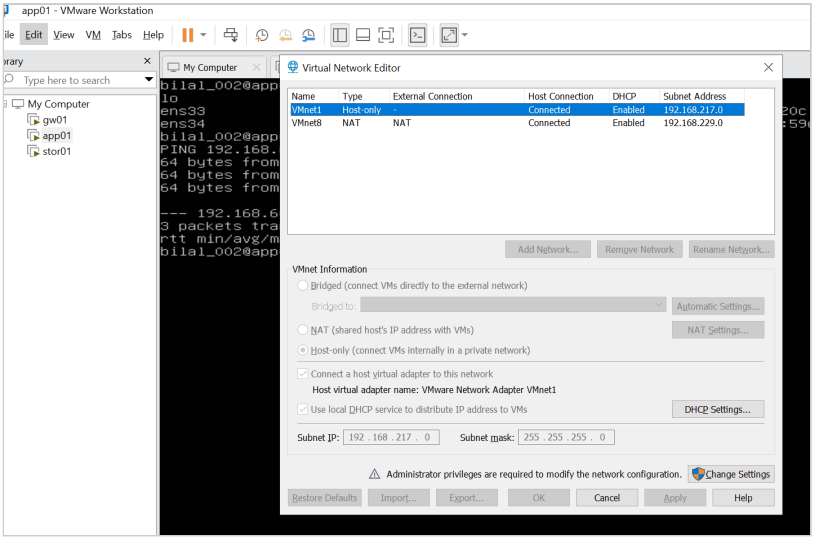


Figure 18 – VMware's Virtual Network Editor lists only VMnet1 and VMnet8 – VMnet2 is an isolated switch, as intended.

3.3 stor01 – the archive room, and the missing disks

stor01 got the same treatment, now done in the right order from the start – lesson learned from app01.

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ls /etc/netplan
50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo cp /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml ~/netplan-backup.yaml
bilal_003@stor01:~$ echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-
network-config.cfg
network: {config: disabled}
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo cat /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
network:

  version: 2

  ethernets:

    ens34:

      addresses: [192.168.60.20/24]

      routes:

        - to: default

          via: 192.168.60.1

      nameservers:

        addresses: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_003@stor01:~$
```

Figure 19 – stor01: file found, backed up, cloud-init disabled (correctly this time), settings with 192.168.60.20, permissions set.

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo netplan try
WARNING:root:Cannot call Open vSwitch: ovsdb-server.service is not running.
Do you want to keep these settings?


Press ENTER before the timeout to accept the new configuration


Changes will revert in 108 seconds
Configuration accepted.
bilal_003@stor01:~$ _
```

Figure 20 – stor01: netplan try accepted.

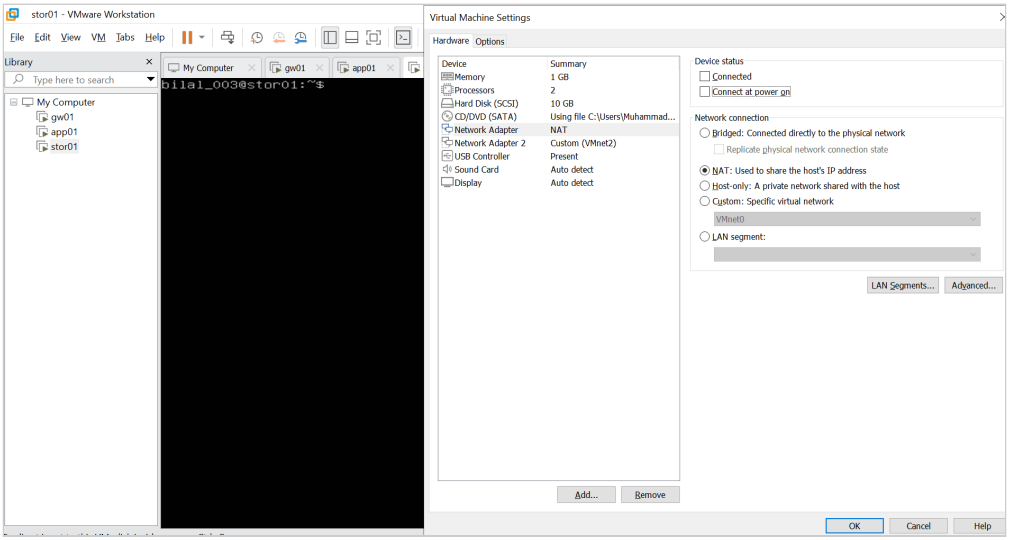


Figure 21 – stor01's internet adapter unplugged in VMware: both "Connected" and "Connect at power on" unticked.

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            DOWN
ens34            UP             192.168.60.20/24 fe80::20c:29ff:fe08:26d6/64
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ip route
default via 192.168.60.1 dev ens34 proto static
192.168.60.0/24 dev ens34 proto kernel scope link src 192.168.60.20
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ping -c 3 192.168.60.1
PING 192.168.60.1 (192.168.60.1) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=5.36 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=4.76 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=3 ttl=64 time=2.04 ms

--- 192.168.60.1 ping statistics ---
3 packets transmitted, 3 received, 0% packet loss, time 2003ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 2.039/4.050/5.357/1.443 ms
bilal_003@stor01:~$ lsblk
NAME                      MAJ:MIN RM   SIZE RO TYPE MOUNTPOINTS
loop0                       7:0    0  63.9M  1 loop /snap/core20/2318
loop1                       7:1    0    74M  1 loop /snap/core22/2955
loop2                       7:2    0  63.8M  1 loop /snap/core20/2922
loop3                       7:3    0    87M  1 loop /snap/lxd/29351
loop4                       7:4    0  38.8M  1 loop /snap/snapd/21759
loop5                       7:5    0 115.2M  1 loop /snap/lxd/40911
loop6                       7:6    0  44.7M  1 loop /snap/snapd/28254
sda                         8:0    0    10G  0 disk
├─sda1                      8:1    0     1M  0 part
├─sda2                      8:2    0   1.8G  0 part /boot
└─sda3                      8:3    0   8.2G  0 part
  └─ubuntu--vg-ubuntu--lv 253:0    0   8.2G  0 lvm  /
sr0                        11:0    1  1024M  0 rom
bilal_003@stor01:~$
```

Figure 22 – stor01 after reboot: ens33 DOWN, 192.168.60.20, default via gw01, 3/3 pings to gw01 – but lsblk still shows only sda.

Third surprise. The network was perfect, but `lsblk` showed that the two extra data disks planned for the storage phase had never been added. I powered stor01 off, added two 5 GB disks in VMware, and checked again:

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ lsblk
NAME                      MAJ:MIN RM   SIZE RO TYPE MOUNTPOINTS
loop0                       7:0    0  63.9M  1 loop /snap/core20/2318
loop1                       7:1    0  63.8M  1 loop /snap/core20/2922
loop2                       7:2    0    87M  1 loop /snap/lxd/29351
loop3                       7:3    0    74M  1 loop /snap/core22/2955
loop4                       7:4    0 115.2M  1 loop /snap/lxd/40911
loop5                       7:5    0  38.8M  1 loop /snap/snapd/21759
loop6                       7:6    0  44.7M  1 loop /snap/snapd/28254
sda                         8:0    0    10G  0 disk
├─sda1                      8:1    0     1M  0 part
├─sda2                      8:2    0   1.8G  0 part /boot
└─sda3                      8:3    0   8.2G  0 part
  └─ubuntu--vg-ubuntu--lv 253:0    0   8.2G  0 lvm  /
sdb                         8:16   0     5G  0 disk
sdc                         8:32   0     5G  0 disk
sr0                        11:0    1     2G  0 rom
bilal_003@stor01:~$ _
```

Figure 23 – After adding them: sdb and sdc, 5 GB each, empty and ready for Phase 2 (LVM).

Why do we go to the next step?

All three servers now have fixed addresses and can reach gw01. app01 and stor01 have **no internet line of their own** – so right now they have **no internet at all**. They know they should ask gw01, but gw01 does not pass anything on yet (`ip_forward = 0`, Figure 3). That is the next step.

Chapter 4 – gw01 becomes a router (Step 1.2)

What I did and why. By default, Linux refuses to pass on traffic that is not meant for itself – like a receptionist who only answers her own calls. Switching **IP forwarding** on turns gw01 into a switchboard between the lab and the internet.

```
echo "net.ipv4.ip_forward=1" | sudo tee /etc/sysctl.d/99-forward.conf  # permanent setting
sudo sysctl --system                                                   # load it now
sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward                                             # check: must be 1
```

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "net.ipv4.ip_forward=1" | sudo tee /etc/sysctl.d/99-forward.conf
net.ipv4.ip_forward=1
bilal_001@gw01:~$ sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward
net.ipv4.ip_forward = 1
bilal_001@gw01:~$
```

Figure 24 – ip_forward = 1. In the Phase 0 baseline (Figure 3) it was 0.

Why do we go to the next step?

gw01 now *passes traffic on*, but the internet still cannot answer app01. Addresses like 192.168.60.10 are **private**: they are not valid on the internet, so replies would have nowhere to go. gw01 must translate them – that is NAT.

Chapter 5 – Sharing the internet safely: NAT (Step 1.3)

What I did and why. NAT (Network Address Translation) works like a company mailroom. When app01 sends a letter out, gw01 crosses out the sender "Room 10" and writes the **company's street address** – its own. When the reply arrives, gw01 remembers who asked and delivers it to app01. The firewall rules decide **who may pass**: the lab may go out, and replies come back in. (Strictly blocking everything else needs a DROP default policy, which follows in Phase 6; today the lab is protected because its private addresses cannot be reached from the internet.)

```
# NAT: lab traffic leaving through ens33 gets gw01's address as sender
sudo iptables -t nat -A POSTROUTING -o ens33 -s 192.168.60.0/24 -j MASQUERADE
# allow: lab -> internet
sudo iptables -A FORWARD -i ens34 -o ens33 -j ACCEPT
# allow back in ONLY replies to conversations the lab started
sudo iptables -A FORWARD -i ens33 -o ens34 -m state --state ESTABLISHED,RELATED -j ACCEPT
# keep the rules after a reboot
sudo apt install -y iptables-persistent
sudo netfilter-persistent save
```

Rule	Plain words
MASQUERADE	"Write the company's return address on outgoing mail"
FORWARD lab → internet	"Staff may make outgoing calls"
FORWARD internet → lab, only ESTABLISHED,RELATED	"Only call-backs are put through"

The proof – from a server that has no internet card

```
ping -c 3 8.8.8.8      # can app01 reach a server on the internet?
curl -s ifconfig.me    # ask a website: which address do you see me coming from?
```

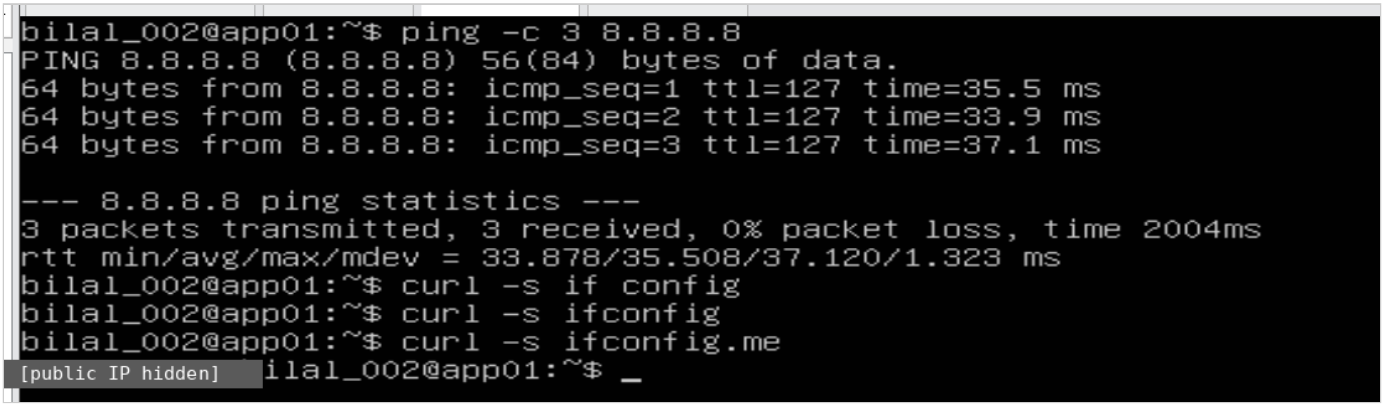


Figure 25 – app01 reaches the internet (3/3 replies from 8.8.8.8), and the website sees the home public address (hidden here), not 192.168.60.10. The two empty curl lines before were typos.

What Figure 25 proves.

- app01 has no internet card (Figure 17), yet it reaches 8.8.8.8 – **the only possible path is through gw01**.
- The website sees the public address, **not** 192.168.60.10 – NAT replaced the sender address.
- The reply TTL is 127 instead of 128. TTL is a counter that drops by one at every router – **the packets passed through one extra router: gw01**.

And from gw01's side – the NAT rule's counter shows the traffic it translated:

```
sudo iptables -t nat -L -n -v --line-numbers   # list NAT rules with packet counters
```

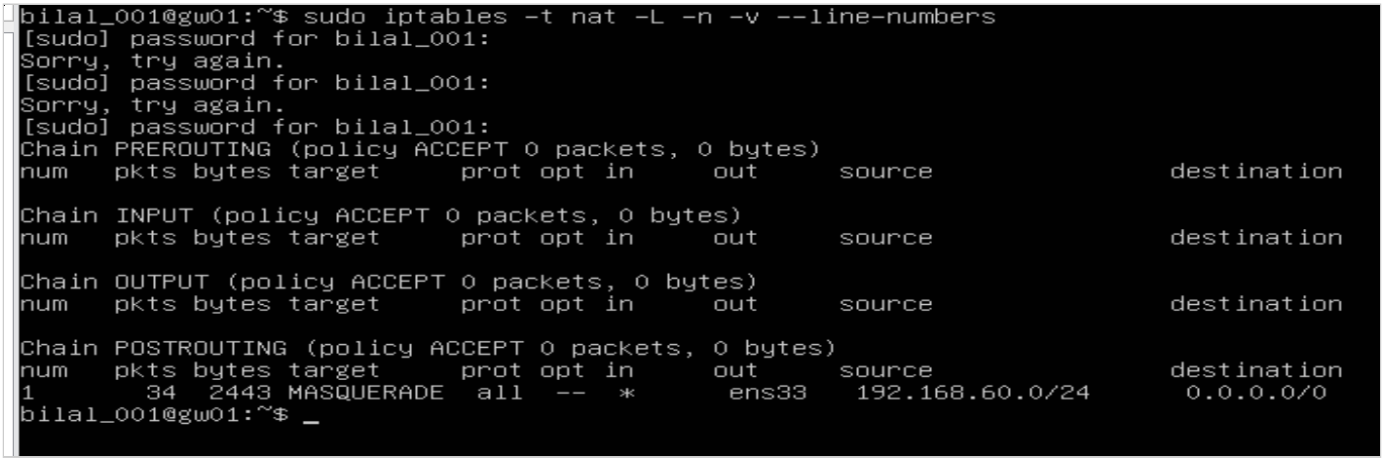


Figure 26 – On gw01 the MASQUERADE rule has translated 34 packets (2443 bytes) from 192.168.60.0/24 out through ens33. ("Sorry, try again" = mistyped sudo password.)

Why do we go to the next step?

The servers can now talk to each other and to the internet – but only by **number**. People and tools (SSH, file sharing, automation) use **names** like `stor01`. The next step teaches the servers to find each other by name.

Chapter 6 – Names instead of numbers (Step 1.4)

What I did and why. Computers connect only to numbers. Before connecting to a name, Linux looks it up – like a phone looking up a contact before dialing. It checks two places, in this order:

1. **`/etc/hosts`** – a small **personal contact list** on each machine. Checked first.
2. **DNS** – the internet's **public phone book**. Used only if the name is not in the contact list.

`getent` ("get entry") asks the system exactly this: *what is the address for this name?*

```
getent hosts stor01                                  # unknown -> prints nothing
echo "192.168.60.20 stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts  # add stor01 to app01's contact list
getent hosts stor01                                  # now: 192.168.60.20
ping -c 1 stor01                                     # reach the server BY NAME
```

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ getent hosts stor01
bilal_002@app01:~$ echo "192.168.60.20 stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
[sudo] password for bilal_002:
192.168.60.20 stor01
bilal_002@app01:~$ getent hosts stor01
192.168.60.20   stor01
bilal_002@app01:~$ pinc -c 1 stor01
Command 'pinc' not found, did you mean:
  command 'ping' from deb iputils-ping (3:20211215-1ubuntu0.1)
  command 'ping' from deb inetutils-ping (2:2.2-2ubuntu0.2)
  command 'inc' from deb mailutils-mh (1:3.14-1)
  command 'inc' from deb mmh (0.4-4)
  command 'inc' from deb nmh (1.7.1-11)
  command 'minc' from deb mblaze (1.1-1)
  command 'pic' from deb groff-base (1.22.4-8build1)
Try: sudo apt install <deb name>
bilal_002@app01:~$ ping -c 1 stor01
PING stor01 (192.168.60.20) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from stor01 (192.168.60.20): icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=5.30 ms

--- stor01 ping statistics ---
1 packets transmitted, 1 received, 0% packet loss, time 0ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 5.296/5.296/5.296/0.000 ms
bilal_002@app01:~$ _
```

Figure 27 – On app01: the first lookup is empty; after adding the entry the name resolves and "ping stor01" works. ("pinc" was a typo.)

```
grep '^hosts' /etc/nsswitch.conf   # the lookup ORDER
dig +short google.com              # ask DNS directly
```

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ grep '^hosts' /etc/nsswitch.conf
hosts:          files dns
bilal_002@app01:~$ resolvectl status | head -5
Global
       Protocols: -LLMNR -mDNS -DNSOverTLS DNSSEC=no/unsupported
resolv.conf mode: stub

Link 2 (ens33)
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo apt install -y dnsutils
Reading package lists... Done
Building dependency tree... Done
Reading state information... Done
dnsutils is already the newest version (1:9.18.39-0ubuntu0.22.04.6).
0 upgraded, 0 newly installed, 0 to remove and 66 not upgraded.
bilal_002@app01:~$ dig +short google.com
142.251.110.100
142.251.110.102
142.251.110.113
142.251.110.139
142.251.110.138
142.251.110.101
bilal_002@app01:~$
```

Figure 28 – "hosts: files dns" – the contact list is checked before DNS. dig returns Google's addresses, so DNS works through gw01.

Every server gets the same contact list

Each machine has its **own** `/etc/hosts`, so app01's entry did not help gw01 or stor01. I gave every server the names of the other two:

Machine	Added
gw01	app01 (.10), stor01 (.20)
app01	gw01 (.1) – stor01 was already there
stor01	gw01 (.1), app01 (.10)

The accidental "break it" test. On gw01 I first typed `192.168.60.200 stor01` by mistake, then the correct `.20` line. `/etc/hosts` is read top to bottom and **the first match wins**, so gw01 would have sent everything for stor01 to the non-existent .200 – exactly the classic fault the guide wanted me to provoke on purpose. I removed the wrong line in nano. (A similar slip on stor01 – `192.168.60.20 app01` – was caught and corrected the same way.)

```
My Computer | gw01 | app01 | stor01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.1  gw01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
[sudo] password for bilal_001:
192.168.60.1  gw01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.10  app01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
192.168.60.10  app01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.200  stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
192.168.60.200  stor01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.20  stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
192.168.60.20  stor01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ _
```

Figure 29 – The typo on gw01: a wrong 192.168.60.200 line for stor01 before the correct .20 line. The first match would have won.

The proof – every server reaches the other two by name:

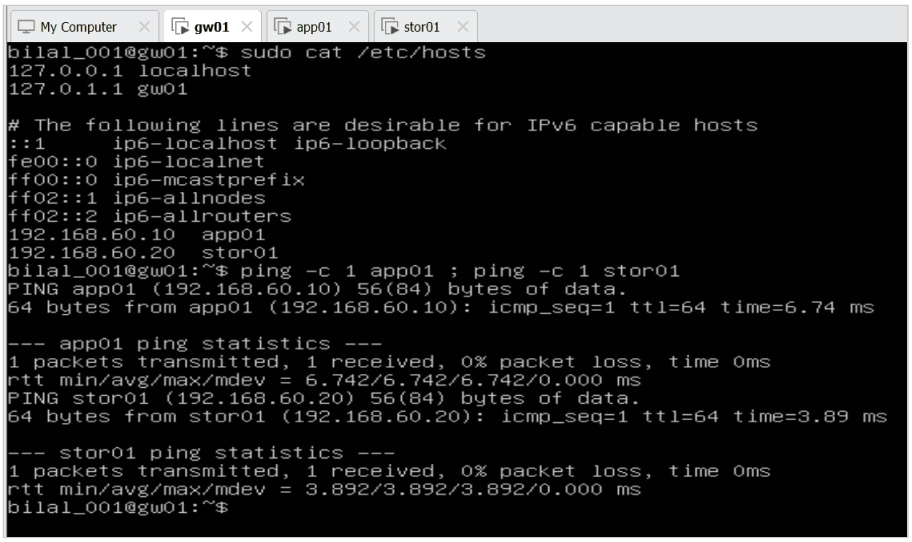


Figure 30 – gw01: correct contact list; ping app01 and ping stor01 by name, 1/1 received each.

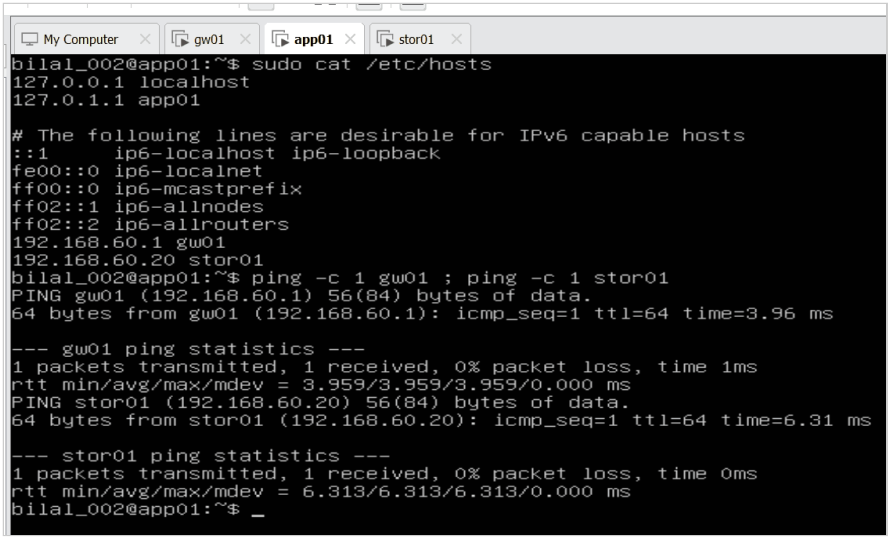


Figure 31 – app01: gw01 and stor01 by name, both reply.

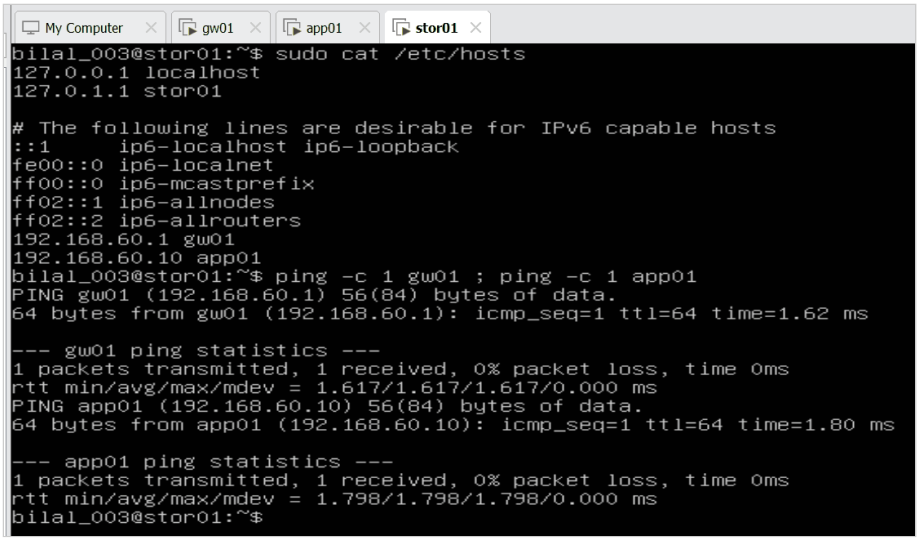


Figure 32 – stor01: gw01 and app01 by name, both reply.

Step 1.4 is complete. It also showed the weakness of `/etc/hosts`: the same list had to be typed by hand on three machines, with two typos along the way. That is exactly why companies use a central DNS server – or automation such as Ansible (Phase 7A).

Chapter 7 – Problems I met and how I solved them

#	What happened	Why	How I solved it
1	`systemctl get default` failed	Typo – the command is `get-default`	Retyped
2	Unsure whether `>> tee file` saves output	>> writes to a file; a pipe sends output to a program	Pipe into `tee file` (screen + file), or `>> file` (file only)
3	The netplan file in the guide did not exist	Ubuntu names it `50-cloud-init.yaml`	Checked with `ls`, used the real file
4	Pasted YAML arrived scrambled	Different keyboard layout in the VM; vim auto-indent	Quit without saving, typed by hand in nano
5	Warning “Cannot call Open vSwitch”	netplan checks for software that is not installed	Harmless – ignored
6	app01 still had its own internet address	Virtual cable still plugged in	Unplugged in VMware settings, rebooted
7	cloud-init line started with # on app01	Typing slip – # makes it a comment	Rewrote the file, verified with `cat`
8	stor01 had no data disks	Never added at VM creation	Added 2 × 5 GB disks
9	`curl ifconfig` printed nothing	Incomplete name; `-s` hides errors	Used `ifconfig.me`
11	Typos in `/etc/hosts`: `.200` for stor01 on gw01, `.20` for app01 on stor01	Typing slips; the first matching line wins	Checked with `cat` and `getent`, corrected in nano
12	stor01 flooded the console with `EXT4-fs error … Detected aborted journal` and `Remounting filesystem read-only`	The virtual disk was interrupted on the Windows side (host disk space, sleep or a forced stop); Linux switched the filesystem to read-only to protect the data	Restarted the VM from VMware; the filesystem recovered and became writable again (verified by editing `/etc/hosts`)
10	SSH from Windows to gw01 timed out, although SSH was running	Not needed for the design – admin access comes through a VPN later	Deferred; worked in the VMware console

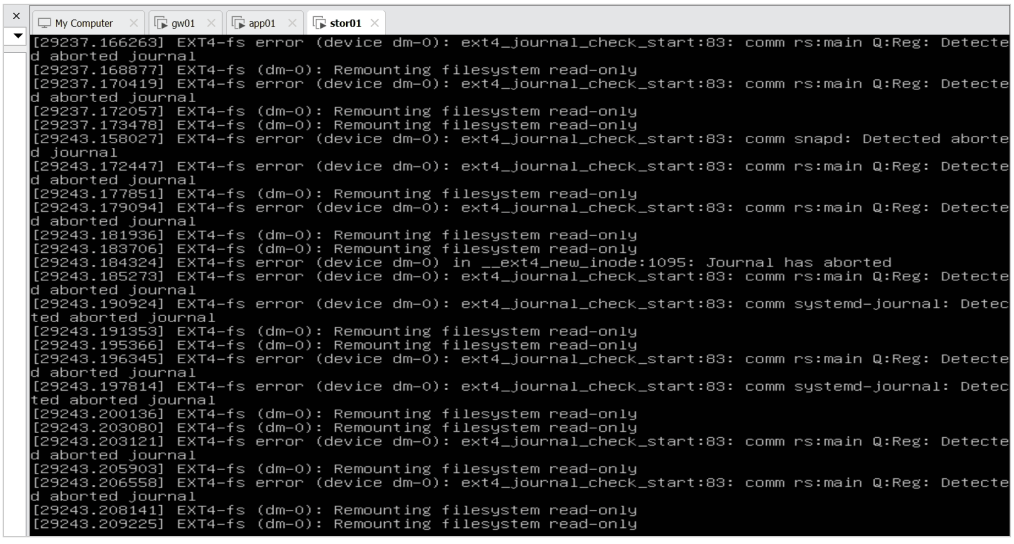


Figure 33 – Problem 12: stor01’s system disk hit errors and Linux switched it to read-only to protect the data.

Chapter 8 – Where we stand at the end of Day 1

Goal	Status
Baseline of gw01 recorded (kernel, memory, boot)	Done
gw01 in server mode	Done (app01, stor01 to follow)
Fixed addresses on all three servers, surviving reboot	Done
app01 and stor01 without their own internet line	Done
gw01 routes and translates (IP forwarding + NAT)	Done – 34 packets translated
Only replies allowed back into the lab	Rule in place; strict enforcement (DROP policy) in Phase 6
Servers find each other by name	Done – all three, by name
Data disks ready for storage	Done (sdb, sdc)

The journey in one picture:

```
Morning:   3 separate machines, each with its own internet line, lab network unused
             |
Step 1.1:  fixed addresses  ->  gw01 .1   app01 .10   stor01 .20
           internet cables of app01 and stor01 unplugged
             |
Step 1.2:  gw01 becomes a router (ip_forward 0 -> 1)
             |
Step 1.3:  gw01 translates addresses (NAT) and lets only replies back in
             |
Step 1.4:  servers find each other by name
             |
Evening:   one controlled door to the internet - gw01
```

How I would explain it in an interview: *"I built the network foundation of a three-server Linux lab: static addressing with netplan, internal servers with no direct internet access, and a Linux gateway doing NAT with stateful forwarding, so all outbound traffic passes one controlled point. I verified every change after reboot and documented ten issues with their root causes."*

Next steps: Step 1.5 (ports – which programs listen on which "door") and Step 1.6 (SSH key login from gw01 to the other servers, the basis for automation later).

Chapter 9 – Key understanding (in my own words)

These are the conclusions I reached by questioning each step until it made sense. They are written so I can explain them in an interview.

1. The network file and cloud-init

- `/etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml` is the main network settings file: IP address, gateway and DNS. It was written once by **cloud-init** when Ubuntu was installed. At every boot **netplan reads it** and configures the network cards.
- cloud-init is the **writer**, netplan is the **reader**. cloud-init could rewrite the file on a later boot and erase my settings.
- So I created `/etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg` with `network: {config: disabled}`. This only stops **cloud-init from managing the network** – the network itself and netplan keep working.
- Files in a `.d` folder are read in alphabetical order and **the last one wins**, so a `99-` file has the final word. The numbers only matter between files in the **same folder** – 50 (netplan) and 99 (cloud-init) are never compared.
- In Proxmox or the cloud, cloud-init is used the other way round: the admin enters IP, user and SSH key in the hypervisor, and cloud-init writes them into the server at first boot – ideal for cloned templates. In my VMware lab nothing feeds cloud-init, so I configure netplan by hand and keep cloud-init away from the network.

2. What the network file says

- `addresses: [192.168.60.10/24]` – **I am** 192.168.60.10; `/24` means 192.168.60.0–255 are my direct neighbours.
- `routes: - to: default via: 192.168.60.1` – "default" is not a machine, it means **everything I don't know**; `via` names who to hand it to: gw01.
- `nameservers: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]` – the internet's phone books. A name is first looked up in `/etc/hosts` (my own contact list – that is how `stor01` is found), and only then asked from DNS (that is how `google.com` is found).
- netplan only sets **addresses, gateway and DNS**. Being a router (ip_forward), NAT and firewall (iptables) and VPN (WireGuard) are set elsewhere.

3. The path to the internet

> app01 is 192.168.60.10 and has no internet adapter. For anything outside the lab it goes via gw01 (192.168.60.1), its default gateway. gw01 translates app01's private address into its own (NAT) and passes the traffic on through VMware and the home router to the internet. stor01 works the same way with 192.168.60.20.

4. NAT, forwarding and conntrack

> NAT recognises lab traffic by its IP range (`-s 192.168.60.0/24`) and changes the sender address as it leaves via `-o ens33`. Forwarding decides who may pass using the cards (`-i ens34 -o ens33`). Replies are let back in only if conntrack – gw01's memory of every conversation – confirms they are ESTABLISHED or RELATED to a conversation the lab started. conntrack also remembers which lab machine asked, so NAT can return each reply to the right one.

- **Two jobs, two tables:** the NAT table *changes the address* (`-j MASQUERADE`); the filter table's FORWARD chain *gives permission* (`-j ACCEPT`). A packet is checked by FORWARD first and rewritten in POSTROUTING just before it leaves – whatever order the commands were typed in.
- **`-s`/`-d` take IP addresses, `-i`/`-o` take card names.** `-s ens34` is always wrong. In POSTROUTING only the exit card is known, so `-i` is not allowed there – the lab must be identified by its IP range.
- **States:** NEW = someone starts a conversation; ESTABLISHED = a reply in a conversation the lab started; RELATED = a helper message (e.g. an error) belonging to it. `sudo conntrack -L` on gw01 shows the live list.
- **Honest limit today:** Ubuntu's default FORWARD policy is still ACCEPT, so the "only replies come back" rule is not yet enforced strictly. Right now the lab is protected because its private addresses sit behind two layers of NAT and cannot be reached from the internet. The strict version comes in Phase 6, when the default policy becomes DROP.
- `netfilter-persistent save` must run **last** – it saves only the rules that exist at that moment.

5. Names: /etc/hosts, DNS, getent and ping

> **getent** ("get entries") is like searching the phone book. It looks up a name or IP first in `/etc/hosts`, then in **DNS** if one is configured. It works both ways: name → IP (forward lookup) and IP → name (reverse lookup, e.g. `getent hosts 192.168.60.20` → `stor01`). It only **reads** – it never contacts the machine.
>
> **ping** is like calling. It uses the **same lookup** (`/etc/hosts`, then DNS) to find the number, then really contacts the machine with **ICMP** messages – "are you there?" (echo request) and "yes, I'm here" (echo reply). ICMP has **no ports**. So getent can succeed while ping fails – if the machine is off, the network is broken, or a **firewall blocks ICMP**.
>
> In our lab there is no internal DNS server, so we put the names in `/etc/hosts`. The servers could already reach each other **by IP**; `/etc/hosts` lets them reach each other **by name**.

- **Phone picture:** the contacts app inside the phone = the system resolver (`/etc/hosts` → DNS); getent = opening the contacts and reading a number; ping = pressing *call* – it looks up the same contact, then dials; ICMP = the phone network that carries the call.
- **Troubleshooting rule:** getent fails → a **name** problem (missing/wrong entry or DNS). getent works but ping fails → a **network** problem (machine off, cabling, firewall).
- `/etc/hosts` is a file on **each** machine – fine for a small lab, but 100 servers means 100 files to edit. Companies use an **internal DNS server** for their own names (as the Windows Server does in Project 1) and **public DNS** (1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8) for internet names.
- **The DNS helper and loopback:** on Ubuntu, programs do not ask 1.1.1.1 directly – they ask a small helper on the same machine, **systemd-resolved**, at **127.0.0.53**. Every **127.x.x.x** address is **loopback** – the machine talking to itself, like putting a note in your own pocket: the traffic never leaves the machine (`lo` in `ip -br a`). The helper answers from its **DNS cache** – short-term memory of name lookups for the whole machine – or asks the real DNS servers through gw01. The cache speeds things up, expires by itself (**TTL**), and can be cleared with `sudo resolvectl flush-caches`. `resolvectl status` shows which DNS servers are in use.
- **DNS troubleshooting in three commands:** `getent hosts <name>` (does the name resolve at all?) → `resolvectl status` (which DNS servers?) → `dig +short <name>` (does DNS itself answer? dig skips `/etc/hosts`).
- `hostname` shows the machine's own name; `getent hosts <name>` asks what address a name has; `tee -a /etc/hosts` appends a new entry.

Glossary

Word	Meaning
Virtual machine (VM)	A computer simulated by software inside a real computer
Kernel	The engine of Linux that talks to the hardware
Module / driver	Add-on that lets the kernel use specific hardware
systemd / target	The manager that starts services / the start-up mode (desktop or server)
IP address	A machine's "phone number" on a network
Private address	Valid only inside a home or company network (e.g. 192.168.x.x)
/24	Network size: 256 addresses sharing the first three number blocks
Network card (ens33, ens34)	The socket a network cable plugs into; `lo` = the machine talking to itself
netplan / YAML	Ubuntu's network settings / the file format where indentation matters
cloud-init	Helper that sets up a new server and may overwrite manual settings
Default route / gateway	"Where to send traffic for unknown destinations" – here gw01
IP forwarding	The switch that lets Linux act as a router
NAT / MASQUERADE	Replacing private sender addresses with the gateway's own address
Firewall / iptables	Rules that decide which traffic may pass
TTL	Counter in each packet, lowered by 1 at every router
DNS	The internet's phone book: names to numbers
/etc/hosts	A machine's personal contact list, checked before DNS
getent	Asks the system what a name resolves to
lsblk / sda, sdb, sdc	Lists disks / the system disk and two data disks
SSH	Secure remote login to a server's command line

Day 1 (part 1) – 2026-10-13: Lab setup and Phase 0 (system baseline)

Project	Acme Analytics – hardened, observable and recoverable Linux platform
Phase	0 – System baseline
Hosts worked on	gw01 (app01 and stor01 prepared)
Status	Phase 0 complete on gw01 · app01 and stor01: boot target still to set
Author	Muhammad Bilal Javed

> **How to read this report.** Every step has three layers: 💡 **In plain words** – the idea, for any reader, no Linux knowledge needed. 🔧 **Technical** – the exact commands (with a comment on every line) and what they do. 📸 **Evidence** – the real screenshot of the output from my lab. Unfamiliar words are explained in the glossary.

---

1. Objective

💡 **In plain words:** before a mechanic repairs a car, they write down its condition: mileage, oil level, warning lights. Then, if something goes wrong later, they can compare against "how it was before". This phase does the same for a server: **write down how it looks before I change anything.**

🔧 **Technical:** record a **baseline** of the gateway server gw01: kernel version, loaded drivers, memory, IP forwarding state, boot time and boot target. The baseline is the reference point for every later change, for troubleshooting ("what was it like before?") and for audits.

2. The lab environment

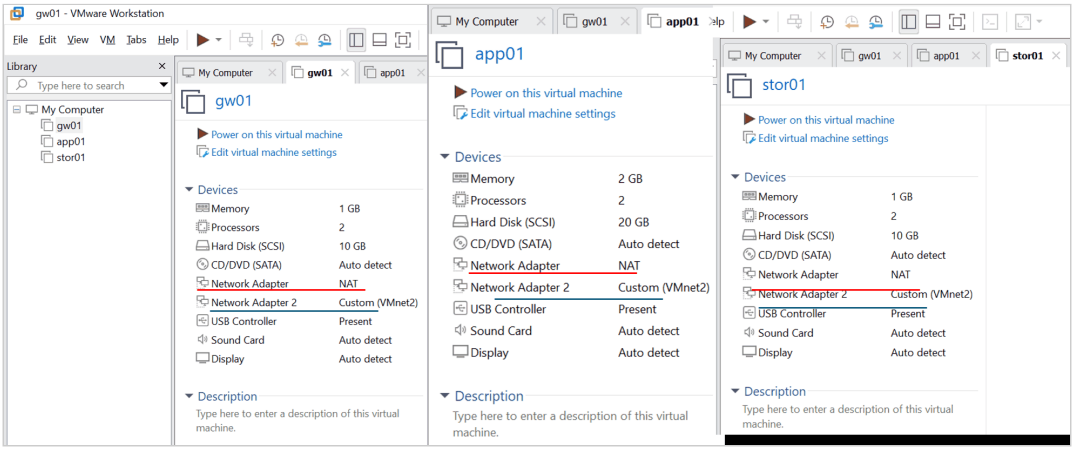
💡 **In plain words:** instead of buying real servers, I run three "computers inside my computer" (virtual machines) with VMware. Each has its own job, like employees in a small company:

- **gw01** – the *gatekeeper*. The only machine allowed to talk to the internet. Everything in and out passes through it.
- **app01** – the *shop window*. Runs the company's web application.
- **stor01** – the *archive room*. Stores files, backups and logs.

Item	Value
Hypervisor (software that runs the virtual machines)	VMware Workstation on Windows
Lab network	VMnet2, isolated custom switch, 192.168.60.0/24, no DHCP, no host adapter
Operating system	Ubuntu Server 22.04 LTS
Kernel	5.15.0-198-generic (#208-Ubuntu SMP, built 4 Sep 2026)

VM	Role	vCPU	RAM	Disks	Network adapters
gw01	Gateway: NAT, firewall, VPN	2	1.9 GiB visible to the OS	10 GB	NAT (internet) + VMnet2 (lab)
app01	Application server	2	2 GB (3 GB planned before monitoring phase)	20 GB	VMnet2 only (NAT adapter disconnected, see part 2)
stor01	Storage and log server	2	1 GB	10 GB + 2 × 5 GB (for LVM)	VMnet2 only (NAT adapter disconnected, see part 2)

📸 **VM hardware as created in VMware** (Network Adapter = NAT, Network Adapter 2 = VMnet2 lab network):



VM hardware of gw01, app01 and stor01

Design decision: only gw01 keeps an internet-facing adapter. app01 and stor01 reach the internet exclusively through gw01 (built in part 2). This makes gw01 the single controlled entry and exit point, so NAT, firewall and VPN controls can be enforced and tested in one place.

---

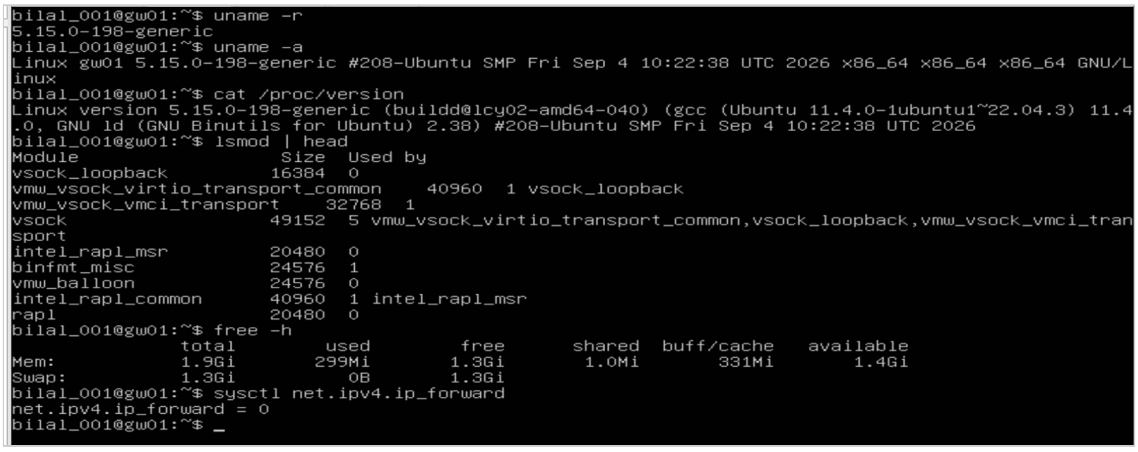
3. Step 0.1 – Kernel, drivers and memory

💡 **In plain words:** the **kernel** is the "engine" of Linux – the core program that talks to the hardware. **Drivers (modules)** are small add-ons that let the engine use specific hardware. Here I check *which engine version* the server runs, *which add-ons are loaded* and *how much memory it has*. I also check one important switch: whether this machine is allowed to pass traffic between networks (like a router) – right now it is not.

🔧 **Commands (run on gw01):**

```
uname -r                    # print only the kernel version
uname -a                    # print everything: hostname, kernel, build date, CPU architecture
cat /proc/version           # the kernel's own description: compiler and build details
lsmod | head                # list loaded kernel modules (drivers); "| head" shows only the first 10 lines
free -h                     # memory and swap usage, "-h" = human-readable (GiB/MiB)
sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward  # read the kernel setting that decides whether this host routes packets
```

📸 **Evidence:**



Kernel, modules, memory and ip_forward on gw01

Check	Result	What it means
Kernel version	`5.15.0-198-generic`	Ubuntu 22.04 standard kernel; noted so future updates can be tracked
Build info	gcc 11.4.0, binutils 2.38	Standard Ubuntu build, nothing custom
Loaded modules	`vmw_vsock_*`, `vmw_balloon`, `vsock`, `intel_rapl_*`	VMware guest drivers are loaded – the OS knows it runs as a VM. `vmw_balloon` lets VMware take back unused memory
Memory	1.9 GiB total, 299 MiB used, 1.4 GiB available; swap 1.3 GiB, 0 used	Plenty of headroom for a gateway
IP forwarding	`net.ipv4.ip_forward = 0`	**gw01 does not route packets yet** – it behaves like a normal PC. Phase 1 switches this to 1

---

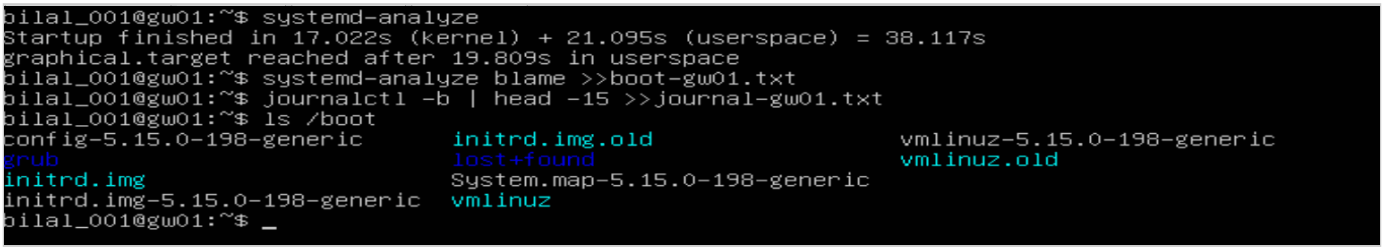
4. Step 0.2 – Boot process

💡 **In plain words:** starting a computer is a relay race – each runner hands over to the next: the **firmware** wakes the hardware → the **bootloader (GRUB)** picks and loads the engine → the **kernel** starts → **systemd**, the "manager", starts all the services (network, SSH, ...) → you get a login. Here I measure **how long the race takes** and save the details as evidence.

🔧 **Commands (run on gw01):**

```
systemd-analyze                              # total boot time, split into kernel and userspace
systemd-analyze blame >> boot-gw01.txt       # time per service, appended (>>) to a file as evidence
journalctl -b | head -15 >> journal-gw01.txt # first 15 log lines of this boot (-b), appended to a file
ls /boot                                     # files the bootloader uses to start Linux
```

📸 **Evidence:**



systemd-analyze and /boot contents on gw01

Check	Result
Total boot time	**38.117 s** = 17.022 s kernel + 21.095 s userspace (services)
Default target reached	`graphical.target` after 19.809 s in userspace
`/boot` contents	`vmlinuz-5.15.0-198-generic` (the kernel), `initrd.img-5.15.0-198-generic` (initial RAM disk – a mini system that helps the kernel find the real disk), `vmlinuz.old` / `initrd.img.old` (**previous kernel kept as a fallback** if an update fails), `grub/` (bootloader), `config-*` and `System.map-*` (kernel build settings and symbol map)

Boot chain: firmware (BIOS/UEFI) → GRUB bootloader → Linux kernel → initramfs → systemd (PID 1) → services → login.

---

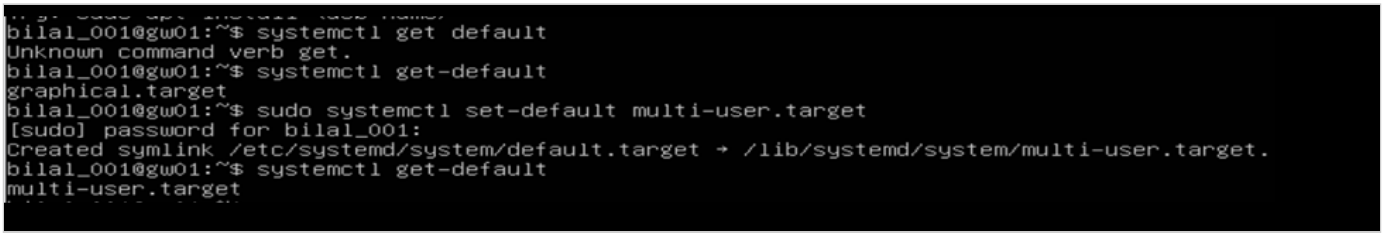
5. Step 0.3 – Boot target (desktop mode vs server mode)

💡 **In plain words:** Linux can start in different "modes", called **targets**. `graphical.target` starts a desktop with windows and mouse – useful for a laptop, wasted on a server nobody sits in front of. `multi-user.target` starts everything a server needs (network, services, logins) **without** the desktop. Less software running = faster start, less memory used and fewer things an attacker could abuse.

🔧 **Commands (run on gw01):**

```
systemctl get-default                          # which target the system boots into now
sudo systemctl set-default multi-user.target   # change it to server mode (needs admin rights: sudo)
systemctl get-default                          # check that the change took effect
```

📸 **Evidence** (including my first typo, see issues):



Changing the default boot target on gw01

Before	After
`graphical.target`	`multi-user.target`

systemd confirmed the change by creating the link `/etc/systemd/system/default.target → /lib/systemd/system/multi-user.target`.

Old "runlevel" (classic Linux)	systemd target today
0	poweroff.target
1	rescue.target (repair mode)
3	multi-user.target (server)
5	graphical.target (desktop)
6	reboot.target

---

6. Issues encountered

#	Symptom	Cause	Resolution
1	`systemctl get default` → `Unknown command verb get.`	Typo: the command is `get-default`, one word with a hyphen	Re-ran as `systemctl get-default`
2	Unsure whether `>> tee file` saves output	`>>` sends output to a **file**; `|` (pipe) sends it to a **program**. `>> tee` would create a file literally named `tee`	Use `command | tee file` (show on screen **and** save) or `command >> file` (append to file only)

7. Lessons learned

- A baseline captured **before** changes makes later troubleshooting faster and provable.
- `ip_forward` is the single kernel setting that decides whether a Linux host routes traffic.
- Servers should boot into `multi-user.target`; the previous kernel in `/boot` is the safety net if an update fails.
- Saving command output to files turns “I did it” into evidence for documentation and audits.

8. Next steps

1. Set `multi-user.target` on app01 and stor01; take snapshot `10-baseline` of all VMs.
2. **Phase 1 – Network foundation** → continued in Day 1, part 2.

Day 1 (part 2) – 2026-10-13: Phase 1, network foundation

Project	Acme Analytics – hardened, observable and recoverable Linux platform
Phase	1 – Network foundation: Steps 1.1–1.4
Hosts worked on	gw01, app01, stor01
Status	1.1 static IPs ✅ · 1.2 routing ✅ · 1.3 NAT ✅ · 1.4 name resolution ✅
Author	Muhammad Bilal Javed

> **How to read this report.** Every step has three layers: 💡 **In plain words** – the idea, for any reader. 🔧 **Technical** – the exact commands, with a comment on every line. 📸 **Evidence** – the real screenshot from my lab. Unfamiliar words are explained in the glossary.

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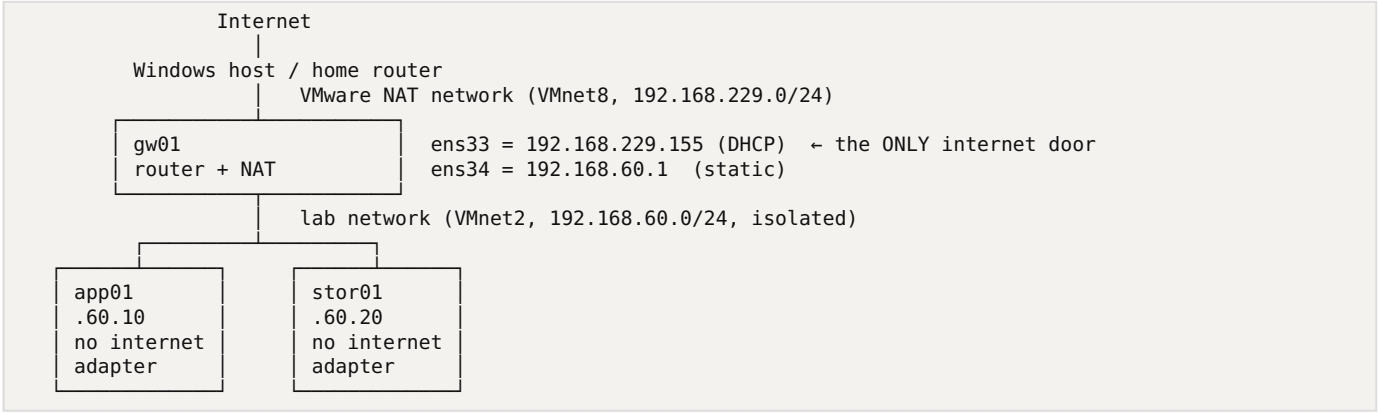
1. Objective

💡 **In plain words:** at the end of Phase 0 the three servers were like three new employees with no desk phones: they could not reliably reach each other, and two of them had their own uncontrolled line to the outside world. In this phase I:

1. give every server a **fixed address** (like a permanent desk-phone number),
2. **cut the private internet lines** of app01 and stor01,
3. turn gw01 into the **company switchboard** – the one and only way out to the internet,
4. teach the servers to find each other **by name** instead of by number.

🔧 **Technical:** static IPv4 addressing with netplan, IP forwarding and source NAT (MASQUERADE) with stateful forwarding on gw01, and name resolution via `/etc/hosts` and DNS.

2. Target network design



Host	External card (ens33)	Lab card (ens34)	Way to the internet (“default gateway”)
gw01	DHCP, 192.168.229.155	192.168.60.1/24	VMware NAT, directly
app01	disconnected	192.168.60.10/24	through gw01 (192.168.60.1)
stor01	disconnected	192.168.60.20/24	through gw01 (192.168.60.1)

💡 **Why this design?** One door is easier to guard than three. All firewall rules, logs and later the VPN live on gw01. The internet can never start a connection to app01 or stor01 directly.

---

3. Step 1.1 – Fixed (static) addresses with netplan

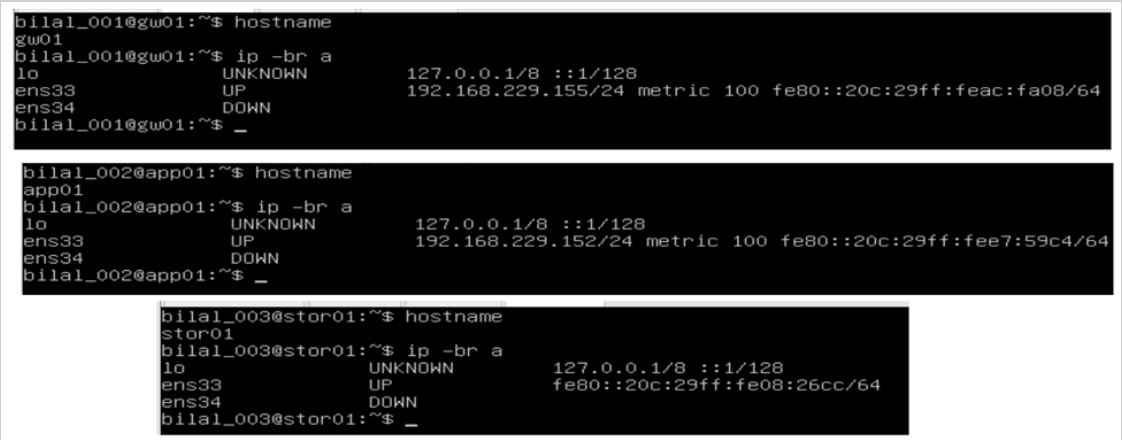
3.1 Look before you change: which network cards exist?

💡 **In plain words:** each VM has two “network sockets” (cards). Before configuring them I check their names and current addresses.

🔧 **Commands:**

```
hostname          # confirm which machine I am on
ip -br a          # list all network cards, brief (-br) form: name, state, address
```

📸 **Evidence – starting point on all three VMs:**



Network cards before configuration

Card	Meaning
lo	loopback – the machine talking to itself (127.0.0.1). Always present
ens33	1st card = VMware NAT network. gw01 and app01 had internet addresses (192.168.229.x) from VMware's DHCP
ens34	2nd card = lab network (VMnet2). **DOWN with no address** – nothing configured yet

3.2 Find the configuration file and make a backup

💡 **In plain words:** on Ubuntu, network settings live in a small text file in the folder `/etc/netplan/`. Before editing any config file, I make a copy – so I can always go back.

🔧 **Commands:**

```
ls /etc/netplan                                          # which netplan file exists?
sudo cp /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml ~/netplan-backup.yaml # backup copy into my home folder
```

📸 **Evidence:** the file is called `50-cloud-init.yaml`, not `00-installer-config.yaml` as my guide assumed (issue 1):



Netplan filename on app01

3.3 Stop cloud-init from overwriting my settings

💡 **In plain words:** `cloud-init` is a helper program that sets up the network automatically at first boot – and it may **rewrite my file** on a later boot, silently undoing my work. I leave it a note saying "network: hands off".

🔧 **Command:**

```
# write the line "network: {config: disabled}" into a new cloud-init config file
# (tee writes to the file AND shows the line on screen so I can check it)
echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg
```

📸 **Evidence – gw01: backup, current file, cloud-init disabled:**



Backup and cloud-init disable on gw01

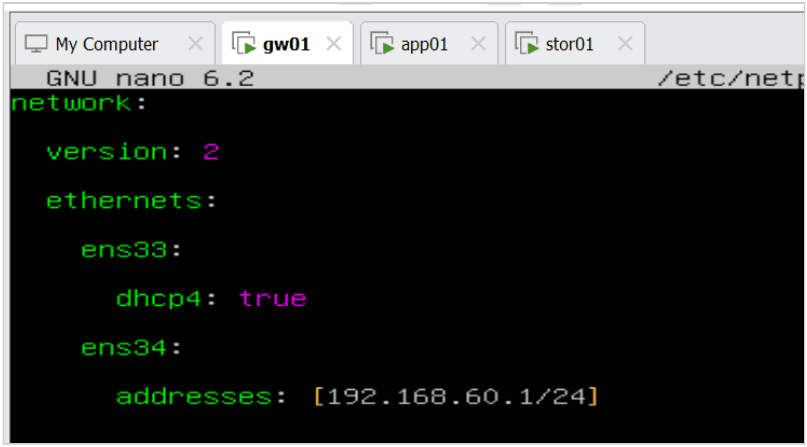
3.4 Write the new network settings

💡 **In plain words:** the netplan file is written in **YAML**, a format where **indentation (spaces) is part of the meaning** – like an outline where sub-points must be indented under their heading. One wrong space and the file is invalid.

🔧 **gw01** (`sudo nano /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml`):

```
network:
  version: 2
  ethernets:
    ens33:                          # card 1: internet side
      dhcp4: true                   #   get its address automatically from VMware
    ens34:                          # card 2: lab side
      addresses: [192.168.60.1/24] #   fixed address; no gateway — gw01 IS the gateway
```

📸 **Evidence – typed by hand in nano on gw01:**



gw01 netplan file in nano

🔧 **app01** (stor01 identical, with `192.168.60.20/24`):

```
network:
  version: 2
  ethernets:
    ens34:                          # only the lab card is configured
      addresses: [192.168.60.10/24] # fixed address; "/24" = network size (192.168.60.0–255)
      routes:
        - to: default               # for every destination I don't know …
          via: 192.168.60.1         # … send it to gw01 (the "default gateway")
      nameservers:
        addresses: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]  # public DNS servers: translate names like google.com into IPs
```

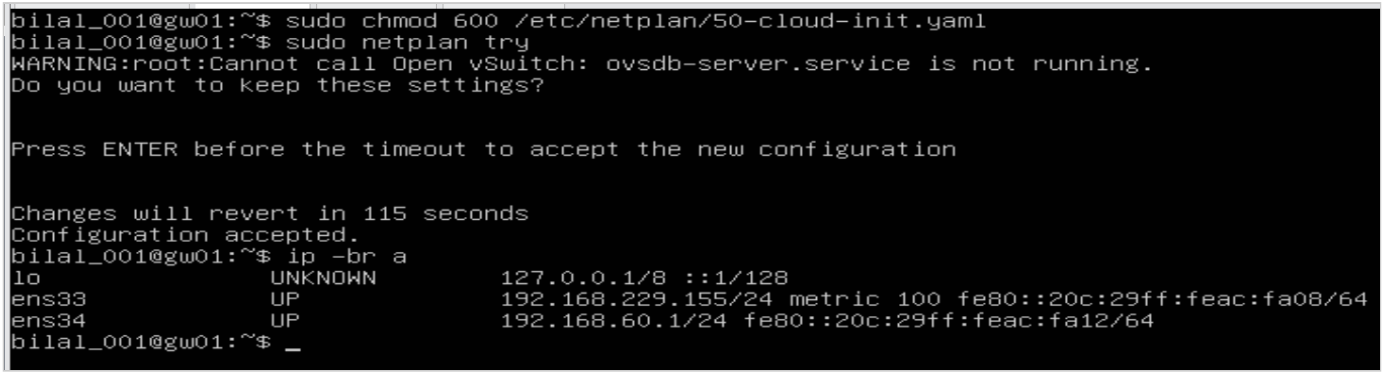
3.5 Apply safely – with an automatic “undo”

💡 **In plain words:** changing network settings on a server is like changing the lock on the only door while you are inside: if it goes wrong, you may lock yourself out. `netplan try` applies the change but **automatically undoes it after 120 seconds** unless I press Enter to confirm. If I can still type, the change works – I press Enter.

🔧 **Commands:**

```
sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml  # only root may read/write the file (netplan warns otherwise)
sudo netplan try                                # apply with auto-rollback; press ENTER to keep
ip -br a                                        # check the new addresses
```

📸 **Evidence – gw01:** ens34 now has `192.168.60.1/24`. The Open vSwitch warning is harmless (issue 4):



netplan try on gw01

📸 **Evidence – app01:** file content and `netplan try`:

```
50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo cp /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml ~/netplan-backup.yaml
bilal_002@app01:~$ echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-n
etwork-config.cfg
#network: {config: disabled}
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo cat /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
network:

  version: 2

  ethernets:

    ens34:

      addresses: [192.168.60.10/24]

      routes:

        - to: default

          via: 192.168.60.1

      nameservers:

        addresses: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo netplan try
WARNING:root:Cannot call Open vSwitch: ovsdb-server.service is not running.
Do you want to keep these settings?


Press ENTER before the timeout to accept the new configuration


Changes will revert in 119 seconds
Configuration accepted
```

netplan try on app01

3.6 Problem found: app01 still had its own internet line

📸 After applying, app01 could reach gw01 – **but ens33 still had an internet address (192.168.229.152)**. That breaks the design: app01 must not have its own way out.

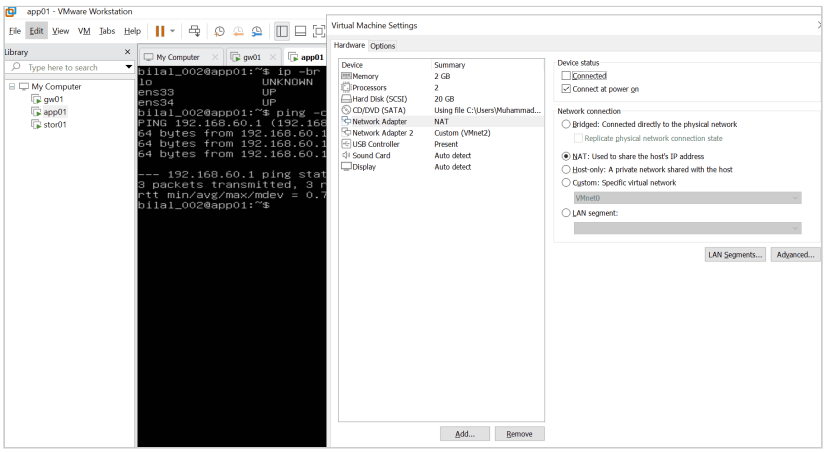
```
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            UP             192.168.229.152/24 metric 100 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59c4/64
ens34            UP             192.168.60.10/24 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59ce/64
bilal_002@app01:~$ ping -c 3 192.168.60.1
PING 192.168.60.1 (192.168.60.1) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=10.8 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=0.755 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=3 ttl=64 time=1.33 ms

--- 192.168.60.1 ping statistics ---
3 packets transmitted, 3 received, 0% packet loss, time 2035ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 0.755/4.287/10.779/4.596 ms
bilal_002@app01:~$
```

app01 still connected to the NAT network

💡 **In plain words:** turning off the setting inside Linux is not enough – the **virtual cable** was still plugged in. The real fix is to unplug it in VMware itself.

🔧 **Fix – VMware → VM → Settings → Network Adapter (NAT):** untick **Connected** and **Connect at power on**, then reboot.



Disconnecting app01's NAT adapter in VMware

3.7 Proof after reboot

💡 **In plain words:** a setting that disappears after a restart is worthless. I reboot and check that everything is still correct.

🔧 **Commands:**

```
sudo reboot        # restart the VM
ip -br a           # addresses after the restart
ip route           # the routing table: where traffic is sent
```

📸 **Evidence – app01 after reboot:**

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            DOWN
ens34            UP             192.168.60.10/24 fe80::20c:29ff:fee7:59ce/64
bilal_002@app01:~$ ip route
default via 192.168.60.1 dev ens34 proto static
192.168.60.0/24 dev ens34 proto kernel scope link src 192.168.60.10
bilal_002@app01:~$ _
```

app01 after reboot

Line	Meaning
`ens33 DOWN`	internet card unplugged ✅
`ens34 UP 192.168.60.10/24`	fixed lab address survived the reboot ✅
`default via 192.168.60.1 dev ens34`	“anything not local → send to gw01” ✅
`192.168.60.0/24 dev ens34 … src 192.168.60.10`	lab neighbours are reached directly on ens34 ✅

📸 Evidence – stor01: same method, file written and permissions set, internet adapter unplugged in VMware:

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ls /etc/netplan
50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo cp /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml ~/netplan-backup.yaml
bilal_003@stor01:~$ echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-
network-config.cfg
network: {config: disabled}
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo cat /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
network:

  version: 2

  ethernets:

    ens34:

      addresses: [192.168.60.20/24]

      routes:

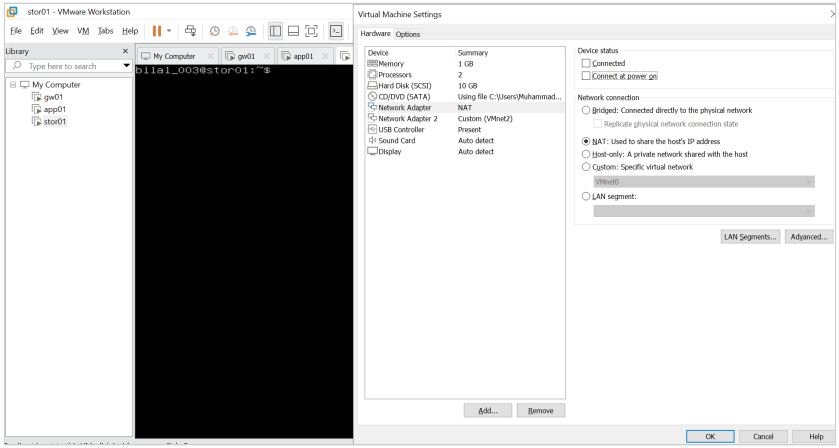
        - to: default

          via: 192.168.60.1

      nameservers:

        addresses: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]
bilal_003@stor01:~$ sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml
bilal_003@stor01:~$
```

stor01 netplan file



stor01 NAT adapter disconnected

📸 Evidence – stor01 after the same steps: ens33 DOWN, `192.168.60.20/24`, default via gw01, ping to gw01 3/3 received:

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ip -br a
lo               UNKNOWN        127.0.0.1/8 ::1/128
ens33            DOWN
ens34            UP             192.168.60.20/24 fe80::20c:29ff:fe08:26d6/64
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ip route
default via 192.168.60.1 dev ens34 proto static
192.168.60.0/24 dev ens34 proto kernel scope link src 192.168.60.20
bilal_003@stor01:~$ ping -c 3 192.168.60.1
PING 192.168.60.1 (192.168.60.1) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=5.36 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=2 ttl=64 time=4.76 ms
64 bytes from 192.168.60.1: icmp_seq=3 ttl=64 time=2.04 ms

--- 192.168.60.1 ping statistics ---
3 packets transmitted, 3 received, 0% packet loss, time 2003ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 2.039/4.050/5.357/1.443 ms
bilal_003@stor01:~$ lsblk
NAME                      MAJ:MIN RM   SIZE RO TYPE MOUNTPOINTS
loop0                       7:0    0  63.9M  1 loop /snap/core20/2318
loop1                       7:1    0    74M  1 loop /snap/core22/2955
loop2                       7:2    0  63.8M  1 loop /snap/core20/2922
loop3                       7:3    0    87M  1 loop /snap/lxd/29351
loop4                       7:4    0  38.8M  1 loop /snap/snapd/21759
loop5                       7:5    0 115.2M  1 loop /snap/lxd/40911
loop6                       7:6    0  44.7M  1 loop /snap/snapd/28254
sda                         8:0    0    10G  0 disk
├─sda1                      8:1    0     1M  0 part
├─sda2                      8:2    0   1.8G  0 part /boot
└─sda3                      8:3    0   8.2G  0 part
  └─ubuntu--vg-ubuntu--lv 253:0    0   8.2G  0 lvm  /
sr0                        11:0    1  1024M  0 rom
bilal_003@stor01:~$
```

stor01 network and disks

3.8 Problem found: stor01's data disks were missing

💡 **In plain words:** `lsblk` lists the disks of a machine. stor01 should have two extra empty 5 GB disks for the storage phase – but only the system disk `sda` was there. I powered it off, added two 5 GB disks in VMware, and checked again.

🔧 **Command:**

```
lsblk     # list block devices (disks and partitions)
```

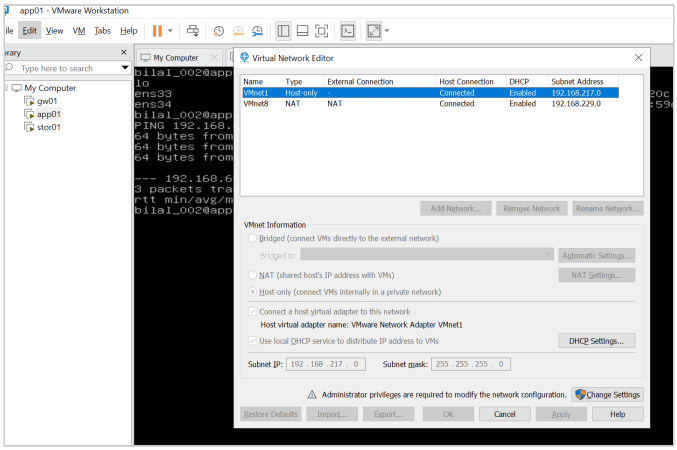
📸 **Evidence – after adding the disks:** `sdb` and `sdc`, 5 GB each, empty (no partitions), ready for Phase 2:

```
bilal_003@stor01:~$ lsblk
NAME                      MAJ:MIN RM   SIZE RO TYPE MOUNTPOINTS
loop0                       7:0    0  63.9M  1 loop /snap/core20/2318
loop1                       7:1    0  63.8M  1 loop /snap/core20/2922
loop2                       7:2    0    87M  1 loop /snap/lxd/29351
loop3                       7:3    0    74M  1 loop /snap/core22/2955
loop4                       7:4    0 115.2M  1 loop /snap/lxd/40911
loop5                       7:5    0  38.8M  1 loop /snap/snapd/21759
loop6                       7:6    0  44.7M  1 loop /snap/snapd/28254
sda                         8:0    0    10G  0 disk
├─sda1                      8:1    0     1M  0 part
├─sda2                      8:2    0   1.8G  0 part /boot
└─sda3                      8:3    0   8.2G  0 part
  └─ubuntu--vg-ubuntu--lv 253:0    0   8.2G  0 lvm  /
sdb                         8:16   0     5G  0 disk
sdc                         8:32   0     5G  0 disk
sr0                        11:0    1     2G  0 rom
bilal_003@stor01:~$ _
```

stor01 data disks sdb and sdc

3.9 Note: VMnet2 does not appear in the Virtual Network Editor

📸 The editor lists only VMnet1 and VMnet8:



VMware Virtual Network Editor

💡 **In plain words:** this is correct. VMnet2 is used as a **private switch** with no connection to Windows and no automatic address service. The lab is completely closed – only gw01 connects it to the outside.

---

4. Step 1.2 – Turn gw01 into a router (IP forwarding)

💡 **In plain words:** by default a Linux machine **refuses to pass on** traffic that is not meant for itself – like a receptionist who only takes calls for herself. Switching on **IP forwarding** turns gw01 into a switchboard that passes calls between the lab and the internet. In Phase 0 this was `0` (off).

🔧 **Commands (gw01):**

```
# save the setting in a config file so it survives reboots
echo "net.ipv4.ip_forward=1" | sudo tee /etc/sysctl.d/99-forward.conf
sudo sysctl --system            # load all sysctl config files now (no reboot needed)
sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward      # verify: must say 1
```

📸 **Evidence:** `net.ipv4.ip_forward = 1` (was `0` in the Phase 0 baseline):

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "net.ipv4.ip_forward=1" | sudo tee /etc/sysctl.d/99-forward.conf
net.ipv4.ip_forward=1
bilal_001@gw01:~$ sysctl net.ipv4.ip_forward
net.ipv4.ip_forward = 1
bilal_001@gw01:~$
```

IP forwarding enabled on gw01

---

5. Step 1.3 – NAT: share gw01's internet with the lab

💡 **In plain words:** addresses like 192.168.60.10 are **private** – the internet cannot send replies to them, just like a letter addressed to "Room 10" cannot be delivered without the building's street address. **NAT (Network Address Translation)** works like a company mailroom: when app01 sends something out, gw01 replaces the sender address with **its own** address; when the reply comes back, gw01 remembers who asked and hands it to app01.

The firewall rules decide **who may pass**: the lab may go out, and replies come back in. (Strictly blocking everything else needs a DROP default policy, which follows in Phase 6; today the lab is protected because its private addresses cannot be reached from the internet.)

🔧 **Commands (gw01):**

```
# NAT: traffic from the lab leaving via ens33 gets gw01's address as sender
sudo iptables -t nat -A POSTROUTING -o ens33 -s 192.168.60.0/24 -j MASQUERADE
# allow: lab (ens34) → internet (ens33)
sudo iptables -A FORWARD -i ens34 -o ens33 -j ACCEPT
# allow back in ONLY replies to connections the lab started
sudo iptables -A FORWARD -i ens33 -o ens34 -m state --state ESTABLISHED,RELATED -j ACCEPT
# make the rules survive a reboot
sudo apt install -y iptables-persistent
sudo netfilter-persistent save
```

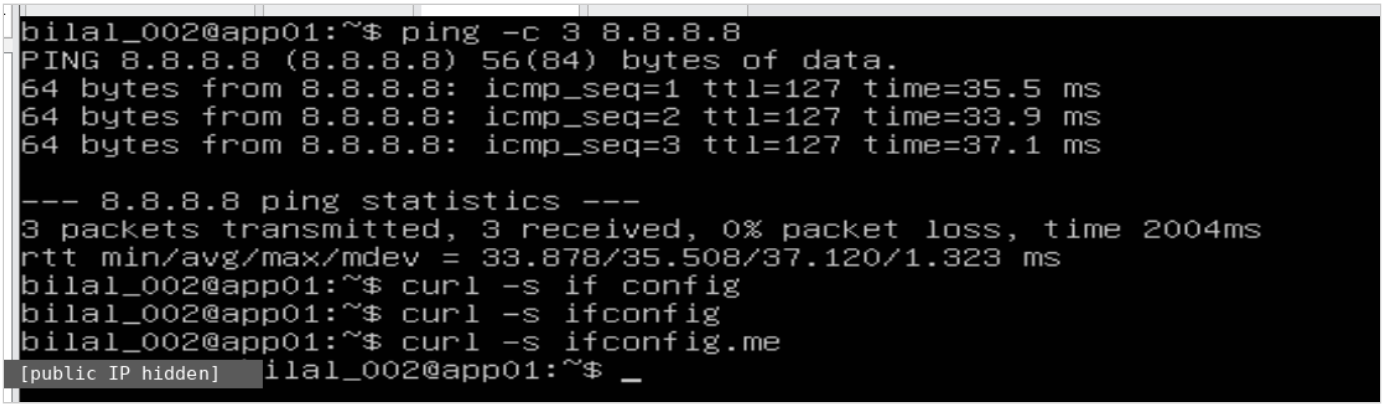
Rule	Plain words	Technical
`MASQUERADE`	"write my return address on outgoing mail"	Source NAT to the current address of ens33; chosen over SNAT because ens33 gets its address via DHCP and may change
`FORWARD ens34 → ens33 ACCEPT`	"staff may make outgoing calls"	Allows new outbound connections from the lab
`FORWARD ens33 → ens34 ESTABLISHED,RELATED`	"only call-backs are put through"	Stateful rule: inbound traffic allowed only if it belongs to a connection the lab started

Test from app01 (which has no internet card of its own)

🔧 **Commands (app01):**

```
ping -c 3 8.8.8.8      # can I reach a server on the internet? (-c 3 = send 3 packets)
curl -s ifconfig.me    # ask a website: "which address do you see me coming from?"
```

📸 **Evidence** (my home public IP is hidden for privacy):



app01 reaches the internet through gw01

Test	Result	What it proves
`ping 8.8.8.8`	✅ 3/3 received, 0 % loss, avg 35.5 ms	app01 reaches the internet – **only possible through gw01**
`curl ifconfig.me`	✅ shows the home network's public address, **not** 192.168.60.10	NAT replaced app01's private address
TTL 127 (instead of 128)	each router lowers TTL by 1	the packets passed through one extra router: gw01

🔧 **Proof on gw01's side** – the NAT rule's packet counter:

```
sudo iptables -t nat -L -n -v --line-numbers   # list NAT rules with packet/byte counters
```

📸 **Evidence:** the MASQUERADE rule translated **34 packets (2443 bytes)** from 192.168.60.0/24 out through ens33 ("Sorry, try again" = mistyped sudo password):

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ sudo iptables -t nat -L -n -v --line-numbers
[sudo] password for bilal_001:
Sorry, try again.
[sudo] password for bilal_001:
Sorry, try again.
[sudo] password for bilal_001:
Chain PREROUTING (policy ACCEPT 0 packets, 0 bytes)
num   pkts bytes target     prot opt in     out     source               destination

Chain INPUT (policy ACCEPT 0 packets, 0 bytes)
num   pkts bytes target     prot opt in     out     source               destination

Chain OUTPUT (policy ACCEPT 0 packets, 0 bytes)
num   pkts bytes target     prot opt in     out     source               destination

Chain POSTROUTING (policy ACCEPT 0 packets, 0 bytes)
num   pkts bytes target     prot opt in     out     source               destination
1       34  2443 MASQUERADE  all  --  *      ens33   192.168.60.0/24      0.0.0.0/0
bilal_001@gw01:~$ _
```

NAT counters on gw01

Note: `curl` prints the address without a line break, so the prompt appears glued to it (…`bilal_002@app01`). `curl -s ifconfig.me; echo` adds the line break.

---

6. Step 1.4 – Names instead of numbers (`/etc/hosts` and DNS)

💡 **In plain words:** computers only connect to **numbers** (IP addresses), but people – and tools like SSH, Ansible or file shares – prefer **names** like `stor01`. Before connecting, Linux has to look the name up, like a phone looking up a contact before dialing. It looks in two places, in this order:

1. **`/etc/hosts`** – a small **personal contact list** on each machine. Checked **first**.
2. **DNS** – the **public phone book** of the internet. Used only if the name is not in the contact list.

`getent` (= "get entry") asks the system exactly that question: *"what is the address for this name?"*

🔧 **Commands (app01):**

```
        getent hosts stor01                                  # look up "stor01" → nothing yet (unknown name)
        echo "192.168.60.20 stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts  # add stor01 to app01's contact list (-a = append, don't
overwrite)
        getent hosts stor01                                  # look up again → now 192.168.60.20
        ping -c 1 stor01                                     # use the NAME to reach the server
```

📸 **Evidence:** first lookup empty → entry added → lookup answers → ping by name works (`pinc` was a typo):

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ getent hosts stor01
bilal_002@app01:~$ echo "192.168.60.20 stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
[sudo] password for bilal_002:
192.168.60.20 stor01
bilal_002@app01:~$ getent hosts stor01
192.168.60.20   stor01
bilal_002@app01:~$ pinc -c 1 stor01
Command 'pinc' not found, did you mean:
  command 'ping' from deb iputils-ping (3:20211215-1ubuntu0.1)
  command 'ping' from deb inetutils-ping (2:2.2-2ubuntu0.2)
  command 'inc' from deb mailutils-mh (1:3.14-1)
  command 'inc' from deb mmh (0.4-4)
  command 'inc' from deb nmh (1.7.1-11)
  command 'minc' from deb mblaze (1.1-1)
  command 'pic' from deb groff-base (1.22.4-8build1)
Try: sudo apt install <deb name>
bilal_002@app01:~$ ping -c 1 stor01
PING stor01 (192.168.60.20) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from stor01 (192.168.60.20): icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=5.30 ms

--- stor01 ping statistics ---
1 packets transmitted, 1 received, 0% packet loss, time 0ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 5.296/5.296/5.296/0.000 ms
bilal_002@app01:~$ _
```

getent and ping by name on app01

🔧 **Commands (app01) – lookup order and DNS:**

```
        grep '^hosts' /etc/nsswitch.conf   # show the lookup ORDER for host names
        resolvectl status | head -5        # show the DNS resolver status
        sudo apt install -y dnsutils       # install dig (was already installed)
        dig +short google.com              # ask DNS directly for google.com's addresses
```

📸 **Evidence:**

```
bilal_002@app01:~$ grep '^hosts' /etc/nsswitch.conf
hosts:          files dns
bilal_002@app01:~$ resolvectl status | head -5
Global
       Protocols: -LLMNR -mDNS -DNSOverTLS DNSSEC=no/unsupported
resolv.conf mode: stub

Link 2 (ens33)
bilal_002@app01:~$ sudo apt install -y dnsutils
Reading package lists... Done
Building dependency tree... Done
Reading state information... Done
dnsutils is already the newest version (1:9.18.39-0ubuntu0.22.04.6).
0 upgraded, 0 newly installed, 0 to remove and 66 not upgraded.
bilal_002@app01:~$ dig +short google.com
142.251.110.100
142.251.110.102
142.251.110.113
142.251.110.139
142.251.110.138
142.251.110.101
bilal_002@app01:~$
```

nsswitch order and DNS lookup on app01

Result	Meaning
`hosts: files dns`	`/etc/hosts` (“files”) is checked first, then DNS
`dig` → six `142.251.110.x` addresses	DNS works from app01 **through gw01’s NAT**

All three servers get the contact list

Each machine has its own `/etc/hosts`, so every server received the names of the other two (gw01: app01, stor01 · app01: gw01 · stor01: gw01, app01).

Accidental break test: on gw01 I first typed `192.168.60.200 stor01`, then the correct `.20` line. `/etc/hosts` is read top to bottom and the **first match wins**, so stor01 would have resolved to the wrong address – the exact fault the guide asks you to provoke. The wrong line was removed in nano; a similar slip on stor01 (`192.168.60.20 app01`) was corrected the same way.

My Computer | gw01 | app01 | stor01

```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.1  gw01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
[sudo] password for bilal_001:
192.168.60.1  gw01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.10  app01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
192.168.60.10  app01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.200  stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
192.168.60.200  stor01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ echo "192.168.60.20  stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
192.168.60.20  stor01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ _
```

Typo on gw01

📸 Evidence – every server reaches the other two by name:

My Computer | gw01 | app01 | stor01

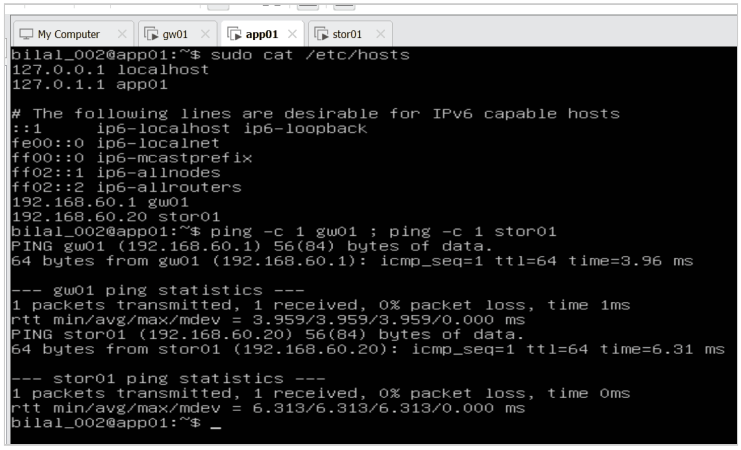
```
bilal_001@gw01:~$ sudo cat /etc/hosts
127.0.0.1 localhost
127.0.1.1 gw01

# The following lines are desirable for IPv6 capable hosts
::1     ip6-localhost ip6-loopback
fe00::0 ip6-localnet
ff00::0 ip6-mcastprefix
ff02::1 ip6-allnodes
ff02::2 ip6-allrouters
192.168.60.10  app01
192.168.60.20  stor01
bilal_001@gw01:~$ ping -c 1 app01 ; ping -c 1 stor01
PING app01 (192.168.60.10) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from app01 (192.168.60.10): icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=6.74 ms

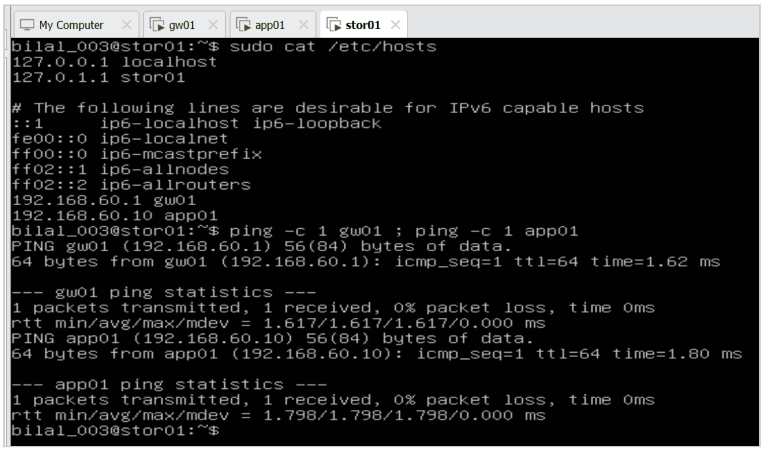
--- app01 ping statistics ---
1 packets transmitted, 1 received, 0% packet loss, time 0ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 6.742/6.742/6.742/0.000 ms
PING stor01 (192.168.60.20) 56(84) bytes of data.
64 bytes from stor01 (192.168.60.20): icmp_seq=1 ttl=64 time=3.89 ms

--- stor01 ping statistics ---
1 packets transmitted, 1 received, 0% packet loss, time 0ms
rtt min/avg/max/mdev = 3.892/3.892/3.892/0.000 ms
bilal_001@gw01:~$
```

gw01 pings by name



app01 pings by name



stor01 pings by name

---

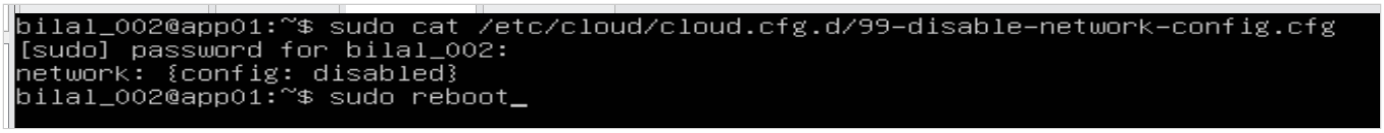
7. Results summary

Requirement	Status	Evidence
Fixed lab IPs on all servers, survive reboot	✅	sections 3.5–3.7
app01 / stor01 have no direct internet adapter	✅	ens33 DOWN on both
gw01 routes between networks	✅	`ip_forward = 1`
Lab reaches internet only via gw01 (NAT)	✅	ping 8.8.8.8 + ifconfig.me from app01
Inbound connections from the internet blocked	🟡	ESTABLISHED,RELATED rule in place; default FORWARD policy still ACCEPT – strict DROP follows in Phase 6. Lab currently unreachable from outside because of double NAT
Servers resolve each other by name	✅	all three, by name (`/etc/hosts`)
stor01 data disks present for Phase 2	✅	`sdb`, `sdc` 5 GB

8. Issues encountered

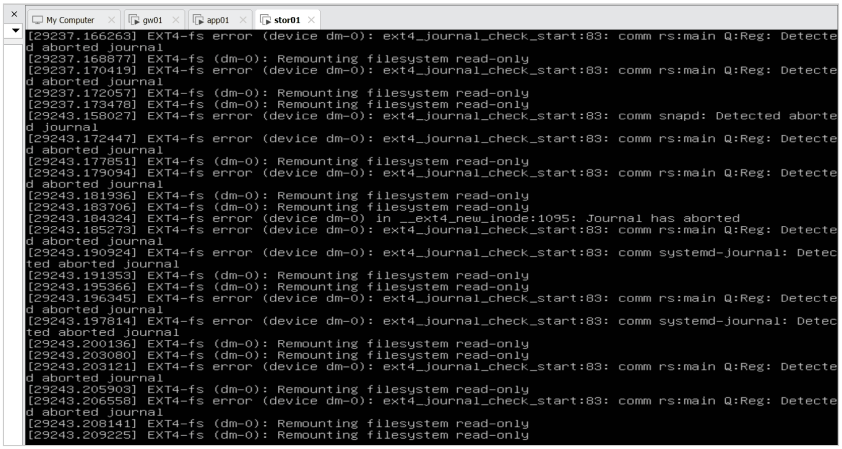
#	Symptom	Cause	Resolution
1	Netplan file named in the guide did not exist	Ubuntu 22.04 installer names it `50-cloud-init.yaml`	Checked with `ls /etc/netplan`, edited the real file, disabled cloud-init network management
2	YAML pasted into the VMware console arrived garbled (Ö instead of `:`, ü instead of `[`, staircase indentation)	VM keyboard layout differs from the host layout; vim auto-indents pasted text	Left vim without saving (`Esc`, `:q!`) and typed the file by hand in nano, using spaces
3	`netplan` warned that file permissions are too open	File readable by all users	`sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml`
4	`netplan try` printed `Cannot call Open vSwitch`	netplan checks for Open vSwitch, which is not installed	Harmless, ignored – no OVS interfaces are used
5	app01 still had a 192.168.229.x address on ens33	NAT adapter still connected in VMware	Unticked *Connected* and *Connect at power on*, rebooted; ens33 now DOWN
6	VMnet2 not visible in the Virtual Network Editor	It is an isolated custom switch, not a host-only network	Confirmed as correct for the design
7	`lsblk` on stor01 showed only `sda`	The two planned 5 GB data disks had never been added	Powered off, added 2 × 5 GB SCSI disks; `sdb` and `sdc` now present
8	`curl -s if config` / `curl -s ifconfig` printed nothing	Typo / incomplete hostname; `-s` (silent) hides the error	Used the full name `ifconfig.me`; drop `-s` when troubleshooting
9	`ssh bilal_001@192.168.229.155` from Windows PowerShell timed out, although `sshd` was running and listening on port 22	Not investigated further: direct SSH from the Windows host is not part of the design (admin access comes through the WireGuard VPN in Phase 6A)	Deferred; console access used meanwhile
10	On app01 the `tee` output of the cloud-init line appeared as `#network: …`	A `#` makes the line a comment (ignored) – a typing slip	Rewrote the file; `cat` confirms `network: {config: disabled}` (screenshot below)
11	Typos in `/etc/hosts` (`.200` for stor01 on gw01, `.20` for app01 on stor01)	Typing slips; first matching line wins	Verified with `cat/getent`, corrected in nano
12	stor01: `EXT4-fs error … Detected aborted journal, Remounting filesystem read-only` (screenshot below)	Virtual disk interrupted on the Windows side (host disk space, sleep or forced stop); Linux protected the data by going read-only	Restarted the VM from VMware; filesystem writable again

📸 Issue 10 – cloud-init file verified on app01 after the fix:



cloud-init file correct on app01

📸 Issue 12 – stor01 filesystem switched to read-only:



stor01 read-only incident

9. Key understanding (in my own words)

These are the conclusions I reached by questioning each step until it made sense. They are written so I can explain them in an interview.

1. The network file and cloud-init

- `/etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml` is the main network settings file: IP address, gateway and DNS. It was written once by **cloud-init** when Ubuntu was installed. At every boot **netplan reads it** and configures the network cards.
- cloud-init is the **writer**, netplan is the **reader**. cloud-init could rewrite the file on a later boot and erase my settings.
- So I created `/etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg` with `network: {config: disabled}`. This only stops **cloud-init from managing the network** – the network itself and netplan keep working.
- Files in a `.d` folder are read in alphabetical order and **the last one wins**, so a `99-` file has the final word. The numbers only matter between files in the **same folder** – 50 (netplan) and 99 (cloud-init) are never compared.
- In Proxmox or the cloud, cloud-init is used the other way round: the admin enters IP, user and SSH key in the hypervisor, and cloud-init writes them into the server at first boot – ideal for cloned templates. In my VMware lab nothing feeds cloud-init, so I configure netplan by hand and keep cloud-init away from the network.

2. What the network file says

- `addresses: [192.168.60.10/24]` – **I am** 192.168.60.10; `/24` means 192.168.60.0–255 are my direct neighbours.
- `routes: - to: default via: 192.168.60.1` – "default" is not a machine, it means **everything I don't know**; `via` names who to hand it to: gw01.
- `nameservers: [1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8]` – the internet's phone books. A name is first looked up in `/etc/hosts` (my own contact list – that is how `stor01` is found), and only then asked from DNS (that is how `google.com` is found).
- netplan only sets **addresses, gateway and DNS**. Being a router (ip_forward), NAT and firewall (iptables) and VPN (WireGuard) are set elsewhere.

3. The path to the internet

> app01 is 192.168.60.10 and has no internet adapter. For anything outside the lab it goes via gw01 (192.168.60.1), its default gateway. gw01 translates app01's private address into its own (NAT) and passes the traffic on through VMware and the home router to the internet. stor01 works the same way with 192.168.60.20.

4. NAT, forwarding and conntrack

> NAT recognises lab traffic by its IP range (`-s 192.168.60.0/24`) and changes the sender address as it leaves via `-o ens33`. Forwarding decides who may pass using the cards (`-i ens34 -o ens33`). Replies are let back in only if conntrack – gw01's memory of every conversation – confirms they are ESTABLISHED or RELATED to a conversation the lab started. conntrack also remembers which lab machine asked, so NAT can return each reply to the right one.

- **Two jobs, two tables:** the NAT table *changes the address* (`-j MASQUERADE`); the filter table's FORWARD chain *gives permission* (`-j ACCEPT`). A packet is checked by FORWARD first and rewritten in POSTROUTING just before it leaves – whatever order the commands were typed in.
- **`-s`/`-d` take IP addresses, `-i`/`-o` take card names.** `-s ens34` is always wrong. In POSTROUTING only the exit card is known, so `-i` is not allowed there – the lab must be identified by its IP range.
- **States:** NEW = someone starts a conversation; ESTABLISHED = a reply in a conversation the lab started; RELATED = a helper message (e.g. an error) belonging to it. `sudo conntrack -L` on gw01 shows the live list.
- **Honest limit today:** Ubuntu's default FORWARD policy is still ACCEPT, so the "only replies come back" rule is not yet enforced strictly. Right now the lab is protected because its private addresses sit behind two layers of NAT and cannot be reached from the internet. The strict version comes in Phase 6, when the default policy becomes DROP.
- `netfilter-persistent save` must run **last** – it saves only the rules that exist at that moment.

5. Names: /etc/hosts, DNS, getent and ping

> **getent** ("get entries") is like searching the phone book. It looks up a name or IP first in `/etc/hosts`, then in **DNS** if one is configured. It works both ways: name → IP (forward lookup) and IP → name (reverse lookup, e.g. `getent hosts 192.168.60.20` → `stor01`). It only **reads** – it never contacts the machine.
>
> **ping** is like calling. It uses the **same lookup** (`/etc/hosts`, then DNS) to find the number, then really contacts the machine with **ICMP** messages – "are you there?" (echo request) and "yes, I'm here" (echo reply). ICMP has **no ports**. So getent can succeed while ping fails – if the machine is off, the network is broken, or a **firewall blocks ICMP**.
>
> In our lab there is no internal DNS server, so we put the names in `/etc/hosts`. The servers could already reach each other **by IP**; `/etc/hosts` lets them reach each other **by name**.

- **Phone picture:** the contacts app inside the phone = the system resolver (`/etc/hosts` → DNS); getent = opening the contacts and reading a number; ping = pressing *call* – it looks up the same contact, then dials; ICMP = the phone network that carries the call.
- **Troubleshooting rule:** getent fails → a **name** problem (missing/wrong entry or DNS). getent works but ping fails → a **network** problem (machine off, cabling, firewall).

- `/etc/hosts` is a file on **each** machine – fine for a small lab, but 100 servers means 100 files to edit. Companies use an **internal DNS server** for their own names (as the Windows Server does in Project 1) and **public DNS** (1.1.1.1, 8.8.8.8) for internet names.
- **The DNS helper and loopback:** on Ubuntu, programs do not ask 1.1.1.1 directly – they ask a small helper on the same machine, **systemd-resolved**, at **127.0.0.53**. Every **127.x.x.x** address is **loopback** – the machine talking to itself, like putting a note in your own pocket: the traffic never leaves the machine (`lo` in `ip -br a`). The helper answers from its **DNS cache** – short-term memory of name lookups for the whole machine – or asks the real DNS servers through gw01. The cache speeds things up, expires by itself (**TTL**), and can be cleared with `sudo resolvectl flush-caches`. `resolvectl status` shows which DNS servers are in use.
- **DNS troubleshooting in three commands:** `getent hosts <name>` (does the name resolve at all?) → `resolvectl status` (which DNS servers?) → `dig +short <name>` (does DNS itself answer? dig skips `/etc/hosts`).
- `hostname` shows the machine's own name; `getent hosts <name>` asks what address a name has; `tee -a /etc/hosts` appends a new entry.

10. Lessons learned

- **Check, don't assume:** the real file name (`ls /etc/netplan`) differed from the documentation.
- **Back up before editing** any configuration file.
- cloud-init can silently undo manual network changes; disabling its network module makes the admin the owner of the configuration.
- `netplan try` + a reboot test = safe change: automatic undo if wrong, proof of persistence if right.
- Network isolation is enforced at the **hypervisor** (unplugged virtual cable), not only inside the OS.
- Verify hardware against the plan early (`lsblk`) – a missing disk found now costs one minute; found in Phase 2 it blocks the whole storage phase.
- `ip_forward` + MASQUERADE + a stateful FORWARD rule is the minimal recipe for a Linux NAT gateway; the replies-only rule keeps the lab closed to inbound connections.
- Name resolution order (`files` before `dns`) explains why a stale `/etc/hosts` entry can break a healthy service.
- Pasting into a VM console is unreliable across keyboard layouts; typing short config files is faster than debugging garbled input.

11. Next steps

1. **Step 1.5:** ports and sockets – who is listening where (`ss`, `lsof`, `nc`).
2. **Step 1.6:** SSH key login from gw01 to app01 and stor01 (gw01 later becomes the Ansible control node).

Project 2 – Acme Analytics Linux Platform

Day 2 · Phase 1, Steps 1.5–1.9: ports, SSH keys, links and inodes, users and groups, Linux vs cloud NAT

Muhammad Bilal Javed · 15–16 October 2026

Project	Acme Analytics – hardened, observable and recoverable Linux platform
Phase	1 – Network foundation: 1.5 ports and sockets · 1.6 SSH keys · 1.7 links and inodes · 1.8 users and groups · 1.9 NAT comparison
Dates	15–16 October 2026
Hosts worked on	app01, stor01, gw01
Status	Step 1.5 ✅ · Step 1.6 ✅ – password-free SSH, remote commands and scp from gw01 to both servers · Step 1.7 ✅ – hard links, soft links, inodes · Step 1.8 ✅ – users, groups, service account · Step 1.9 ✅ – NAT comparison · **Phase 1 complete, snapshot taken**
Author	Muhammad Bilal Javed

> **How to read this report.** 💡 **In plain words** – the idea for any reader. 🔧 **Technical** – the commands, with a comment on every line. 📸 **Evidence** – the real screenshot. Terms are explained in the glossary.

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1. Objective

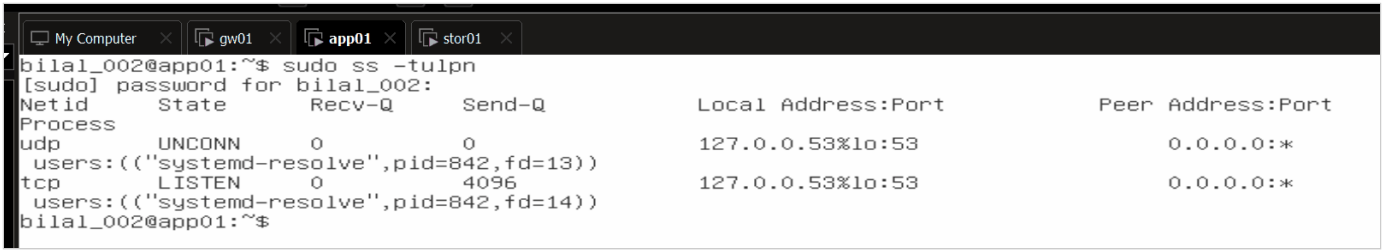
💡 **In plain words:** an IP address is the **address of a building** (which machine). A **port** is a **door number** inside that building (which program). Every service waits behind its own numbered door: SSH behind door 22, DNS behind door 53, a website behind door 80. Before opening new doors, I made an inventory of which doors app01 already has open – and to whom.

🔧 **Technical:** list all listening TCP and UDP sockets on app01 with the owning process, and interpret the result.

2. Procedure

```
sudo ss -tulpn   # ss = socket statistics
#  -t  TCP sockets        -u  UDP sockets
#  -l  only listening      -p  show the owning process
#  -n  numbers, not names  (memory aid: "tulpn" = tulip)
```

📸 **Evidence:**



ss -tulpn on app01

3. Reading the output

Column	Technical meaning	In plain words	In my output
Netid	Protocol: TCP or UDP	TCP = a phone call (confirmed); UDP = a postcard (just sent)	`udp` and `tcp`
State	LISTEN = TCP socket waiting for connections; UNCONN = open UDP socket (UDP never connects); ESTAB = an active TCP connection	LISTEN = a door open and waiting; UNCONN = a letterbox ready for letters	`UNCONN` (udp), `LISTEN` (tcp)
Recv-Q	Bytes received but not yet read by the program	Letters that arrived but are not opened yet	`0` – nothing waiting
Send-Q	On a LISTEN socket: the maximum queue of waiting connections	How many visitors may queue at the door	`4096` on the DNS helper's TCP socket; `0` for UDP (no queue)
Local Address:Port	IP and port on this machine where the socket listens	Building address + door number	`127.0.0.53%lo:53`
Peer Address:Port	The other end of a connection	Who is visiting	`0.0.0.0:*` – nobody yet, anyone may come
Process	Program name, process ID, file descriptor	Which program sits behind the door	`systemd-resolve`, pid 842, fd 13 (UDP) and fd 14 (TCP)

The address in detail: `127.0.0.53 % lo : 53` = the loopback address (127.x = the machine talking to itself), bound to the loopback card `lo`, on port 53 (DNS). Reachable **only from programs inside app01**.

fd (file descriptor): the number a program uses for something it has open – in Linux almost everything is a file, including network sockets. fd 13 and fd 14 are the DNS helper's two sockets.

4. TCP and UDP – the background

	TCP	UDP
Start	**3-way handshake:** SYN → SYN-ACK → ACK ("Can you hear me?" – "Yes, can you hear me?" – "Yes")	No handshake – it just sends
Lost data	Noticed and re-sent automatically – reliable	Lost for good – no check
Speed	Slower, but sure	Faster, no guarantee
In ss	LISTEN → ESTAB	UNCONN
Used for	SSH (22), websites (80/443)	DNS (53), video calls, games

DNS uses UDP for short questions and TCP for answers too large for one packet – that is why the DNS helper listens on both. The firewall rule `ESTABLISHED,RELATED` from Step 1.3 means exactly "packets belonging to a TCP conversation that already completed its handshake".

5. Final verdict

What	Result
Open ports on app01	**1:** port 53 (DNS), UDP + TCP
Program	`systemd-resolved` – the local DNS helper
Reachable from the network?	❌ No – bound to loopback only
SSH (port 22)	❌ Not listening – the package was installed but the service was not enabled
Security view	✅ Minimal attack surface – app01 exposes nothing to the network
Impact on the project	⚠️ No remote administration possible: SSH keys (Step 1.6) and Ansible (Phase 7A) need SSH

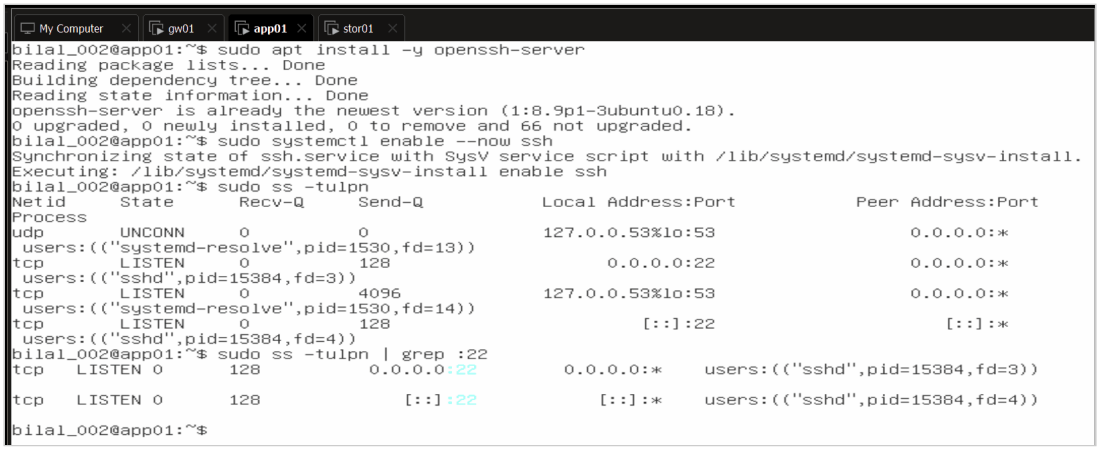
> **Before:** app01 exposed no network services at all – only the local DNS resolver on 127.0.0.53:53, reachable from inside the machine. The SSH package was installed but its service was not running, so it had to be enabled for remote administration.

6. Fix: enable SSH on app01

🔧 **Commands:**

```
sudo apt install -y openssh-server   # make sure the SSH server package is installed
sudo systemctl enable --now ssh      # start it now (--now) AND at every boot (enable)
sudo ss -tulpn | grep :22            # verify: is anything listening on door 22?
```

📸 **Evidence:**



SSH enabled on app01, listening on port 22

Line	Meaning
`openssh-server is already the newest version`	The package was already installed – only the **service was not running**. `enable --now` started it and made it start at every boot
`tcp LISTEN 0.0.0.0:22 … sshd`	SSH waits on door 22 on **all IPv4 addresses** – reachable from gw01 and stor01
`tcp LISTEN [::]:22 … sshd`	The same for IPv6 (`[::]` = all IPv6 addresses)
Send-Q 128	sshd's waiting queue – up to 128 connections may queue
`systemd-resolve` pid 1530 (before: 842)	New process number after the VM restart – normal

Before → after: app01 went from **0 doors open to the network** to **1** – SSH on port 22.

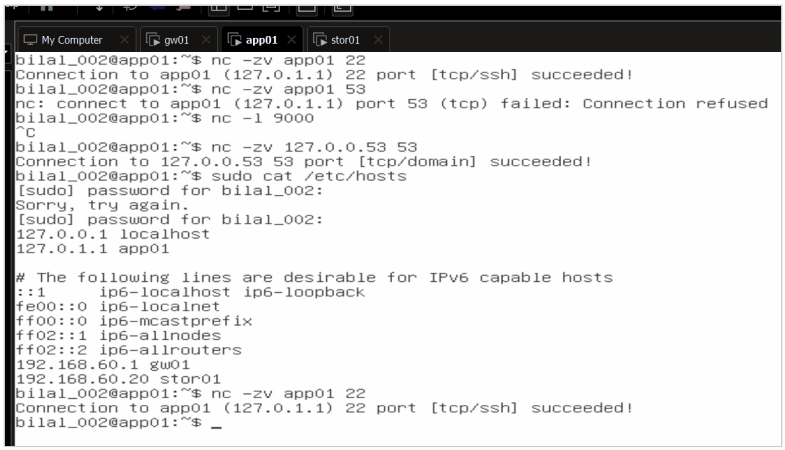
7. Testing a port: `nc -zv` and the binding address

💡 **In plain words:** ping only proves a machine is alive. To prove a **service** answers, you knock on its **door** (port). `nc` (netcat) does exactly that – the admin's standard check when "ping works but the application doesn't".

🔧 **Commands (on app01 – the machine calling itself):**

```
nc -zv app01 22        # -z: only check the door, send no data · -v: print the result
nc -zv app01 53        # same for door 53
nc -zv 127.0.0.53 53   # door 53 at the DNS helper's own address
cat /etc/hosts         # where the name "app01" points to
```

📸 **Evidence:**



Port tests on app01 with nc -zv

Test	Result	Why
`app01:22` (= 127.0.1.1)	✅ succeeded	sshd listens on `0.0.0.0` = **every** address of the machine
`app01:53` (= 127.0.1.1)	❌ Connection refused	The DNS helper listens **only on 127.0.0.53** – a different address
`127.0.0.53:53`	✅ succeeded	The right address – the DNS service **is** running

Three loopback addresses (the whole range 127.x.x.x means "this machine itself", all on the card `lo`):

Address	Created by	Seen in	Purpose
`127.0.0.1`	Worldwide standard	`/etc/hosts` → `localhost`	"Myself" for any program
`127.0.1.1`	Ubuntu installer (hostname)	`/etc/hosts` → `app01`	The machine finds its own name without a network
`127.0.0.53`	systemd-resolved	`/etc/resolv.conf` → `nameserver`	The DNS helper's private address

Refused vs. timeout – two different failures:

Result	What happened	Usual cause
Connection refused	The machine answered "nobody here"	Service not running, or listening on another address
Timeout	No answer at all	Firewall silently dropping, network broken, machine off

Refused points to the **service**; *timeout* points to the **network or firewall**.

8. Key understanding (in my own words)

> **Netid** is the protocol, TCP or UDP. **TCP** starts every conversation with a 3-way handshake (SYN, SYN-ACK, ACK); after that the connection is **ESTAB**. **UDP** has no handshake – it just sends.

Every port leads directly to its own program. The port number decides which program receives the traffic: port **22** → **sshd** (SSH), port **53** → the **DNS helper**, port **80** → a web server. Traffic does **not** pass through the DNS helper first. A port with no program behind it is closed – nobody answers.

LISTEN = a TCP door is open and waiting. **UNCONN** = a UDP door is open. **Recv-Q** = data received but not read yet (0 = nothing waiting). **Send-Q** on a LISTEN socket = how many visitors may wait in the queue (4096 for the DNS helper's TCP socket). **Local address** = this machine's address and door, e.g. `127.0.0.53%lo:53` = the DNS helper on the loopback card, port 53, reachable only from inside app01. **Peer address** = who is visiting – `0.0.0.0:*` = nobody yet; in a real connection it shows the visitor's IP and its random port, e.g. `192.168.60.1:51234` = gw01.

A server can test itself by calling its own address – loopback (127.x.x.x). `localhost` (127.0.0.1) and `app01` (127.0.1.1) both mean "myself". SSH listens on **all** addresses (`0.0.0.0`), so `localhost:22` and `app01:22` both work. The DNS helper listens on **one fixed address only, 127.0.0.53**, so only `127.0.0.53:53` works – any other address gets "connection refused". **The binding address matters:** `0.0.0.0` = the door is open at every entrance of the building; `127.0.0.53` = the door exists at one entrance only.

A port is a door number; a socket is a program standing at that door on a specific machine (IP + port + protocol); a connection is two sockets talking to each other.

DNS has one job: translate a name into an IP address – the phone book, not the phone line. Lookup order on app01: **`/etc/hosts`** (own contact list) → **local DNS helper** `127.0.0.53` (answers from its cache) → **outside DNS server** `1.1.1.1` / `8.8.8.8` through gw01. Once the IP is known, the real traffic goes directly to that IP and port. In a company, an **internal DNS server** answers internal names; in our lab `/etc/hosts` does that job.

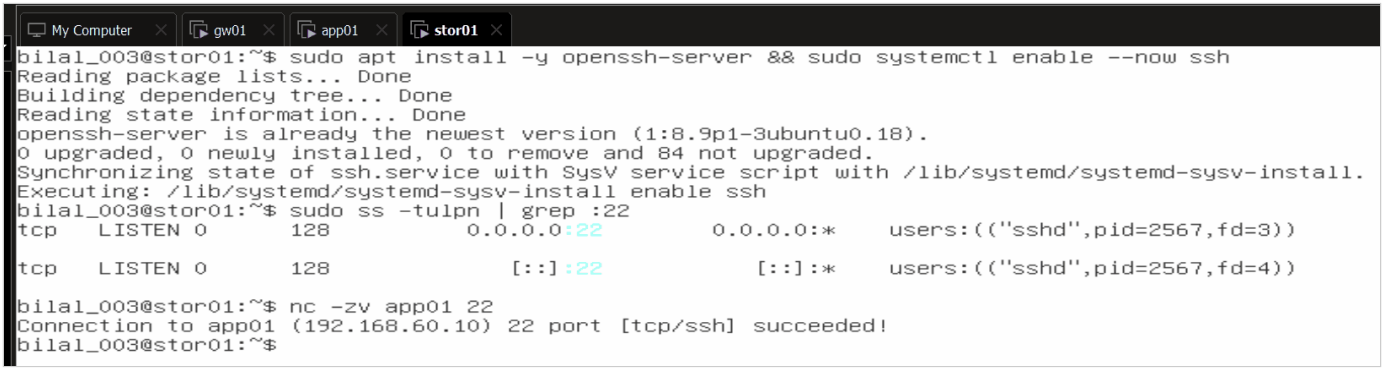
Before the fix, the only open port on app01 was 53, used by the local DNS helper, and only from inside app01 – it accepted **no connections from the network**. Next: enable SSH so port 22 opens.

9. Step 1.5 finished – SSH reachable across the lab network

🔧 **On stor01:** enable SSH and test app01 **from another machine** (on gw01 SSH was already running; only checked):

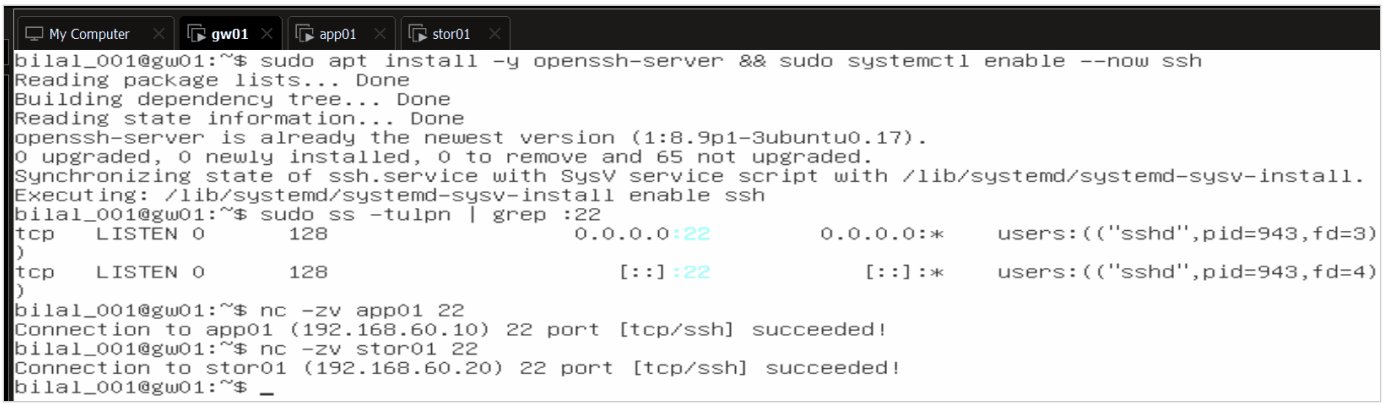
```
sudo apt install -y openssh-server && sudo systemctl enable --now ssh
sudo ss -tulpn | grep :22     # LISTEN 0.0.0.0:22 = door 22 open to the network
nc -zv app01 22               # knock on app01's SSH door over the lab network
```

📸 **Evidence – stor01:** SSH listening, and app01 reached at **192.168.60.10** (not loopback):



stor01: SSH enabled, nc to app01 succeeded

📸 **Evidence – gw01:** SSH listening, both servers reachable on port 22:



gw01: SSH listening, nc to app01 and stor01 succeeded

From	To	Result
stor01	app01 (192.168.60.10):22	✅ succeeded
gw01	app01 (192.168.60.10):22	✅ succeeded
gw01	stor01 (192.168.60.20):22	✅ succeeded

Step 1.5 complete: every server runs SSH on port 22 (`0.0.0.0` and `[::]`), reachable across the lab network.

10. Step 1.6 – SSH keys: log in without a password

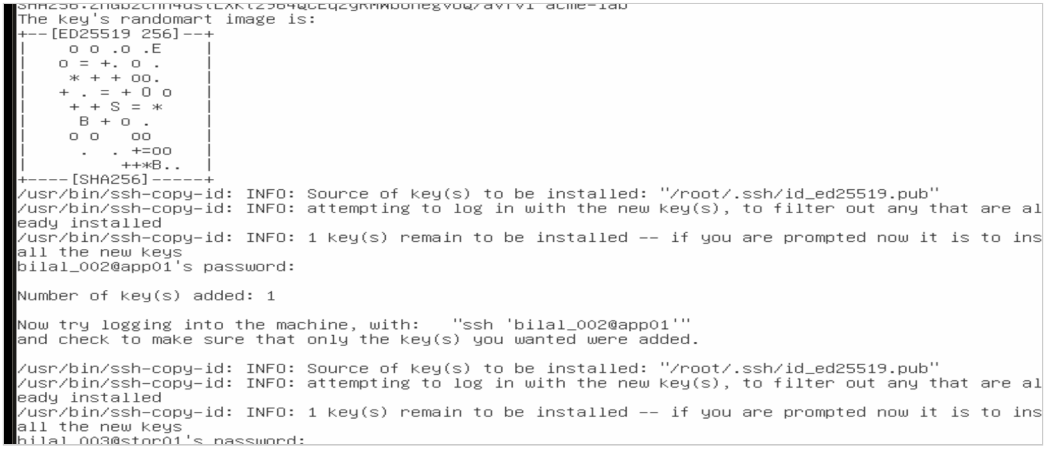
💡 **In plain words:** a password is something you **type**; an SSH key is a **pair of files** – a private key that never leaves gw01 (like a house key in your pocket) and a public key that is copied to each server (like a lock fitted to the door). If the key fits the lock, the door opens – no password. gw01 needs this because it becomes the **Ansible control node** in Phase 7A and must reach every server automatically.

🔧 **On gw01, as the normal user bilal_001 (not root):**

```
ssh-keygen -t ed25519 -C "acme-lab"   # create the key pair (Enter 3×: default path, no passphrase for the lab)
ssh-copy-id bilal_002@app01           # copy the PUBLIC key to app01 (asks the password once)
ssh-copy-id bilal_003@stor01          # same for stor01
```

Issue: key first created for root

📸 The first attempt ran as root – the key landed in `/root/.ssh/`, so password-free login would only work with `sudo ssh …`:



ssh-copy-id using /root/.ssh/id_ed25519.pub

Fix: repeated as **bilal_001**, without `sudo`. The key now lives in `/home/bilal_001/.ssh/`. (The root key copied earlier will be removed during hardening in Phase 6 – servers should not trust gw01's root user.)

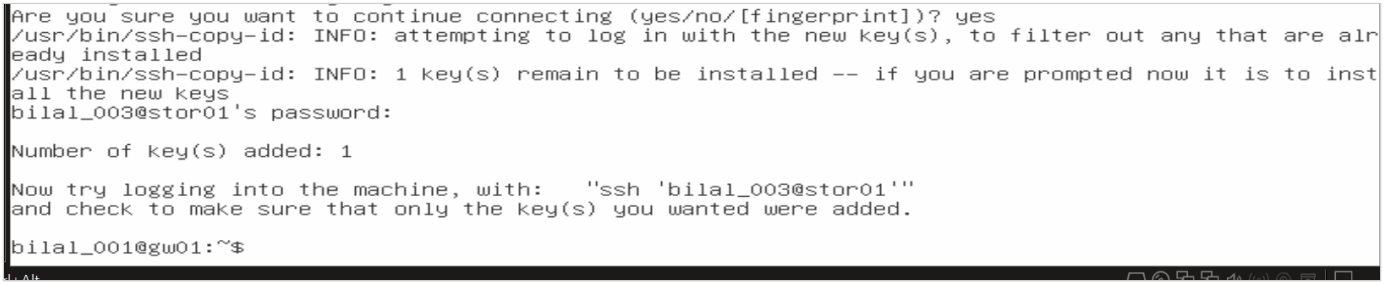
📸 **Evidence – correct key for bilal_001:**



ssh-keygen as bilal_001, key in /home/bilal_001/.ssh

"The authenticity of host … can't be established" – first visit to a server: gw01 asks whether to trust the server's ID (fingerprint). After `yes` it is stored in `~/.ssh/known_hosts`; if a server's ID ever changes, SSH warns – protection against impostors.

📸 **Evidence – key added to stor01 ("Number of key(s) added: 1"):**

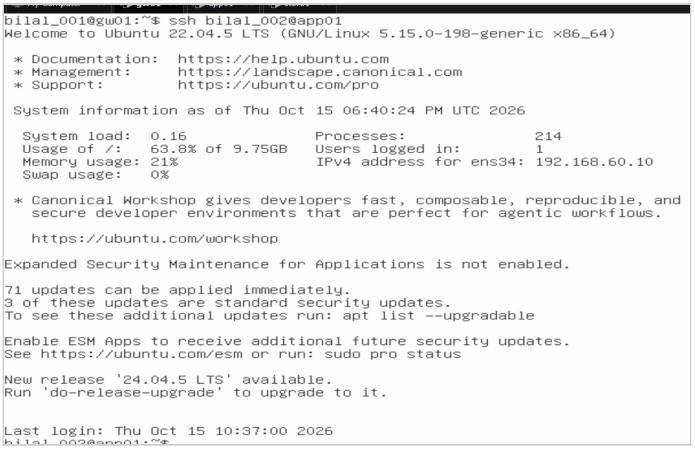


ssh-copy-id to stor01

The proof: login without a password

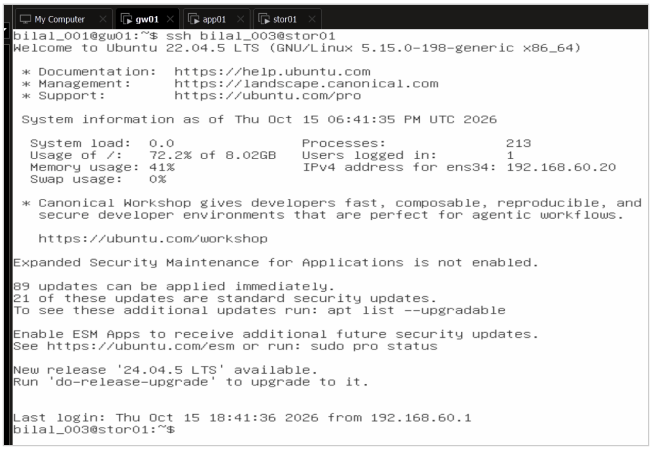
```
ssh bilal_002@app01     # log in to app01 — no password prompt
exit                    # close the session, back to gw01
ssh bilal_003@stor01    # log in to stor01 — no password prompt
exit                    # back to gw01
```

📸 **app01** – logged in with no password; the welcome screen confirms `IPv4 address for ens34: 192.168.60.10`:



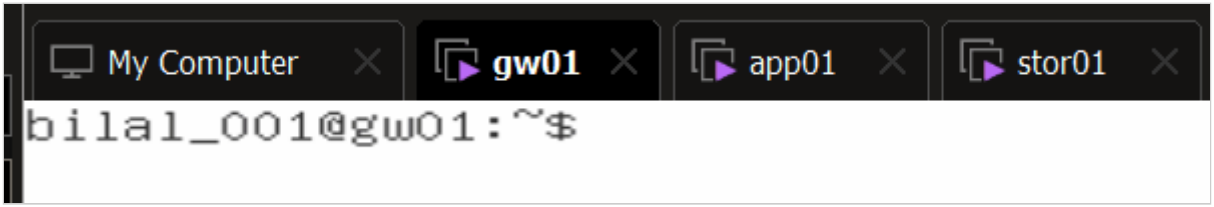
SSH login to app01 without password

📸 **stor01** – same; note `Last login … from 192.168.60.1` – Linux records who logged in from where (the start of an audit trail):



SSH login to stor01 without password

📸 **`exit`** closes the remote session – the prompt `bilal_001@gw01:~$` shows I am back on gw01:



Back on gw01 after exit

Habit: always read the prompt before typing – `user@host` tells you which server the next command runs on.

Observed on the welcome screens	Meaning
app01 / 63.8 % of 9.75 GB · stor01 / 72.2 % of 8.02 GB	stor01's system disk is filling – data moves to the separate LVM disks in Phase 2
71 (app01) / 89 (stor01) updates, 3 / 21 security	to be applied during hardening (Phase 6)
"New release 24.04.5 available"	deliberately **not** upgraded – the lab stays on 22.04

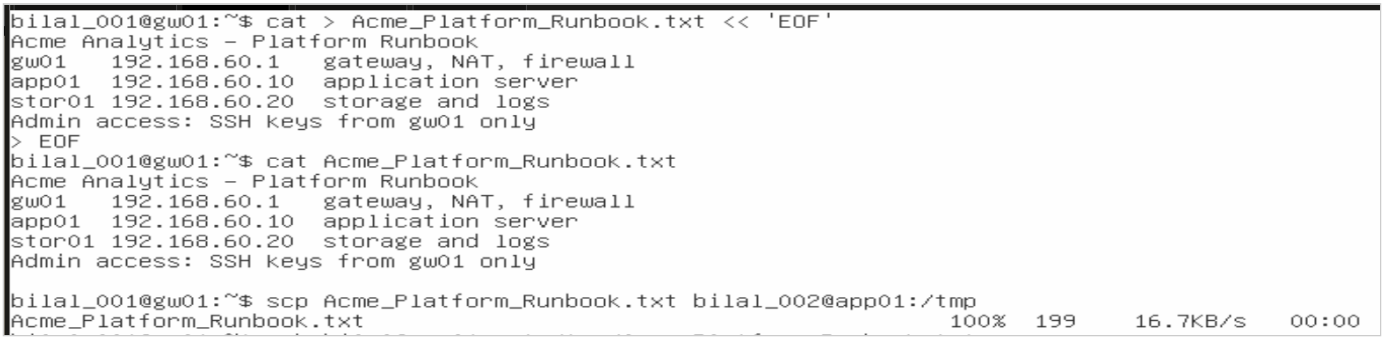
Copying a file over SSH: `scp`

💡 **In plain words:** `scp` (secure copy) sends a file to another server through the same encrypted SSH door – and because the key is installed, no password is needed. Instead of a throw-away test file I created a short **platform runbook** – the kind of handover note admins keep.

```
cat > Acme_Platform_Runbook.txt << 'EOF'      # write the lines below into the file …
Acme Analytics - Platform Runbook
gw01   192.168.60.1   gateway, NAT, firewall
app01  192.168.60.10  application server
stor01 192.168.60.20  storage and logs
Admin access: SSH keys from gw01 only
EOF                                           # … until the end marker EOF ("End Of File")
scp Acme_Platform_Runbook.txt bilal_002@app01:/tmp/        # copy it to app01's /tmp folder
ssh bilal_002@app01 cat /tmp/Acme_Platform_Runbook.txt     # run ONE command on app01 and show the result
```

Heredoc (`<< 'EOF'`): "write everything I type until you see EOF". The closing `EOF` stands alone on its line; the quotes keep the text exactly as typed. File names use underscores – spaces in Linux file names need quoting and break scripts.

📸 **Evidence – file created and copied (`100% 199 bytes`, no password):**



Runbook created with a heredoc and copied with scp

📸 **Evidence – read back on app01 with a one-shot SSH command:**



Runbook read on app01 via ssh

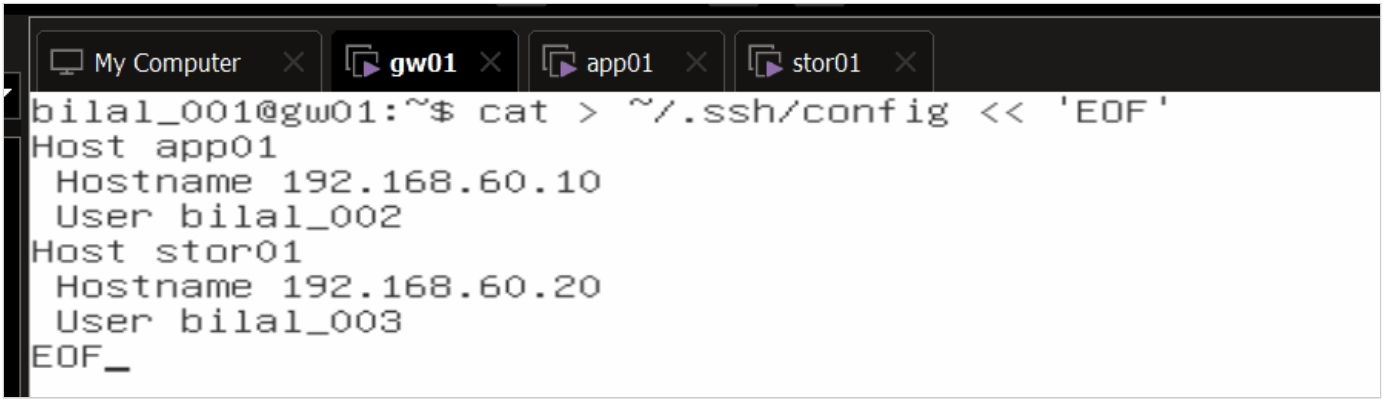
`ssh user@host command` runs a single command on the remote server and returns – the same pattern Ansible uses later.

SSH shortcuts: `~/.ssh/config`

💡 **In plain words:** a personal address book for SSH – type `ssh app01` instead of `ssh bilal_002@192.168.60.10`.

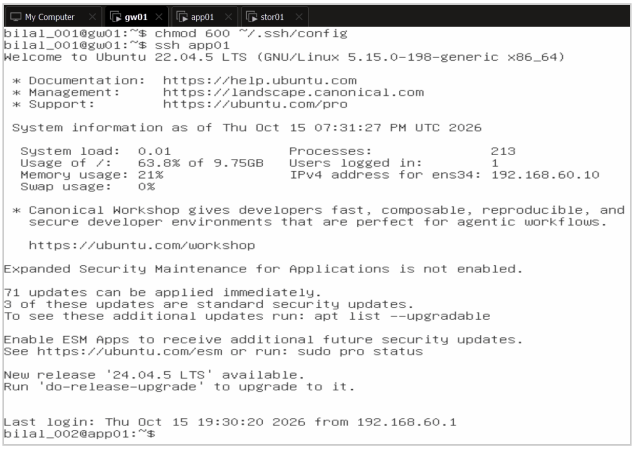
```
cat > ~/.ssh/config << 'EOF'
Host app01
    HostName 192.168.60.10
    User bilal_002
Host stor01
    HostName 192.168.60.20
    User bilal_003
EOF
chmod 600 ~/.ssh/config   # only the owner may read it – SSH refuses a config others can read
ssh app01                 # log in by short name – no user, no password
exit
ssh stor01
exit
```

📸 **Evidence – the shortcut file:**



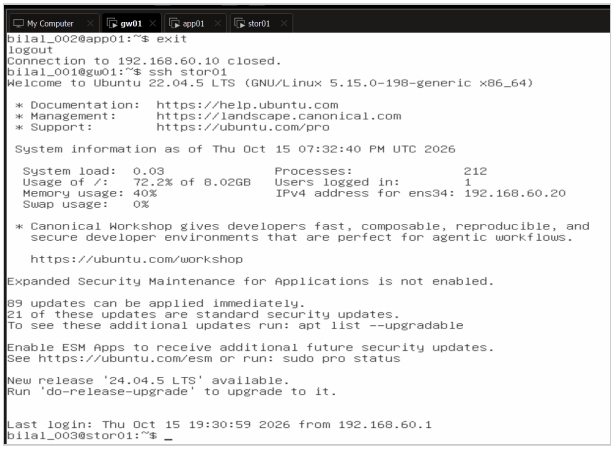
~/.ssh/config with Host entries for app01 and stor01

📸 **Evidence – `ssh app01` logs in as bilal_002 without a password:**



ssh app01 by alias

📸 Evidence – `exit` ("Connection to 192.168.60.10 closed"), then `ssh stor01`:



exit and ssh stor01 by alias

Interactive transfer: `sftp`

```
sftp app01                          # open a file session over SSH
sftp> ls                            # list files in the home folder on app01
sftp> cd /tmp                       # change folder on app01
sftp> get Acme_Platform_Runbook.txt # download to gw01
sftp> exit
```

📸 Evidence – runbook downloaded from app01 to gw01 (100 %):



sftp session: ls, cd, get

Why not FTP?

> **FTP sends usernames, passwords and files in clear text** – anyone listening on the network can read them. **SCP and SFTP run inside SSH**, so everything is **encrypted**, and with keys no password crosses the network at all. Companies do not use plain FTP for administration.

Tool	Use	Encrypted
`scp`	copy one file quickly	✅ (SSH)
`sftp`	browse and transfer interactively	✅ (SSH)
`ftp`	legacy file transfer	❌ clear text

Step 1.6 complete: gw01 reaches app01 and stor01 by key and by short name, runs remote commands and copies files with `scp` and `sftp` – all encrypted, all without a password.

11. Step 1.7 – Hard links, soft links and inodes

💡 **In plain words:** every file has an **ID card** (the *inode*) holding its owner, permissions, size, dates and where the data sits on disk. The **file name is only a label** in a folder pointing to that ID card. - A **hard link** = a **second label on the same ID card**. Delete one label, the file lives on. - A **soft link** = a **signpost** with its own ID card that only says “go to that name”. Delete the original, the signpost points to nothing.

🔧 **Technical:** a directory is a list of *name → inode number*. `ln` adds another directory entry for the same inode (link count +1). `ln -s` creates a new inode of type symlink that stores a path. The inode and its data blocks are freed only when the link count reaches 0 **and** no process still has the file open.

Why in this project: Phase 2 backs up app data to stor01 with `rsync --link-dest`. Every day’s backup folder hard-links the files that did not change to yesterday’s copy, so 30 daily backups look full-size but take little extra space. A soft link `/backups/latest` points to the newest day and is moved each night. The same signpost idea is used by nginx (`sites-enabled → sites-available`) in Phase 7. This lab proves the mechanism on real files first.

Procedure (on app01, as bilal_002)

```
mkdir -p ~/acme && cd ~/acme
echo "APP_PORT=8080" > app.conf          # an Acme config file
ln app.conf app.conf.backup              # hard link: second name, same inode
ln -s app.conf current.conf              # soft link: signpost holding the path "app.conf"
ls -li                                   # first column = inode number, third = link count
echo "LOG_LEVEL=info" >> app.conf.backup # write through the hard link
cat app.conf                             # the change appears here too — same file
stat app.conf | head -3                  # Inode and Links: 2
```

📸 **Evidence – same inode 276722 and link count 2 for both names; the soft link has its own inode 276727; an edit via the hard link shows in the original:**

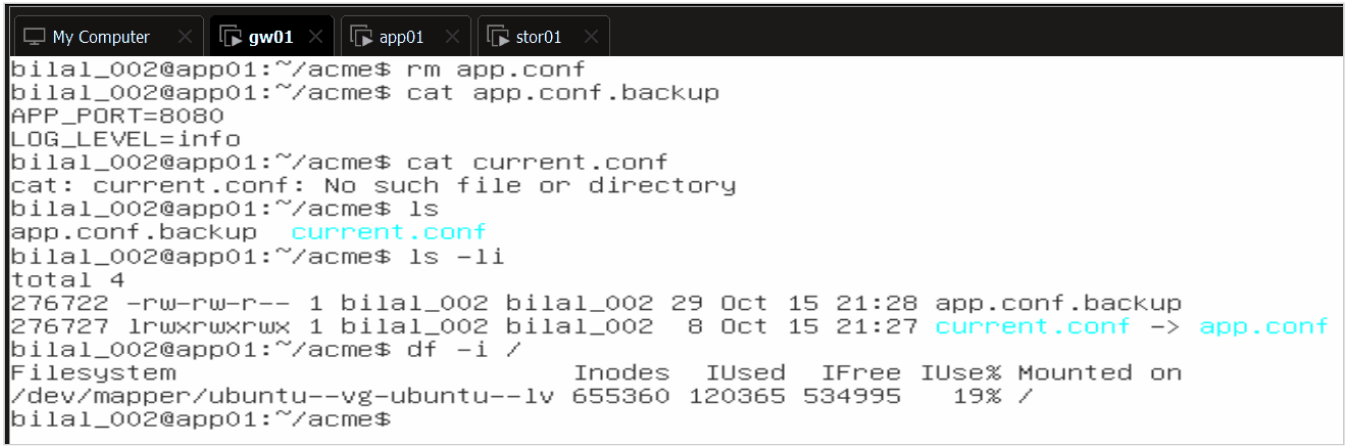
```
bilal_002@app01:~/acme$ ls -li
total 8
276722 -rw-rw-r-- 2 bilal_002 bilal_002 14 Oct 15 21:26 app.conf
276722 -rw-rw-r-- 2 bilal_002 bilal_002 14 Oct 15 21:26 app.conf.backup
276727 lrwxrwxrwx 1 bilal_002 bilal_002  8 Oct 15 21:27 current.conf -> app.conf
bilal_002@app01:~/acme$ echo "LOG_LEVEL=info" >> app.conf.backup
bilal_002@app01:~/acme$ cat app.conf
APP_PORT=8080
LOG_LEVEL=info
bilal_002@app01:~/acme$ stat app.conf | head -3
  File: app.conf
  Size: 29              Blocks: 8          IO Block: 4096   regular file
Device: fd00h/64768d    Inode: 276722      Links: 2
bilal_002@app01:~/acme$
```

ls -li, write through the hard link, stat

The “accidental delete” test

```
rm app.conf           # simulate a colleague deleting the file
cat app.conf.backup   # data is still there
cat current.conf      # "No such file or directory" — the signpost is broken
ls -li                # link count of the survivor is now 1; current.conf shown in red
df -i /               # inode capacity of the root file system
```

📸 **Evidence – hard link survives, soft link broken, inode usage 19 %:**



rm original, hard link survives, soft link broken, df -i

Reading the results

Observation	Meaning
`276722 … 2 … app.conf` and `276722 … 2 … app.conf.backup`	One file, two names (link count 2)
`276727 lrwxrwxrwx … current.conf -> app.conf`	Separate inode; type `l` = symlink; size 8 = the length of the text "app.conf"
`LOG_LEVEL=info` appears in `app.conf`	A hard link is **not a copy** – an edit through either name changes the one file
After `rm`: `app.conf.backup` still readable, link count **1**	Data is freed only when the last name is gone
`current.conf` shown in red, `cat` fails	Dangling soft link – it points to a name that no longer exists
`df -i /`: 655,360 inodes, 120,365 used, **19 %**	Each file uses one inode; when inodes run out you get "No space left on device" even with free GB – worth monitoring (Phase 5A)

Key understanding (in my own words)

> Linux works with inode numbers; the name I type is only a label in a folder. A **hard link** is a second label on the same inode – deleting one name loses nothing, but it does **not** protect against bad edits, because it is the same file. A **soft link** has its own inode and only holds a path – deleting it never harms the original, but deleting the original breaks it. Hard links protect important files against accidental deletion; real protection against bad changes still needs backups (Phase 2).

Step 1.7 complete. `~/acme` stays on app01 as sample data.

12. Step 1.8 – Users, groups and a service account (continued 2026-10-16)

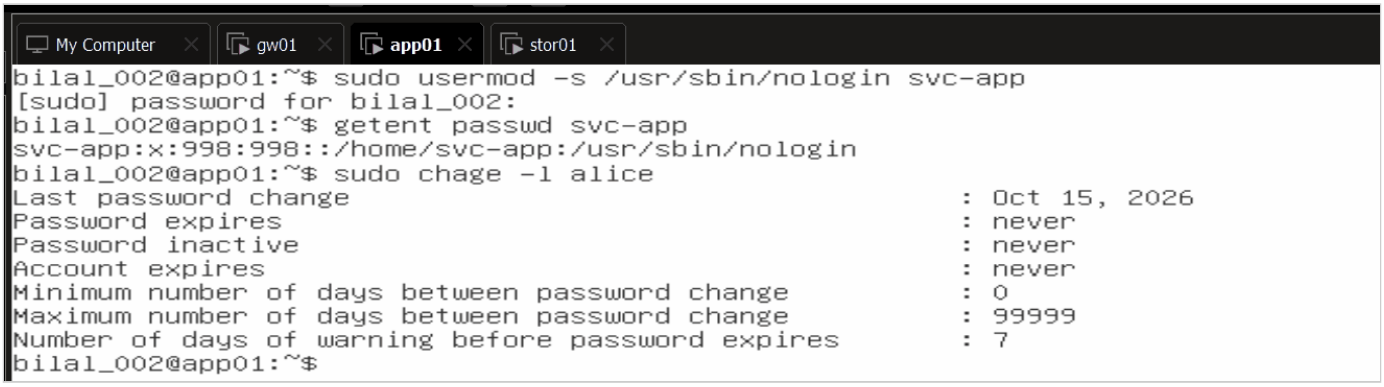
💡 **In plain words:** every person gets their own account, people who do the same job share a **group**, and every **program** gets its own low-rights account that nobody can log in to. When someone leaves, their account is **locked**, not shared or forgotten.

Why in this project: the security questionnaire in the brief asks "who can log in, and with which rights?". This step answers it: named users, a team group, and a no-login service account. In Phase 3 the Acme app's systemd service runs as `svc-app`; in Phase 6 groups decide who may use `sudo` and Docker; in Phase 7A Ansible automates exactly this joiner/leaver process.

Procedure (on app01)

```
sudo groupadd devs                                  # team group (it already existed)
sudo useradd -m -s /bin/bash -G devs alice          # -m home folder, -s shell, -G extra group
sudo useradd -m -s /bin/bash -G devs bob
sudo useradd -r -s /usr/sbin/nologin svc-app        # -r system account, nobody can log in
sudo passwd alice                                   # give alice a password
id alice                                            # uid, primary group, secondary groups
getent group devs                                   # members of devs
sudo chage -l alice                                 # password aging ("change age")
sudo usermod -L bob                                 # lock (leaver)
sudo passwd -S bob                                  # status: L = locked, P = password, NP = none
sudo usermod -U bob                                 # unlock (returner)
```

📸 **Evidence – svc-app has the shell `/usr/sbin/nologin` and system uid 998; alice's password aging:**



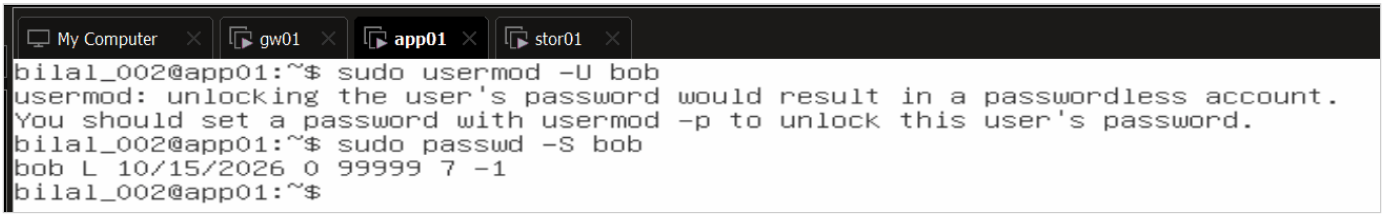
getent passwd svc-app and chage -l alice

📸 **Evidence – devs = alice, bob; svc-app in its own group only; bob locked (L):**



getent group devs, id svc-app, lock bob

📸 **Evidence – unlock refused, because bob has no password yet:**



usermod -U refused: passwordless account

Reading the results

Output	Meaning
`uid=1001(alice) gid=1002(alice) groups=1002(alice), 1001(devs)`	Primary group = her own private group; secondary group = devs
`devs:x:1001:alice,bob`	Both developers are in the team group
`svc-app:x:998:998::/home/svc-app:/usr/sbin/nologin`	uid **below 1000** = system/service account; shell `nologin` = no human login
`chage -l alice`: expires never, max 99999	No password expiry yet – to be set by policy in Phase 6 (e.g. `chage -M 90`)
`bob L 10/15/2026 0 99999 7 -1`	Status **L** = locked; then min/max/warn days and inactive (-1 = not set)
`usermod -U bob` refused	Safety feature: unlocking an account without a password would leave it open with **no password at all**. Set a password first (`sudo passwd bob`), then lock/unlock.

Option cheat sheet

Option	Meaning
`useradd -m`	make the home folder
`useradd -s` / `usermod -s` (small s)	set the shell
`useradd -G`	add to extra groups
`useradd -r`	system account (uid < 1000, no home folder) – low rights come from no extra groups and not being root
`usermod -L` / `-U`	lock / unlock
`passwd -S` (capital S)	show the password status
`chage -l` / `-M 90`	show aging / force a new password every 90 days

Key understanding – final summary

> On app01, the server where the Acme application runs, we created named accounts for each developer – alice and bob – each with their own home folder (`-m`) and login shell (`-s`), and put both in a shared team group `devs`, so rights are given to the team instead of to each person; each user has a primary group (their own) and a secondary group (devs). We then created `svc-app` as a **system account** (`-r`, uid 998, below 1000) with the shell `nologin` and no password: no human can log in as it, it exists only so a program can run under it. Every service runs as some user – the main sshd as root with its pre-login part as `sshd`, nginx as `www-data` – and giving each service its own low-rights account means a hacked service reaches only that account's own files, not root. `chage` shows and sets the password-aging rules, and `usermod -L` / `-U` lock and unlock an account – the leaver/returner process. Linux refused to unlock bob while he had no password, because a human account must have a password or key before it is opened. This step answers the Acme customer's security question "who can log in, and with which rights?", and it is the base for later phases: in Phase 3 the app runs as `svc-app`, in Phase 6 groups control `sudo` and Docker access, and in Phase 7A Ansible automates joiners and leavers.

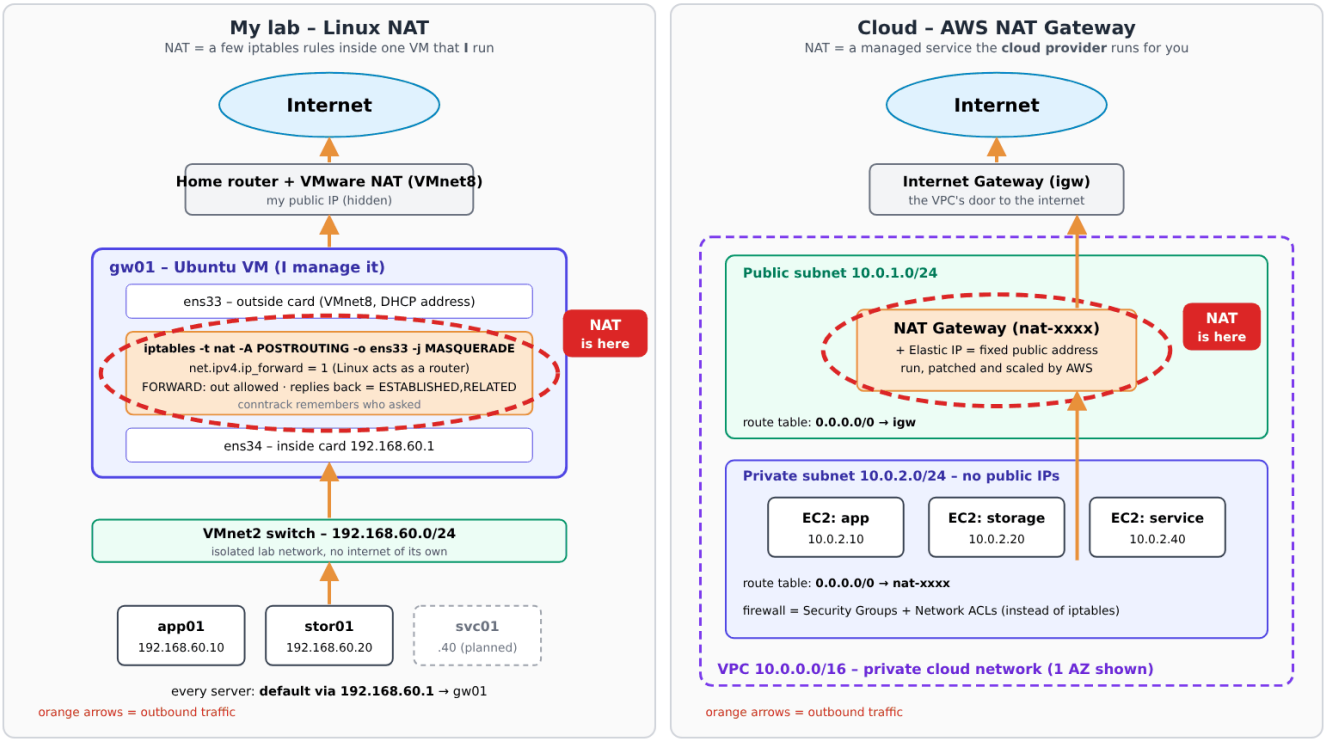
Step 1.8 complete.

13. Step 1.9 – Linux NAT vs Cloud NAT

💡 **In plain words:** NAT is the mailroom that swaps the private sender address for the company's public address on the way out and hands the replies back to the right person. In my lab I **build** that mailroom myself on gw01. In the cloud you **rent** it as a ready-made service.

Where does NAT live? Linux NAT (my lab) vs Cloud NAT (AWS)

Same job in both: private servers reach the internet, but the internet cannot start a connection to them. The red circle marks the NAT.



Same job: swap the private sender address for a public one on the way out, and let only the replies back in. **Difference:** in the lab I build, patch and keep the NAT alive; in the cloud the provider does, and charges per hour and per GB.

My lab piece	Cloud equivalent (AWS)	What it does
gw01 + iptables MASQUERADE	NAT Gateway	Rewrites the source address of outgoing traffic
ens33 / VMware NAT address	Elastic IP	The public address the internet sees
Home router / VMnet8	Internet Gateway	The door between the network and the internet
VMnet2 192.168.60.0/24	Private subnet	Servers with private addresses only
default via 192.168.60.1	Route table 0.0.0.0/0 → nat-xxxx	Sends unknown destinations to the NAT
iptables FORWARD rules	Security Groups + NACLs	Decides which traffic may pass

Muhammad Bilal Javed · Acme Analytics Linux Platform · Phase 1, Step 1.9

Where does NAT live? Linux NAT in my lab vs AWS NAT Gateway

Where the NAT sits

	My lab (gw01)	Cloud (AWS)
The NAT itself	3 kernel settings on one VM: `ip_forward = 1`, iptables `MASQUERADE`, `FORWARD` rules	A **NAT Gateway** placed in a **public subnet**
How servers find it	`default via 192.168.60.1` in netplan on each server	Private subnet route table `0.0.0.0/0 → nat-xxxx`
Public address	The address of gw01's outside card (VMware NAT / home router)	An **Elastic IP** attached to the NAT Gateway
Way out to the internet	Home router / VMnet8	**Internet Gateway** (public subnet route `0.0.0.0/0 → igw`)
Firewall	iptables `FORWARD` chain	Security Groups + Network ACLs

Comparison across providers

	gw01 (mine)	AWS NAT Gateway	Azure NAT Gateway	GCP Cloud NAT
Who runs it	Me	AWS (managed)	Azure (managed)	Google (managed)
Where	One VM	Public subnet; private route table `0.0.0.0/0 → nat-xxxx`	Attached to a subnet	Configured on a Cloud Router; no NAT VM at all (software-defined)
High availability	None – one VM is a single point of failure	Redundant inside one Availability Zone; one gateway per AZ for full resilience	Managed, zonal	Managed, distributed
Public IP	Address of the NAT adapter	Elastic IP	Public IP(s) or prefix	Auto-allocated or reserved IPs
Cost model	The VM I already run	Per hour + per GB processed	Per hour + per GB processed	Per hour + per GB processed

In three sentences

1. **What stays the same:** the job – outbound source translation, so private servers reach the internet while nobody on the internet can open a connection to them.
2. **What the cloud adds:** the provider runs, patches, scales and keeps the NAT available; in my lab, if gw01 is off, app01 and stor01 lose the internet.
3. **What I would watch:** cost – managed NAT is charged per hour **and per GB**, so heavy traffic (updates, backups, container image pulls) through it gets expensive; options such as VPC endpoints for cloud storage keep that traffic off the NAT.

Key understanding (in my own words)

> In my lab the NAT is not a box – it is three settings inside gw01: forwarding on, a MASQUERADE rule, and FORWARD rules that let replies back. Servers reach it because their default route points to gw01. In the cloud the same job is a managed NAT Gateway in a public subnet, reached through a route table entry and given a fixed Elastic IP; the provider keeps it running and bills per hour and per GB. Same job, different owner.

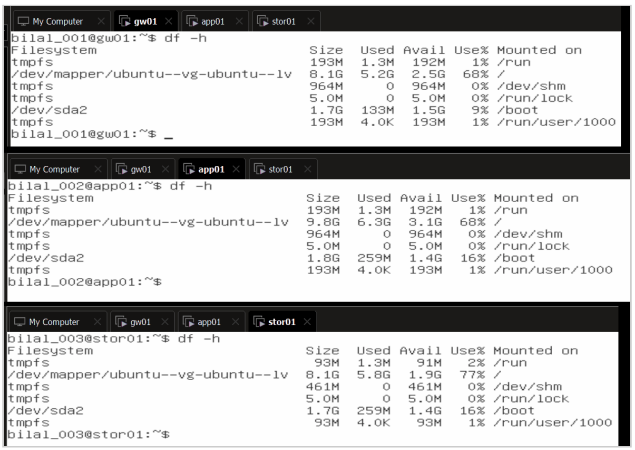
14. End of Phase 1 – updates and snapshot

All three VMs were updated (`sudo apt update && sudo apt -y upgrade`), shut down cleanly and given a VMware snapshot – the **restore point** for everything built in Phase 1.

VM	Snapshot name	Root disk	Used
gw01	`20-Network-gw01`	8.1 G	68 %
app01	`20-Network-app01`	9.8 G	68 %
stor01	`20-Network-stor01`	8.1 G	77 %

Description on every snapshot: *Phase 1 done: static IPs, NAT via gw01, hosts, SSH keys, users/groups, updates installed.*

📸 **Evidence – disk usage on gw01, app01, stor01 before the snapshot:**



df -h on all three VMs

💡 **Why:** a snapshot taken while the VM is **off** is clean and small (no memory saved). If Phase 2 (storage) breaks something, I return to this point in one click instead of rebuilding the network. stor01's root disk is the fullest, which is fine: backups will go to its separate data disks (`sdb`, `sdc`) with LVM in Phase 2.

Phase 1 complete ✅

15. Next steps

1. **Phase 0 leftover:** switch app01 and stor01 to server mode (`multi-user.target`).
2. **Phase 1A:** GLPI service desk – tickets, knowledge base and inventory on svc01.
3. **Phase 2:** storage – LVM on stor01's data disks, NFS share, backups with hard links, LVM snapshots.

Project 2 – Acme Analytics Linux Platform

Day 3 · Phase 1A: the service desk – svc01, storage, network story, GLPI running, asset inventory

Muhammad Bilal Javed · 16–17 October 2026 · study copy

Project	Acme Analytics – hardened, observable and recoverable Linux platform
Phase	1A – Service desk: GLPI tickets, knowledge base and asset inventory
Host worked on	svc01 (new VM)
Status	Step 1A.1 🟡 – svc01 installed, networked, names and SSH key working, disk grown to 23 GB, fully patched · Step 1A.2 ✅ – Docker + GLPI running, opened in the browser · Step 1A.4 ✅ – GLPI agent on all 4 servers, automatic inventory, snapshot `25-service-desk`
Author	Muhammad Bilal Javed

> **How to read this report.** 💡 **In plain words** – the idea for any reader. 🔧 **Technical** – the settings and commands. 📸 **Evidence** – the real screenshot. Terms are explained in the glossary.

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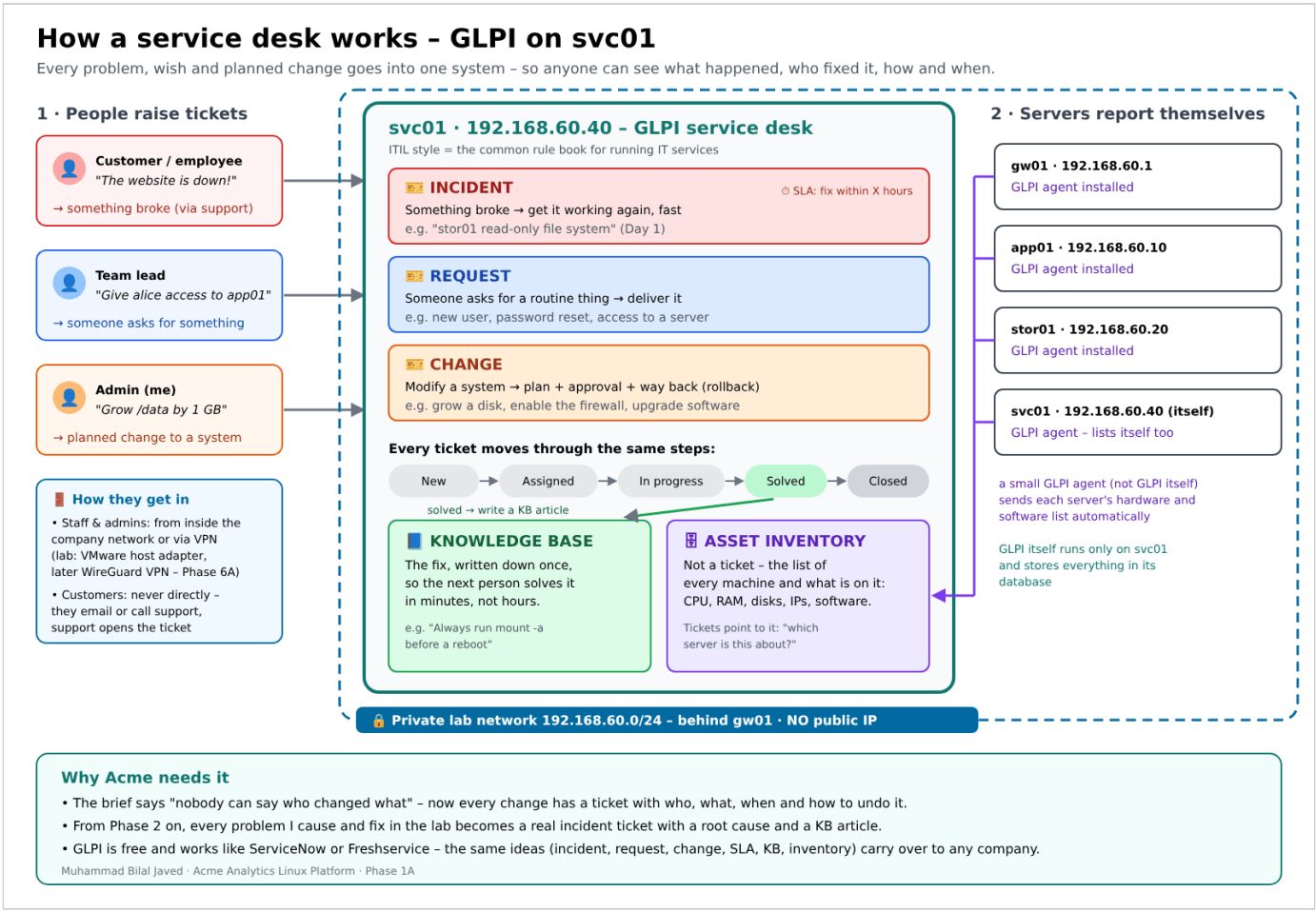
1. The story – why a service desk, and why now

💡 **In plain words:** until now I fixed problems and wrote them down in these reports. A real IT team does not work like that: every problem, every change and every "please give me access" goes into a **ticket system**, so anyone can see *what happened, who fixed it, how, and when*. Phase 1A gives Acme that system.

Where it fits in the Acme story. The brief says: *"nobody can say who changed what"* and *"the first enterprise customer's security questionnaire asks questions the team cannot answer."* The network (Phase 1) now works, so this is the right moment: from Phase 2 on, **every incident I cause and fix becomes a real ticket**, every planned change (e.g. "grow /data by 1 GB") becomes a **change** ticket with a rollback plan, and every server appears in an **asset inventory** automatically.

Ticket type	Meaning	Example in this project
Incident	Something broke	"stor01 read-only file system" (happened on Day 1)
Change	A planned change with a plan and a rollback	"Grow /data by 1 GB", "Enable UFW on stor01"
Request	Someone asks for a routine thing	"Give alice access to app01", a password reset
Knowledge base (KB)	The written fix, so the next person solves it faster	"Always run `mount -a` before a reboot"
Asset inventory	Every server with CPU, RAM, disks, IPs and installed software	gw01, app01, stor01, svc01

📊 **The picture – how a service desk works:**



How a service desk works – GLPI on svc01

Key understanding (in my own words).

> In the IT industry a problem is an **incident**, and handling them is **incident management**. When someone asks for a routine thing – a new user, a password reset, access to a server – it is a **request**. When I modify a system itself – grow a disk, enable a firewall, upgrade software – it is a **change**, which needs a plan, approval and a way back. All three are **tickets** in GLPI, and every ticket moves through the same steps: new → assigned → in progress → solved → closed; a solved fix is written down in the **knowledge base**. The **asset inventory** is not a ticket: it is the list of every machine and what is on it, filled automatically by the GLPI agent on each server, so a ticket can say which server it is about. GLPI follows **ITIL**, the common rule book for running IT services, and is used by many European companies and public bodies.

Who can reach svc01? svc01 has **no public IP** – it sits on the private lab network behind gw01, like app01. Staff and admins reach it from inside the company network (in the lab: my PC through VMware's host adapter; from Phase 6A through the WireGuard VPN). **Customers never reach it directly**: they email or call support, and support opens the ticket for them. A service desk holds the details of every server, so exposing it to the internet would be a security risk.

Why svc01 appears twice in the picture: in the middle it is the **GLPI application** (the help desk); on the right it is the **machine** svc01, which also runs a GLPI agent and lists itself in the inventory. GLPI itself runs only on svc01; the other servers get only the small agent.

Incident or change? "The server is broken, please update it" is an **incident** (something is broken). "The server runs an old version, upgrade it next Tuesday" is a **change** (planned). The SLA – how fast a ticket must be handled – is the IT team's promise, not something the customer sets.

Why GLPI. GLPI is a free, ITIL-style service desk used by many European companies and public bodies. Freshservice or ServiceNow need a paid licence; GLPI teaches the same concepts – incident, change, request, SLA, KB, CMDB – and they carry over to any tool.

Why it matters for my job search. Many of the junior IT / DevOps postings I reviewed ask for ticket systems, SLAs, asset management or knowledge articles. In an interview I can say: *"I ran my lab through GLPI. Every incident I caused has a ticket, a root cause and a KB article, and every server is in the inventory."*

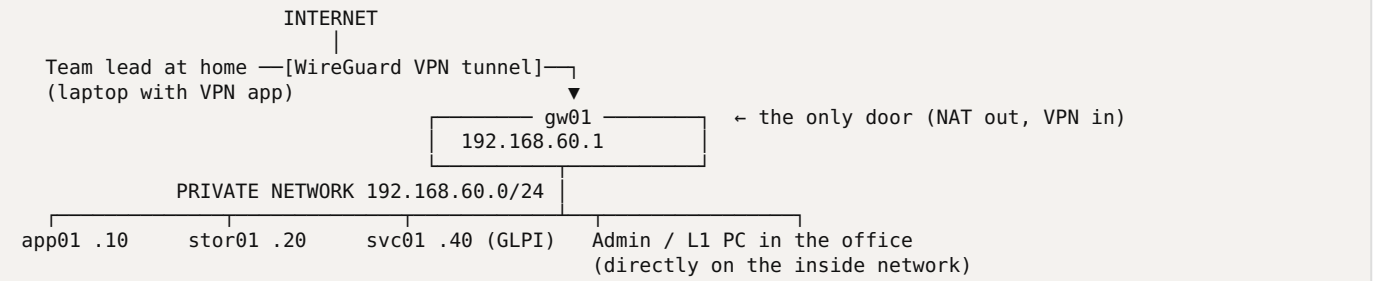
Why a separate server. The service desk must keep working when the servers it tracks are broken – if app01 is down, I still need to open the incident ticket. So it gets its own VM, `svc01`. Later, Project 1 reuses the same svc01 as a second "customer" – one service desk serving two customers is how IT system houses and managed service providers work.

2. svc01 in the lab

VM	Role (plain words)	Role (technical)	IP
gw01	The gatekeeper	NAT, firewall	192.168.60.1
app01	The shop window	App server	192.168.60.10
stor01	The archive room	Storage, backups, logs	192.168.60.20
svc01	**The help desk**	**GLPI tickets, KB, inventory (Docker)**	**192.168.60.40**

2a. How people reach svc01 – and where gw01 comes in

💡 **In plain words:** gw01 is the **only door** between the private network and the internet. People already **inside** (in the office) go straight to svc01. People **outside** (at home) must come in through the door with a **VPN** – like a company badge for remote workers. Strangers and customers never get in.



Who	Where	Path to svc01	Through gw01?
Employee / team lead in the office	On the company network	Browser → `http://192.168.60.40`	❌ already inside
Team lead / admin from home	On the internet	VPN app → encrypted tunnel to gw01 → private network → svc01	✅ via the VPN
Stranger on the internet	Outside, no VPN	Blocked – svc01 has no public IP, gw01 lets in VPN users only	🚫
Customer	Outside	Never connects – emails or calls support; L1 opens the ticket	—
Me in the lab, now	Windows PC	VMware host adapter on VMnet2 → browser → `http://192.168.60.40`	❌
Me in the lab, from Phase 6A	Like the home worker	WireGuard VPN to gw01 → svc01	✅

Lab note: VMware may give the Windows host adapter on VMnet2 the address 192.168.60.1 – gw01's address. Before opening GLPI, check it in the Virtual Network Editor / Windows network settings and use a free address such as 192.168.60.250.

2b. Three examples, start to finish

How the GLPI agent fits in: a small program on each server looks at its own machine once a day (CPU, RAM, disks, IP, software) and sends the report to `http://svc01` – finding svc01 through `/etc/hosts` or DNS. GLPI stores it as an **asset**. The agent creates no tickets and nobody logs in through it. Tickets come from **people**; in each ticket the person picks the affected server ("Item: app01") from the inventory, which links the ticket to the machine.

Thing	Question it answers	Used by
`/etc/hosts` / DNS	"What is stor01's IP?"	Machines, to connect
Asset inventory	"What is app01, what does it have?"	People, to know and plan
Ticket	"What is wrong or needed, and who did what?"	People, to work

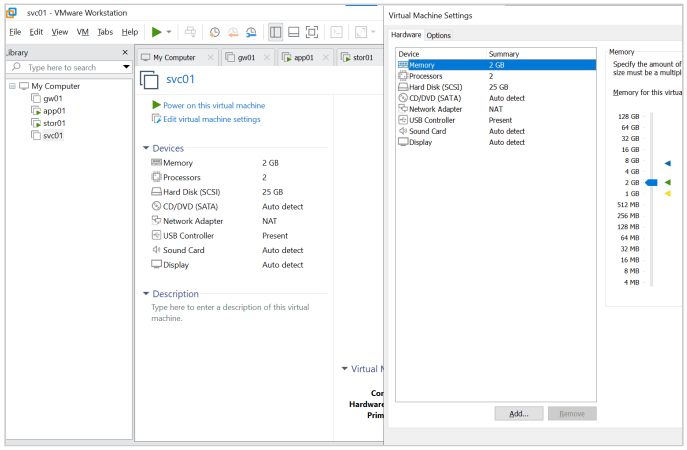
1. **Alice (employee) → Incident.** "I can't open the shared folder on app01." Item: app01. L1 checks (app01 pings, folder hangs) → escalates to **Linux Admins (L2)** with notes → L2 finds the firewall blocking NFS on stor01, fixes it, writes the root cause → Solved → KB article → alice confirms → Closed.
2. **Team lead → Request.** "New developer carol starts tomorrow; account on app01 in group devs." L1 runs `useradd -m -s /bin/bash -G devs carol` and `passwd carol` → Solved → Closed. When carol leaves: a new request → `usermod -L carol`.
3. **Admin → Change.** "/data on stor01 is 90 % full." The inventory shows 4 GB free in the storage pool → change ticket "Grow /data by 1 GB" with plan (`lvextend -r -L +1G`), risk, rollback (LVM snapshot first) and approval → done → `df -h` checked → Closed. The next agent run shows the new size automatically.

In the lab I play every role with separate GLPI accounts: `alice`/`bob` as requesters, `tech.bilal` in the groups **Service Desk (L1)** and **Linux Admins (L2)**. Escalation = reassigning the ticket to the higher group with notes; the history stays with the ticket.

3. VM settings

Setting	Value	Why
OS	Ubuntu Server **22.04.5** LTS (planned 24.04; the 22.04 ISO was used)	Same version as the other servers; GLPI runs in Docker either way
RAM	2 GB	GLPI + its database in Docker
CPU	2 vCPU	Smooth web interface; 1 would also work
Disk	25 GB	Database, ticket attachments, Docker images
Network	**One adapter, Custom → VMnet2**	Lab network only, like app01 and stor01 – internet only through gw01's NAT
CD/DVD	Ubuntu Server ISO, connect at power on	Installation medium
Sound card, USB	Optional – can be removed	A server does not need them
Hostname / user	`svc01` / `bilal_004`	Same naming pattern as the other servers
IP (set in the installer)	`192.168.60.40/24`, gateway `192.168.60.1`, DNS `8.8.8.8`	VMnet2 has no DHCP, so the address is set by hand
Installer option	✅ Install OpenSSH server	So gw01 can manage it over SSH with keys

📸 Evidence – VMware's default settings: 2 GB, 2 CPUs, 25 GB, but the network adapter is on NAT:

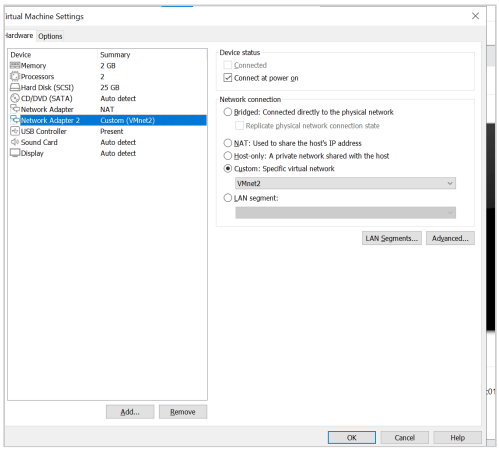


svc01 default settings with NAT

Issue: network adapter on NAT

Seen	VMware creates a new VM with its adapter on **NAT** (direct internet). Then a second adapter was added on VMnet2, so the VM had two adapters.
Why it matters	With NAT, svc01 would bypass gw01 – the gatekeeper design from Phase 1 would be broken, and the NAT adapter would have to be unplugged and netplan fixed after the install (the same trouble app01 had on Day 1).
Fix	Keep one adapter on **Custom → VMnet2**; **remove** the NAT adapter.
Lesson	Check every new VM's network before the first boot – the default is not the design.

📸 Evidence – Network Adapter 2 on Custom (VMnet2), connect at power on:

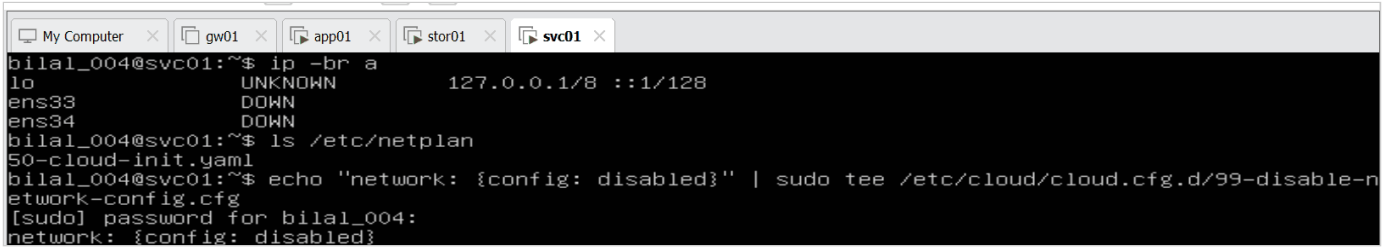


adapter on VMnet2

4. Installation and first boot

4.1 No network after the install

📸 **Evidence – two cards, both DOWN, no IP address; only one netplan file:**

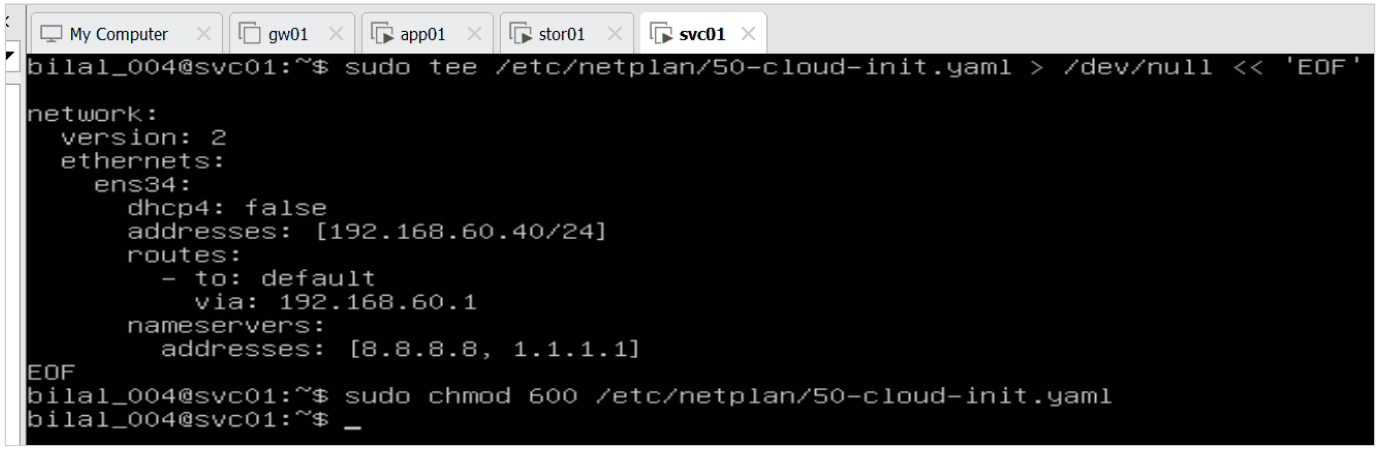


ens33 and ens34 down

Seen	`ip -br a` shows ens33 and ens34, both **DOWN** and without an address; `ip route` is empty; `ping` says *Network is unreachable*.
Cause	The NAT adapter was still attached during the install (two cards), and the manual network settings from the installer were not applied.
Fix	Stop cloud-init from managing the network (as on app01 and stor01, Day 1) and write the netplan file for ens34 (the VMnet2 card) by hand.

```
        echo "network: {config: disabled}" | sudo tee /etc/cloud/cloud.cfg.d/99-disable-network-config.cfg
        sudo tee /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml > /dev/null << 'EOF'
        network:
          version: 2
          ethernets:
            ens34:
              dhcp4: false
              addresses: [192.168.60.40/24]
              routes:
                - to: default
                  via: 192.168.60.1
              nameservers:
                addresses: [8.8.8.8, 1.1.1.1]
        EOF
        sudo chmod 600 /etc/netplan/50-cloud-init.yaml   # only root may read it
        sudo netplan try                                 # applies it; reverts after 120 s unless I press Enter
```

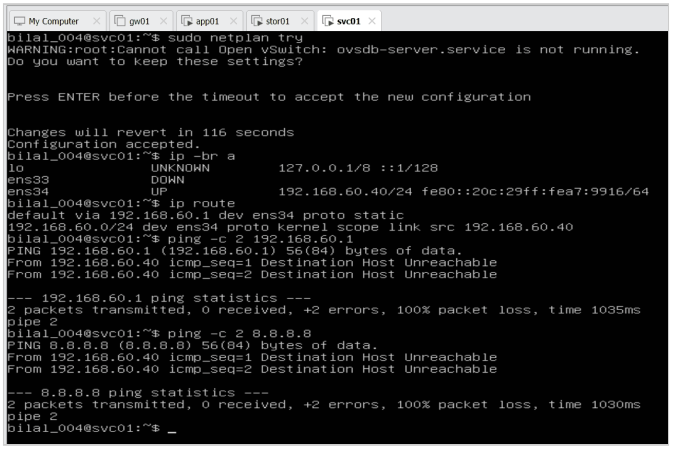
📸 **Evidence – the netplan file:**



netplan file for ens34

4.2 Address works – but gw01 was off

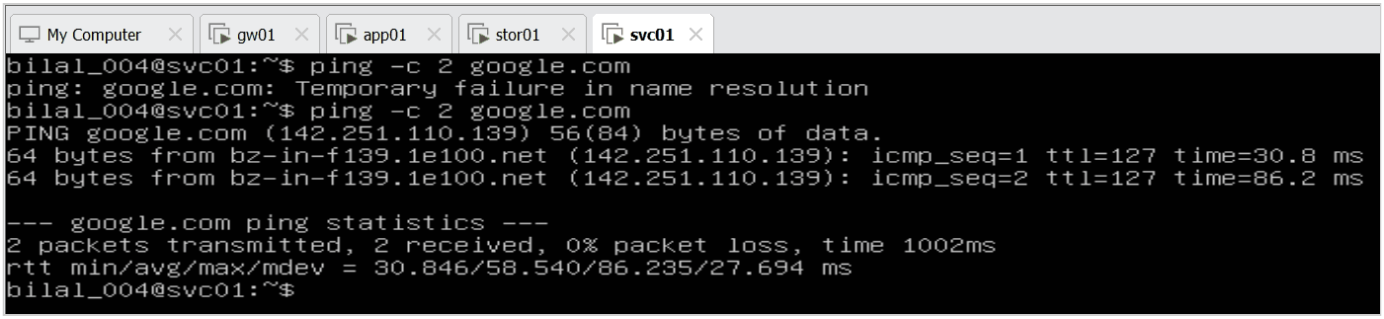
📸 **Evidence – `ens34 UP 192.168.60.40/24`, default route via .1, but "Destination Host Unreachable":**



netplan try, ping unreachable

Seen	svc01 has its address and route, yet `ping 192.168.60.1` and `ping 8.8.8.8` return *Destination Host Unreachable*, and `ping google.com` *Temporary failure in name resolution*.
Cause	**gw01 was powered off.** svc01 asked “who is 192.168.60.1?” and nobody answered. Without the gateway there is no way to the internet – and the DNS server 8.8.8.8 is on the internet.
Fix	Power on gw01.
Lesson	**Always start gw01 first.** The servers can talk to each other without it, but not to the internet or DNS.

📸 **Evidence – after starting gw01: google.com resolves and answers:**



DNS and internet through gw01

4.3 Names: `/etc/hosts` on all four servers

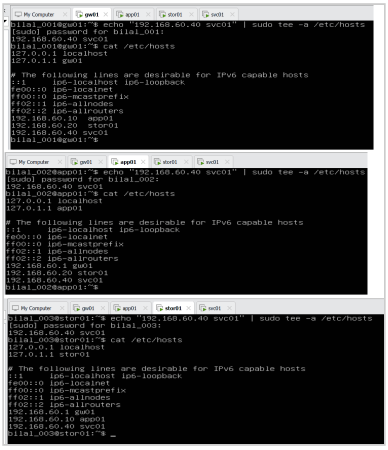
Each machine has its **own** contact list, so the new server must be added to the others, and svc01 must learn the others. A machine never lists itself – it already knows itself as `127.0.1.1`.

Machine	Lists
gw01	app01, stor01, **svc01**
app01	gw01, stor01, **svc01**
stor01	gw01, app01, **svc01**
svc01	gw01, app01, stor01

```
        echo "192.168.60.40 svc01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts      # on gw01, app01, stor01
        echo "192.168.60.1 gw01"    | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts     # on svc01 (one line per echo)
        echo "192.168.60.10 app01"  | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
        echo "192.168.60.20 stor01" | sudo tee -a /etc/hosts
```

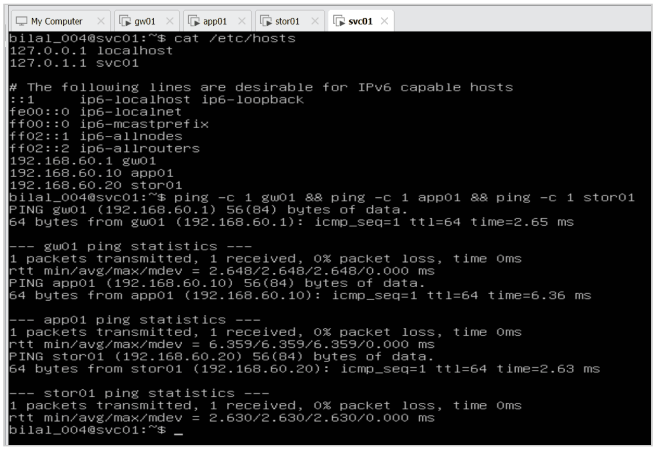
`printf "a\nb\n"` can write several lines in one command because it understands `\n` (new line); plain `echo` does not.

📸 **Evidence – svc01 added on gw01, app01 and stor01:**



hosts on the other three servers

📸 Evidence – svc01's list and ping by name to all three (`ttl=64` = same network, no router in between; `&&` = run the next command only if this one worked):

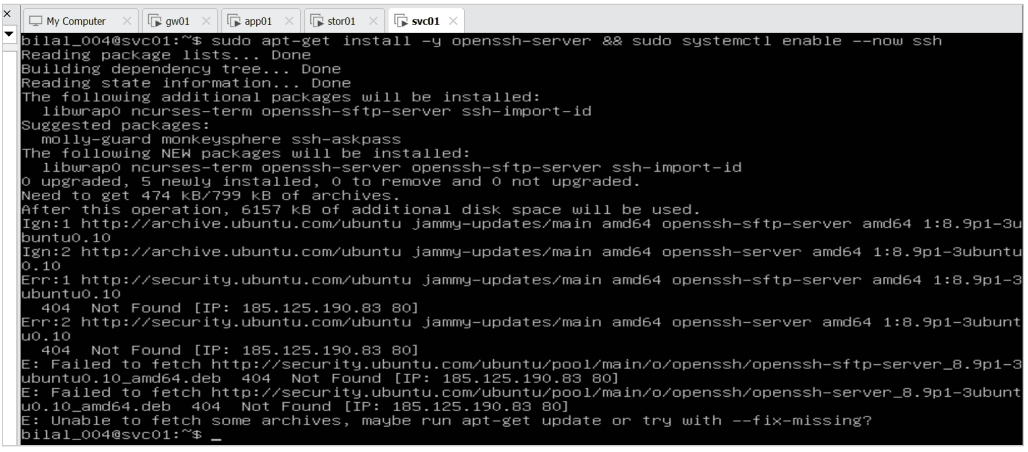


svc01 hosts and ping by name

4.4 SSH: package list out of date

Seen	`apt install openssh-server` fails with **404 Not Found**.
Cause	Not a network problem – the server was reached. The **package list was old**: it asked for a version that has since been replaced, so the file no longer exists.
Fix	`sudo apt update` first, then install.
Lesson	On a fresh server, always run `apt update` before `apt install`.

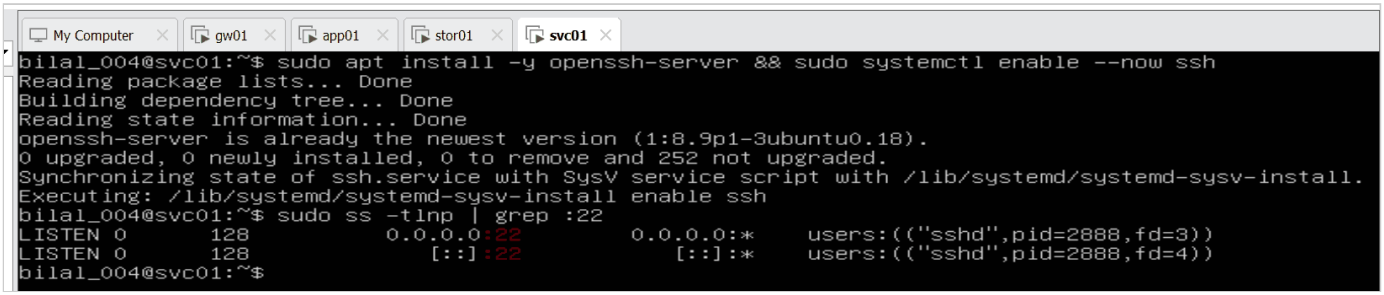
📸 Evidence – the 404 (note `jammy` = Ubuntu 22.04):



apt 404

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install -y openssh-server
sudo systemctl enable --now ssh
sudo ss -tlnp | grep :22
```

📸 Evidence – sshd listening on 0.0.0.0:22 and [::]:22:



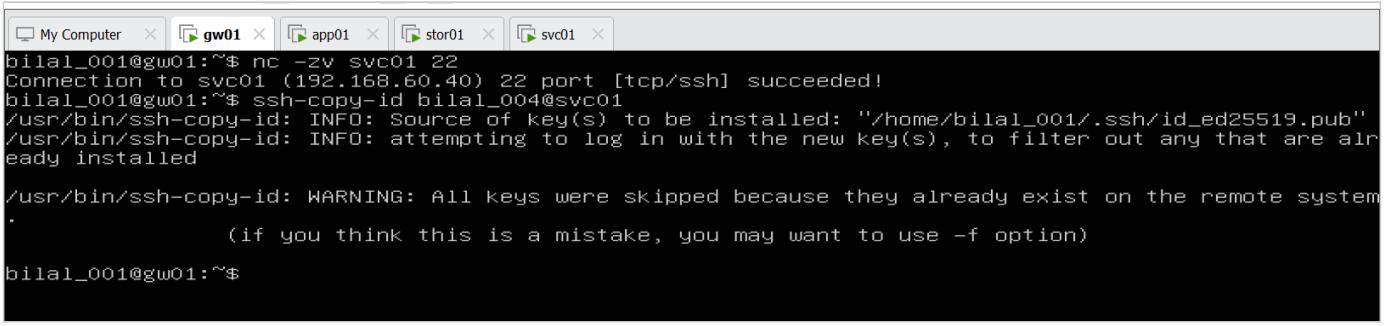
sshd listening

4.5 Key login and shortcut from gw01

```
nc -zv svc01 22                 # door open?
ssh-copy-id bilal_004@svc01     # copy bilal_001's public key
cat >> ~/.ssh/config << 'EOF'
Host svc01
    HostName 192.168.60.40
    User bilal_004
EOF
ssh svc01
```

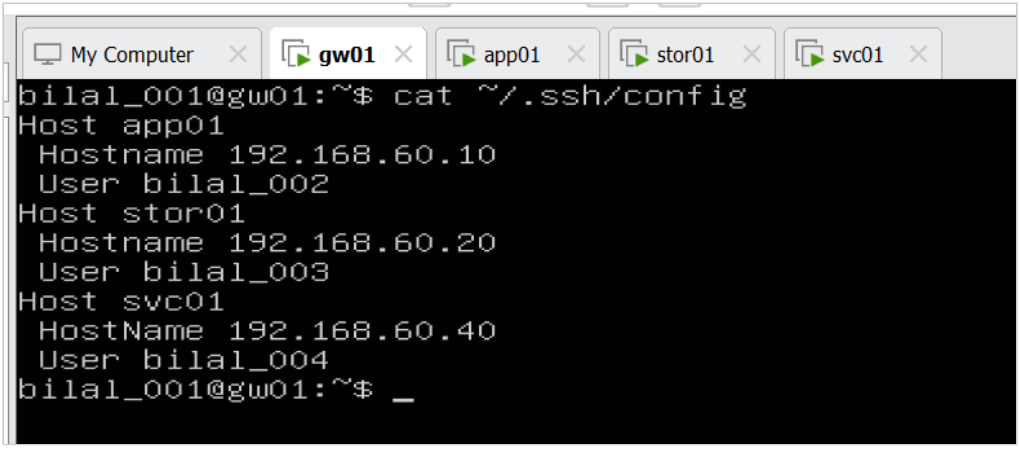
`ssh-copy-id` reported *"All keys were skipped because they already exist on the remote system"* – not an error: it first tests whether the key already works, and it did, so it avoided a duplicate.

📸 **Evidence – port 22 open, key already present:**



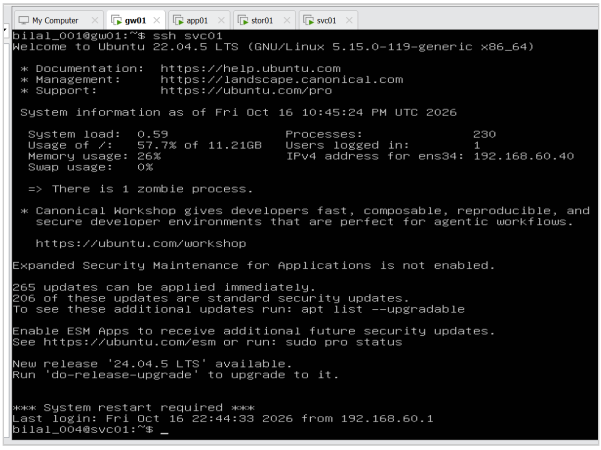
nc and ssh-copy-id

📸 **Evidence – gw01's SSH address book now has app01, stor01 and svc01 (keywords are not case-sensitive: `Hostname` = `HostName`):**



ssh config

📸 **Evidence – `ssh svc01` logs in as bilal_004 without a password:**



ssh svc01

4.6 Read from the welcome screen

Line	Meaning / action
Ubuntu 22.04.5 LTS	Same release as the other servers
Usage of /: 57.7 % of 11.21 GB	The installer used only about 11 GB of the 25 GB disk for the system; the rest is free in the LVM pool → **grow it before Docker** (`lvextend -r -l +100%FREE`)
265 updates, 206 security	Run `sudo apt upgrade -y`
New release 24.04 available	**Not** upgrading – all servers stay on 22.04
1 zombie process	Harmless; gone after reboot (processes are Phase 4)
Times in UTC	Optional: `timedatectl set-timezone Europe/Berlin`, so ticket times match local time
System restart required	Covered by the reboot after the upgrade

Key understanding (in my own words)

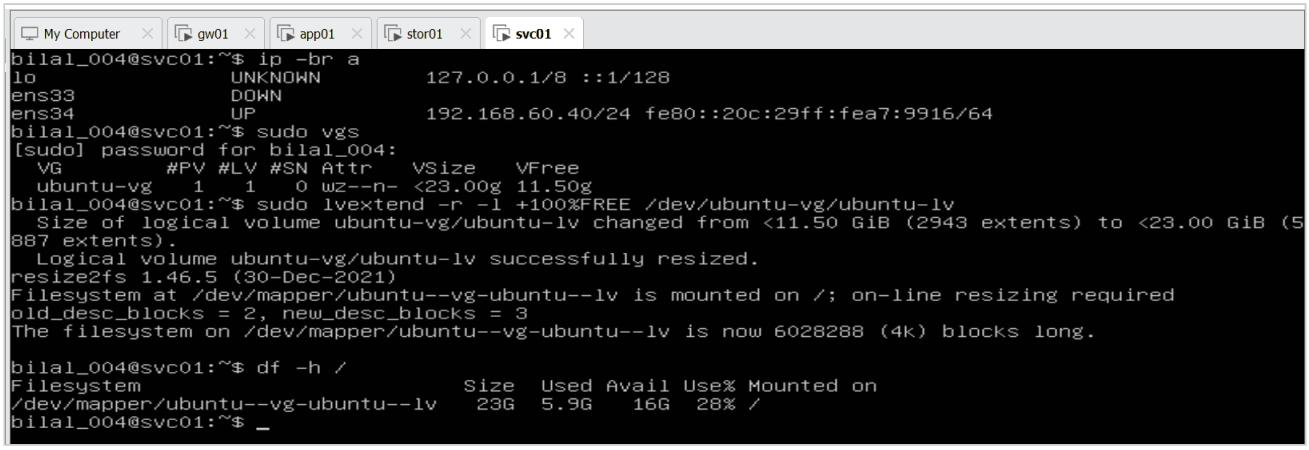
> svc01 joined the lab like app01 and stor01: one card on VMnet2, a fixed address set in netplan, and the default route pointing to gw01. Because gw01 is the only door, svc01 has no internet and no DNS while gw01 is off. Every machine has its own `/etc/hosts`, so a new server must be added to the others' lists and learn theirs. On a fresh server, `apt update` comes before `apt install`. With the key and the SSH shortcut, gw01 now manages all three servers by name, without passwords.

5. Growing the disk before Docker (LVM) – 2026-10-17

💡 **In plain words:** the welcome screen showed the system using only **11.5 GB of the 25 GB disk**. GLPI is about to move in – Docker images, a MySQL database with every ticket, user and inventory record, and ticket attachments – and all of it grows every day. A full disk makes MySQL crash, which would take the service desk itself down: exactly the Acme problem *"disks fill up without warning"*. So the disk was grown **before** installing anything. The system was also fully patched first, because GLPI will open a web service on port 80.

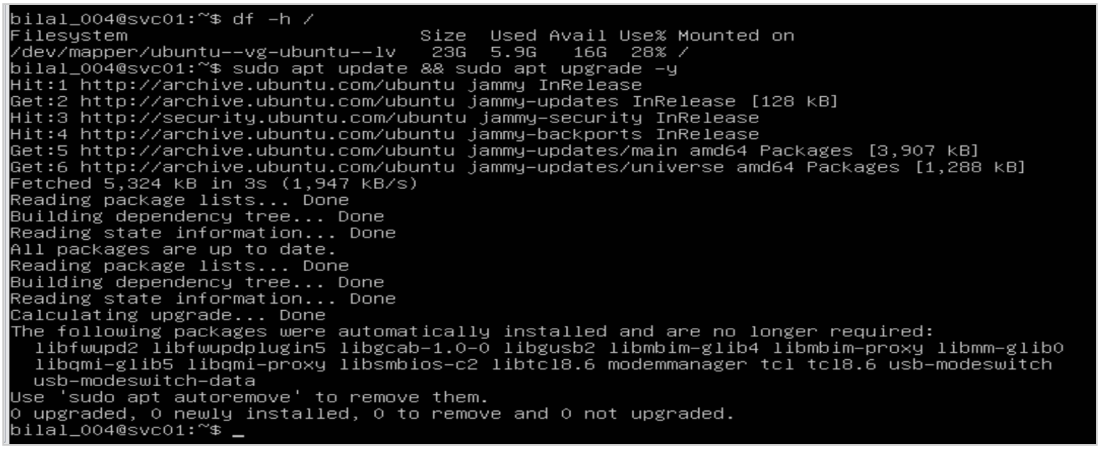
```
        ip -br a                                              # ens34 192.168.60.40 (ens33 = old NAT adapter, to be
removed)
        sudo vgs                                              # the pool: VSize 23 GB, VFree 11.5 GB unused
        sudo lvextend -r -l +100%FREE /dev/ubuntu-vg/ubuntu-lv  # give the volume all free space; -r grows the file
system too
        df -h /                                               # 23 GB, 28 % used
        sudo apt update && sudo apt upgrade -y                # patch before opening a service
```

📸 **Evidence – `vgs` shows 11.5 GB free in the pool; `lvextend` grows the volume from 11.5 to 23 GB while running; `df` shows 23 GB:**



vgs, lvextend, df

📸 Evidence – all packages up to date:

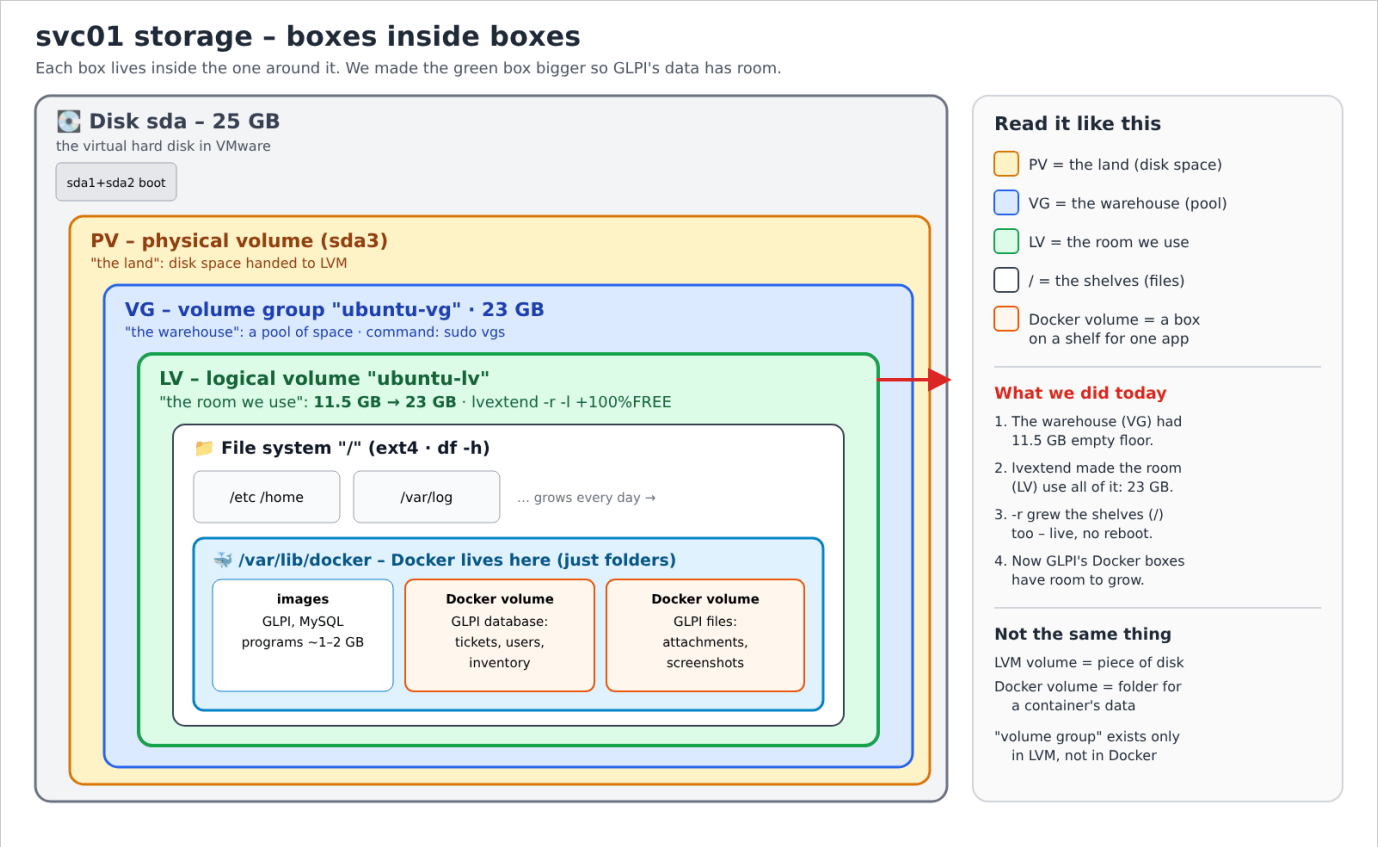


apt upgrade

Reading vgs

Column	Value	Meaning
VG	ubuntu-vg	Name of the pool
#PV	1	Built from 1 physical volume
#LV	1	1 logical volume cut from it
#SN	0	No snapshots
VSize / VFree	23 GB / 11.5 GB	Pool size / part not given to any volume yet

The picture – boxes inside boxes



svc01 storage layers

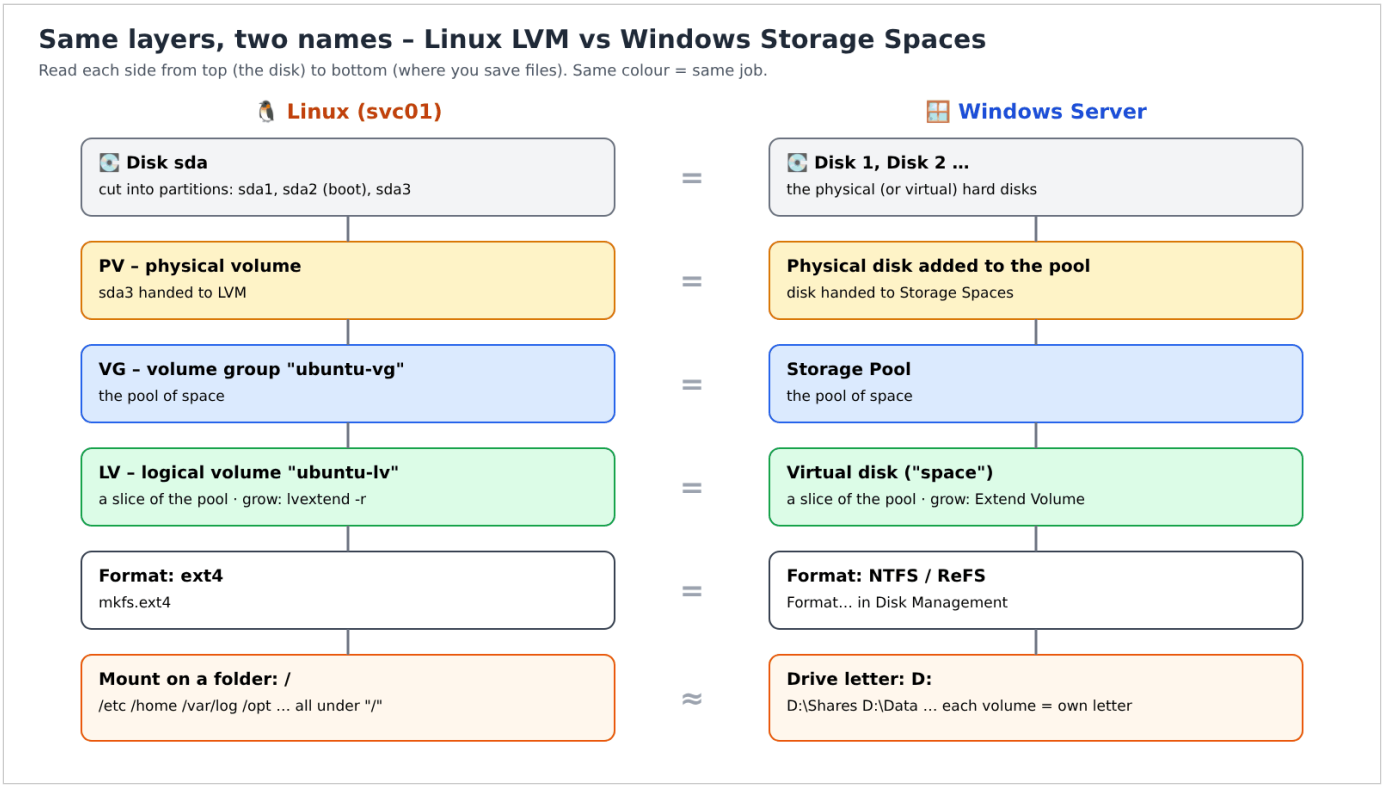
Part of the command	Meaning
`lvextend`	Make a logical volume bigger
`-l +100%FREE`	Small **l**: add all free space of the pool (capital `-L +5G` would add an exact size)
`-r`	Resize the **file system** too – otherwise the volume grows but the space is not usable
`/dev/ubuntu-vg/ubuntu-lv`	Path pattern `/dev/<VG>/<LV>`

Docker: image, container, mounted folder

Word	Simple meaning	Here
Image	The installer – a ready-made program package that never changes	`glpi/glpi`, `mysql:8.0` (kept in `/var/lib/docker`)
Container	The running program made from the image	GLPI and MySQL running
Mounted folder (volume)	A real svc01 folder shown inside the container, where it saves its data	`/opt/helpdesk/storage/mysql` → `/var/lib/mysql` inside MySQL

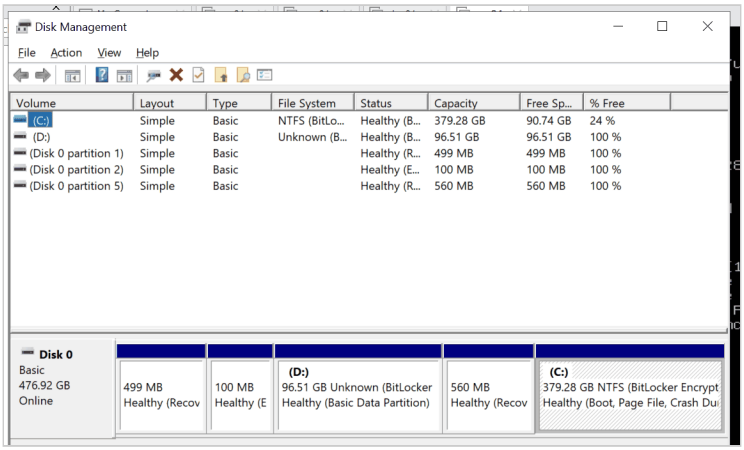
A container is thrown away when it is updated or recreated; data saved in the mounted folder on svc01 survives.

Same layers in Windows



Linux LVM vs Windows Storage Spaces

📸 On my own PC (Disk Management, `diskmgmt.msc`): a “Basic” disk – Disk 0 cut into partitions with drive letters (C:, D:), no pool layer:



Windows Disk Management

Where to look in Windows: **Disk Management** (Win + X) for disks, partitions and letters; **Storage Spaces** (Control Panel, or Server Manager → File and Storage Services → Storage Pools on Windows Server) for pools; PowerShell `Get-Disk`, `Get-Partition`, `Get-Volume`, `Get-StoragePool`.

Key understanding (in my own words)

When I created svc01, I gave it one 25 GB virtual disk, **sda**. A disk can be divided into **partitions**, like C: and D: in Windows. Here, sda1 and sda2 are for booting, and **sda3** (23 GB) is used as a **physical volume (PV)**. On its own, a PV is just raw space. It is never divided: once it is added to a **volume group (VG)**, a pool of space, it belongs to that VG only. One VG can be built from one or several PVs. Here there is one VG, `ubuntu-vg` (23 GB), made from one PV. For a second VG, I would first create another partition on the disk, which becomes its own PV.

Inside a VG I can create many **logical volumes (LVs)**. Here there was one, `ubuntu-lv`, with 11.5 GB, and the other 11.5 GB were free. I could have used the free space for more LVs; separate LVs give **isolation of space**: if one fills up (for example `/var/log` with logs), the others are not affected, and each LV can be grown, backed up or snapshotted on its own. This is about disk space, not security; data is protected by permissions, firewalls and encryption. On svc01 I chose to grow the single LV to the full 23 GB with `lvextend -r -l +100%FREE` while the system was running, and `-r` grew the file system too.

An LV is only usable once it is **formatted** (ext4) and **mounted**; this one is mounted as `/`, the umbrella for every folder (`/etc`, `/home`, `/var/log`, `/var/lib/docker`, `/opt`).

The same idea in Windows: physical disks (≈ PVs) are added to a **Storage Pool** (≈ VG) in Storage Spaces. The pool is cut into **virtual disks** (≈ LVs), which are formatted with NTFS or ReFS (≈ ext4) and given a

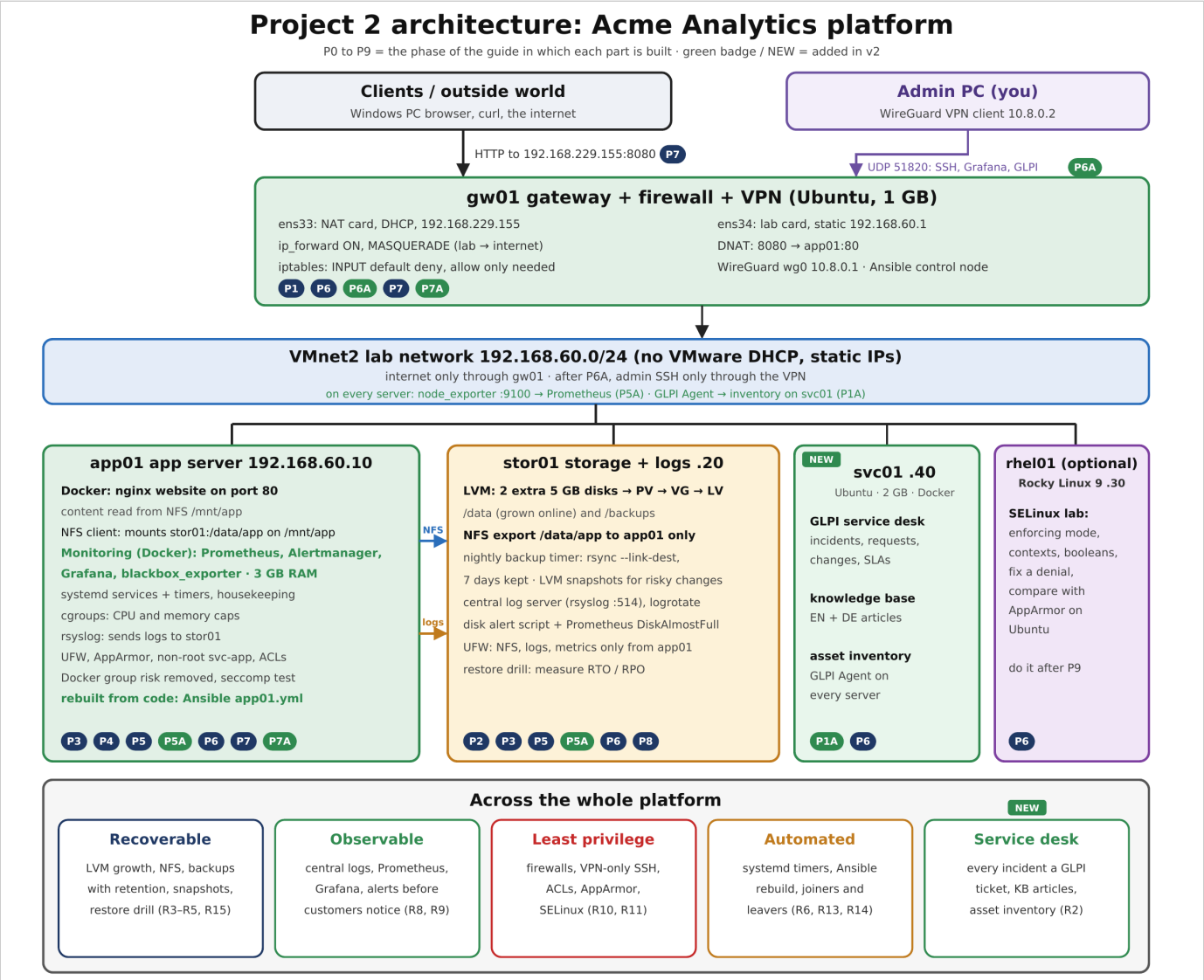
drive letter such as D: (≈ mounting). Extend Volume in Disk Management grows a volume live, like `lvextend -r`. Linux uses one folder tree under `/`, while Windows uses drive letters, but the layers are the same: disk → pool → volume → file system → mount point. On a normal PC like mine the disk is “Basic”: only partitions with drive letters, no pool – storage pools are used on servers with several disks.

For the service desk, Docker takes **images** (the installers for GLPI and MySQL) and runs them as **containers**. Their data is saved in **mounted folders** on svc01, for example `/opt/helpdesk/storage/mysql`, which appears inside MySQL as `/var/lib/mysql`. So tickets, users and inventory stay safe on `/` even if a container is deleted or upgraded, and that is why I grew the disk before installing GLPI.

6. The network story – from the first picture to today

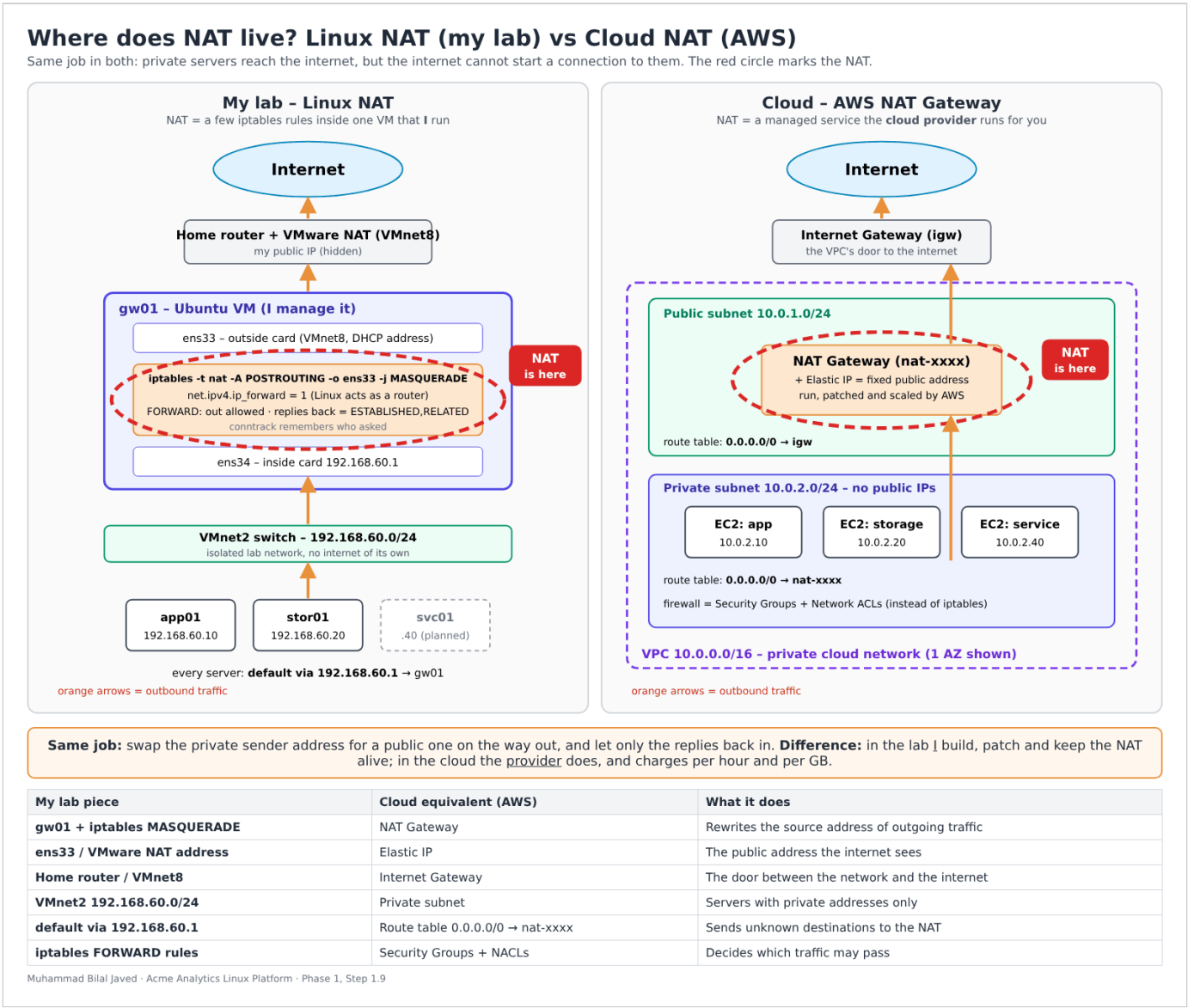
💡 **Read this section alone and you have the whole network in your head – no need to go back to Day 1.**

Picture 1 – the plan. Acme gets four servers on one private lab network, and one gatekeeper (gw01) between that network and the internet.



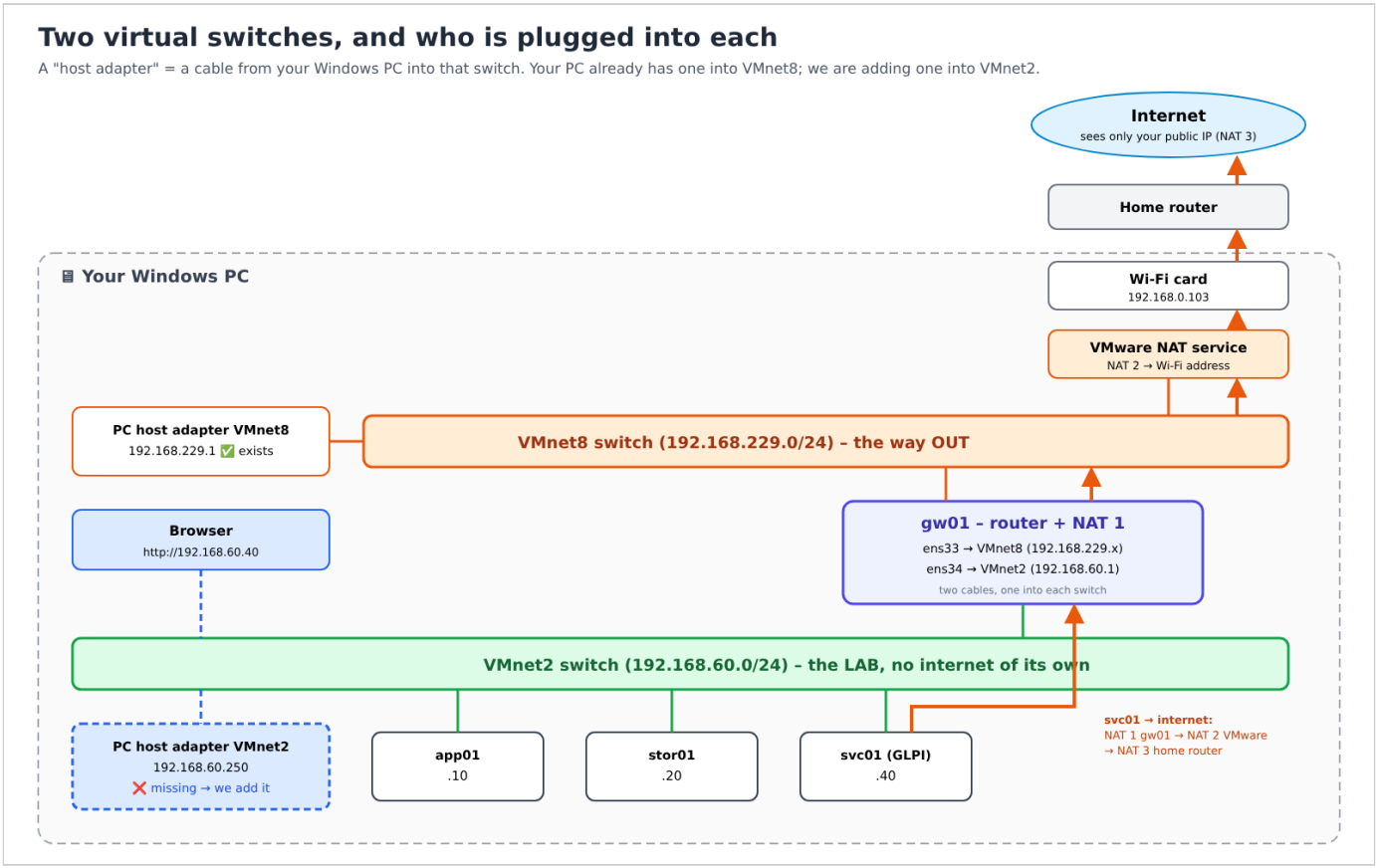
Project architecture

Picture 2 – the gatekeeper (Phase 1). In the beginning every VM had its own NAT card straight to the internet. That is easy but unsafe: nobody controls the traffic. So the servers’ outside cards were removed. Only **gw01** keeps two cards: **ens33** towards VMware’s **VMnet8** (the way out) and **ens34** = `192.168.60.1` on **VMnet2** (the lab). With IP forwarding and an iptables MASQUERADE rule, gw01 became a router with NAT – the same job a cloud NAT gateway does.



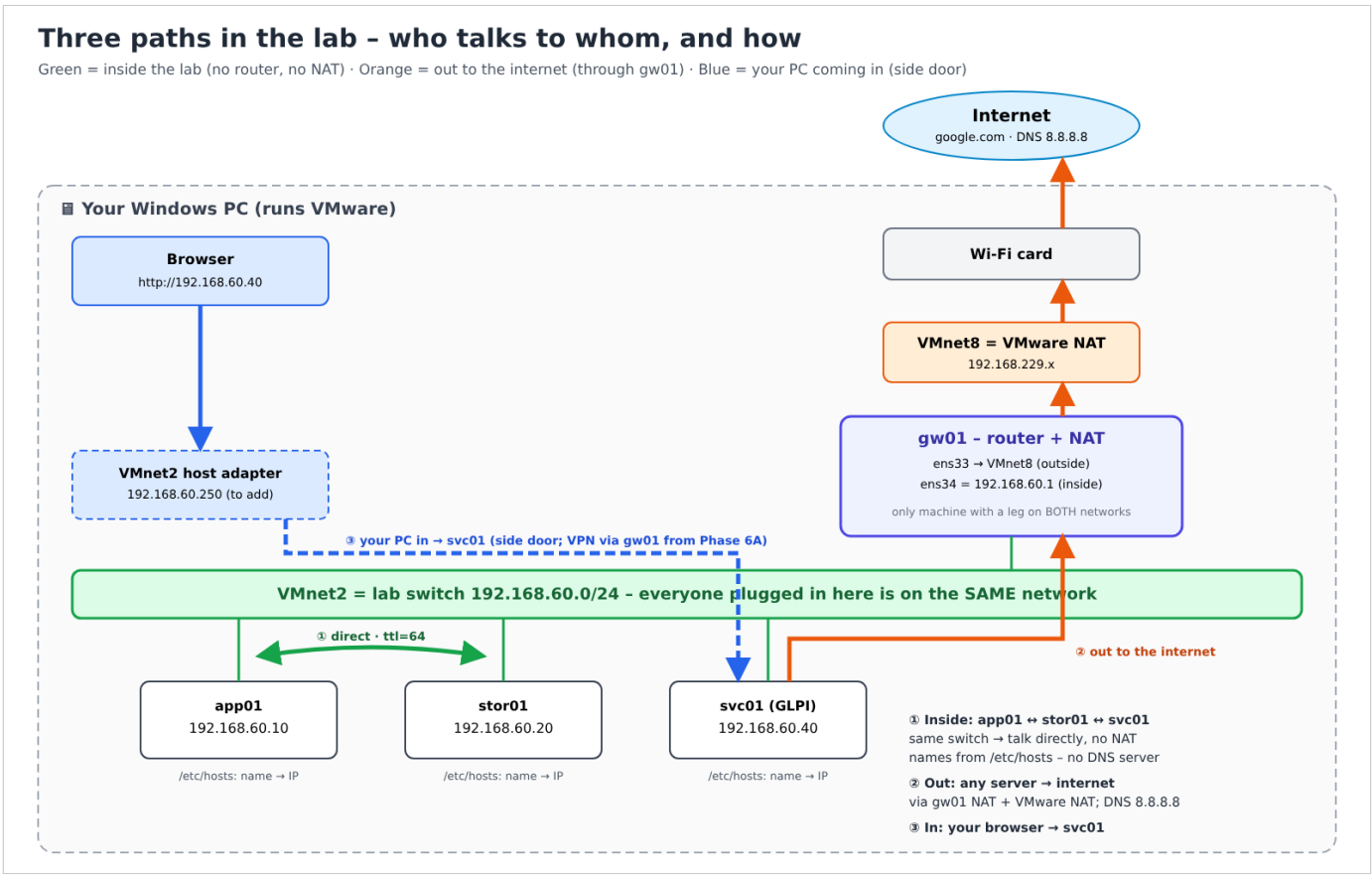
Linux NAT vs cloud NAT

Picture 3 – two virtual switches. VMware builds switches in software. **VMnet2** is the lab switch: app01, stor01, svc01 and gw01's inside card are plugged into it, so they talk to each other **directly** (no router, no NAT – `ttl=64`); `/etc/hosts` only turns their names into IPs. **VMnet8** is the way out: only gw01's outside card is plugged into it. A *host adapter* is a cable from my Windows PC into one switch – it already had one into VMnet8, but **none into VMnet2**.



Two switches and the host adapters

Picture 4 – three paths. ① **Inside:** server ↔ server over VMnet2, directly. ② **Out:** a server → gw01 (**NAT 1**, to gw01's VMnet8 address) → VMware NAT (**NAT 2**, to my Wi-Fi card's address) → home router (**NAT 3**, to my public IP) → internet. DNS (8.8.8.8) is on the internet too, so name lookups for google.com take the same path – that is why nothing worked while gw01 was off. ③ **In:** my browser → svc01. This needs my PC on the lab switch, so the **VMnet2 host adapter** is added with the free address `192.168.60.250` (not .1 – that is gw01). It is a local side door for this one PC, not a VPN; in **Phase 6A** it is replaced by a WireGuard VPN through gw01 – the way a real remote worker comes in.



Three paths in the lab

Why today: GLPI now runs on svc01 and answers `200 OK` from svc01 itself and from gw01. To use the service desk in a browser, my PC needs path ③.

How names are found (two places, in order – `hosts: files dns` in `/etc/nsswitch.conf`):

Order	Where Linux looks	Lab names (stor01)	Internet names (google.com)
1	`/etc/hosts` (local list)	✅ found here	❌ not there
2	DNS via the helper 127.0.0.53 → 8.8.8.8	❌ no DNS server knows the lab	✅ found here (and cached)

Switch, router, bridge:

Device	Like	In the lab
Switch	an extension board – devices on the same network plug in and talk directly	VMnet2 (lab board), VMnet8 (way-out board)
Router	a person between two boards passing messages across	gw01 – one card on each board
Bridge (VMware "Bridged")	plugging a VM straight into the home network	not used – the lab stays separate

Network adapter (VMware) = `ens34` / `ens33` (Linux) = network card (NIC) – one thing, three names.

> **Key understanding (in my own words).** Every server has a network card. VMware calls it a "Network Adapter". Inside Linux the card is called `ens34` or `ens33`.
>
> A virtual switch is like an extension board. VMnet2 is the lab board. VMnet8 is the board for the way out.
>
> app01, stor01 and svc01 are plugged into VMnet2. gw01 is also plugged into VMnet2 with its inside card. All of them have an address in the same network. So they talk to each other directly by IP. This worked from the first day.
>
> To use names, Linux looks in two places. First it checks `/etc/hosts`. Then it asks DNS. Our lab names are written in `/etc/hosts`, so they are found in the first place. Internet names like google.com are not in `/etc/hosts`. So Linux asks DNS. The helper 127.0.0.53 forwards the question to 8.8.8.8 and keeps the answer in a cache.
>
> For the internet, the servers send their traffic to gw01. gw01 has a second card on VMnet8. The address is changed three times on the way out. First gw01 changes it to its own address on VMnet8. Then VMware's NAT changes it to my Wi-Fi card's address. Then my home router changes it to my public IP. The DNS question to 8.8.8.8 also takes this way. So nothing on the internet works while gw01 is off.
>
> My Windows PC had a card on VMnet8 but no card on VMnet2. So my browser could not reach svc01. Now I give my PC a card on VMnet2 with the tick "Connect a host virtual adapter". The card gets the address 192.168.60.250. My browser can now open GLPI on svc01 directly. Nothing changes for the servers.

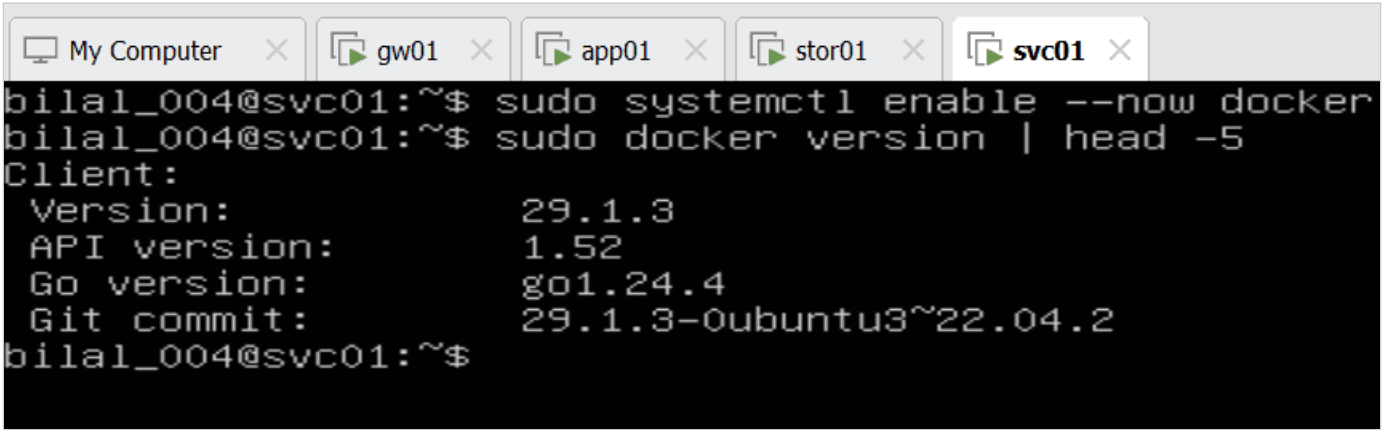
7. Step 1A.2 – Docker and GLPI running, opened in the browser

💡 **In plain words:** GLPI and its MySQL database run as two **containers** on svc01, described in one small file (`compose.yaml`). Their data lives in folders on svc01, so it survives updates. Then my Windows PC got a plug on the lab switch so the browser can open GLPI.

7.1 Install Docker

```
sudo apt update && sudo apt install -y docker.io docker-compose-v2   # Docker engine + "docker compose"
sudo systemctl enable --now docker                                   # start now and at every boot
sudo docker version | head -5
```

📸 **Evidence – Docker 29.1.3 installed:**



docker version

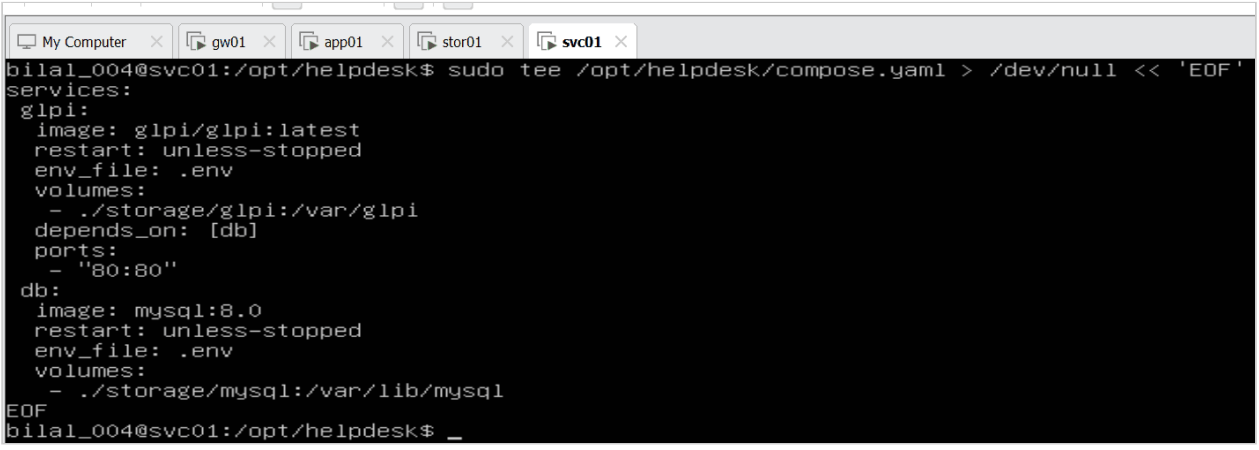
7.2 Settings file and compose file

```
sudo mkdir -p /opt/helpdesk && cd /opt/helpdesk
sudo tee /opt/helpdesk/.env > /dev/null << 'EOF'
GLPI_DB_HOST=db
GLPI_DB_PORT=3306
GLPI_DB_NAME=glpi
GLPI_DB_USER=glpi
GLPI_DB_PASSWORD=<lab-db-password>
MYSQL_RANDOM_ROOT_PASSWORD=yes
MYSQL_DATABASE=glpi
MYSQL_USER=glpi
MYSQL_PASSWORD=<lab-db-password>
EOF
sudo chmod 600 /opt/helpdesk/.env       # passwords inside — only root may read it
```

The real password is not published here; the `.env` file stays on svc01 only.

```
# /opt/helpdesk/compose.yaml — which containers to run
services:
  glpi:
    image: glpi/glpi:latest          # the GLPI installer (image)
    restart: unless-stopped          # start again after a crash or reboot
    env_file: .env
    volumes:
      - ./storage/glpi:/var/glpi     # svc01 folder shown inside the container
    depends_on: [db]                 # start the database first
    ports:
      - "80:80"                      # svc01 port 80 → container port 80
  db:
    image: mysql:8.0
    restart: unless-stopped
    env_file: .env
    volumes:
      - ./storage/mysql:/var/lib/mysql
```

📸 **Evidence – the compose file:**



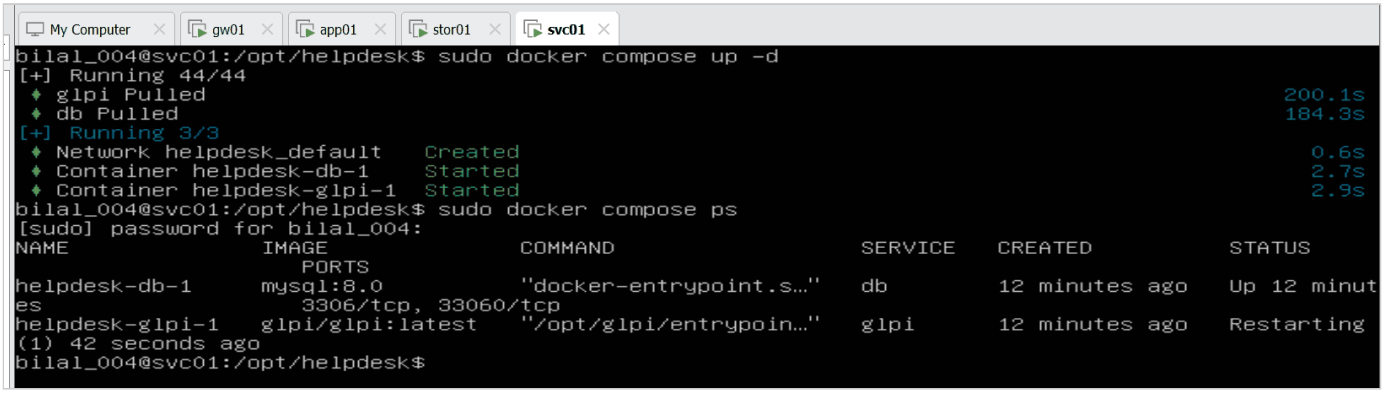
compose.yaml

Lesson – YAML is strict. My first attempts failed: `Services:` instead of `services:` (keywords are lowercase), `glpi:Latest` instead of `latest` (the tag is case-sensitive), `mysql: 8.0` with a space (YAML reads it as a new key → *"mapping values are not allowed"*), and `var/glpi` without the leading `/`. Check a file before starting it: `sudo docker compose config --quiet && echo "YAML OK"`.

7.3 Start – and the permission problem

```
sudo docker compose up -d      # download images, create network, start both containers
sudo docker compose ps
```

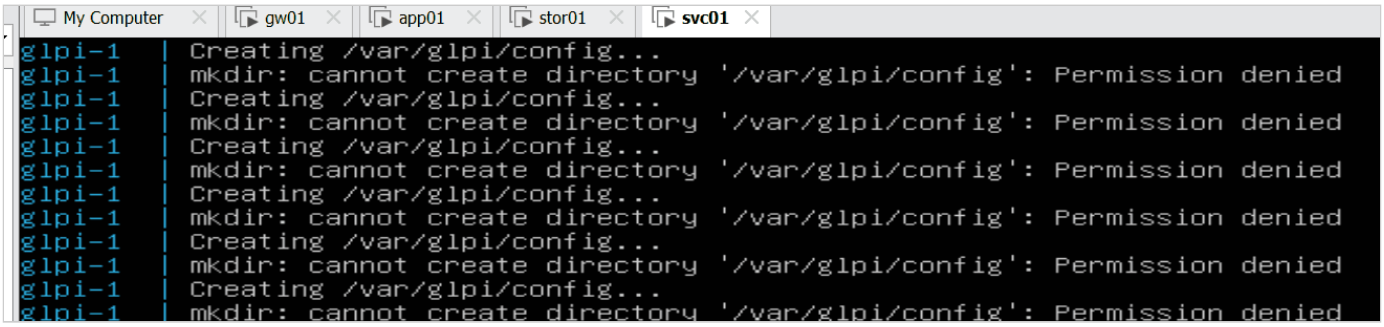
📸 **Evidence – images pulled (~3 min), db "Up", but glpi "Restarting (1)":**



compose up, glpi restarting

Seen	`glpi` keeps restarting with exit code 1.
Read the log	`sudo docker compose logs glpi --tail 40` → *mkdir: cannot create directory '/var/glpi/config': Permission denied*
Cause	Docker created the folder `storage/glpi` on svc01 as **root**. Inside the container GLPI runs as **www-data (user ID 33)**, which may not write there.
Fix	Give the folder to user 33.
Lesson	When a container restarts in a loop, read its logs first – they name the cause. File permissions (Step 1.8) also apply across the container boundary.

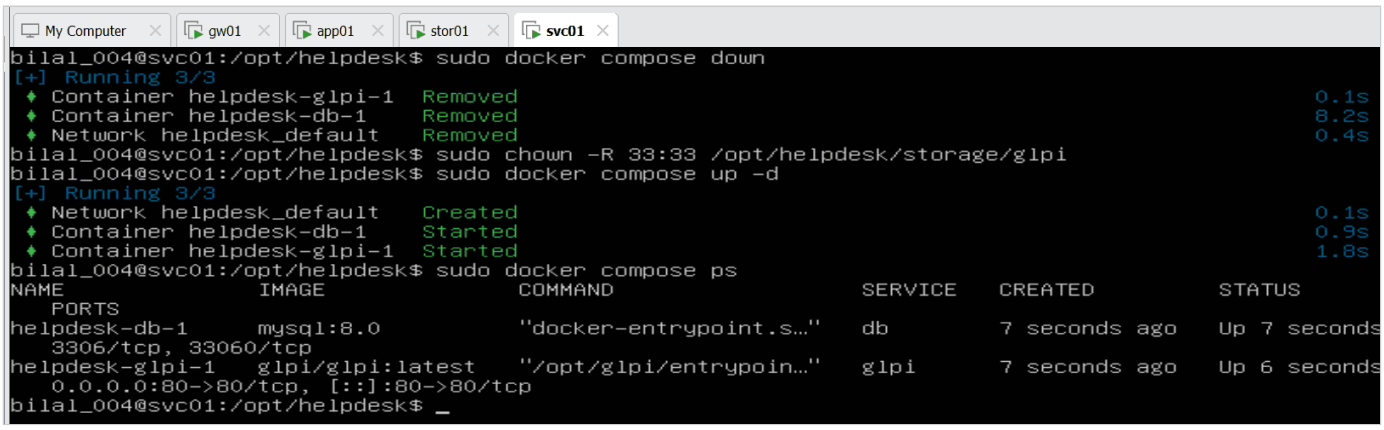
📸 **Evidence – the log:**



permission denied

```
sudo docker compose down
sudo chown -R 33:33 /opt/helpdesk/storage/glpi    # 33 = www-data inside the container
sudo docker compose up -d
sudo docker compose ps
```

📸 **Evidence – both containers "Up"; port 0.0.0.0:80 → 80:**

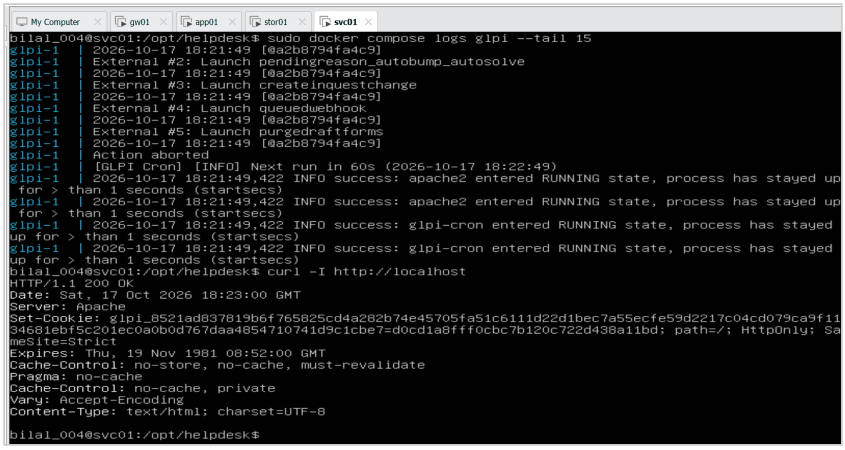


glpi up

7.4 Test from svc01 and from gw01

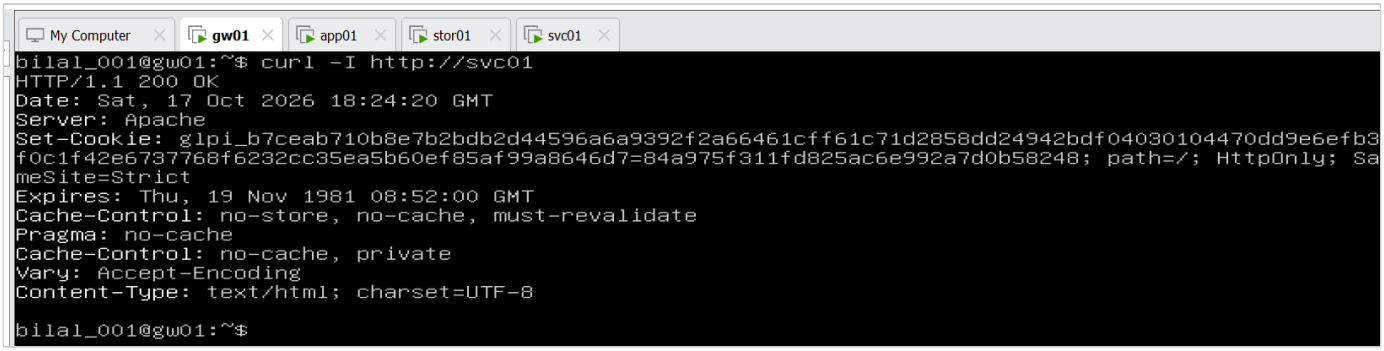
```
sudo docker compose logs glpi --tail 15   # apache2 and glpi-cron "RUNNING"
curl -I http://localhost                   # on svc01
curl -I http://svc01                       # on gw01 — name from /etc/hosts
```

📸 **Evidence – Apache and GLPI cron running; `HTTP/1.1 200 OK` on svc01:**



glpi running, 200

📸 Evidence – `200 OK` from gw01 over the lab network:



gw01 curl 200

HTTP status codes – the server's short answer:

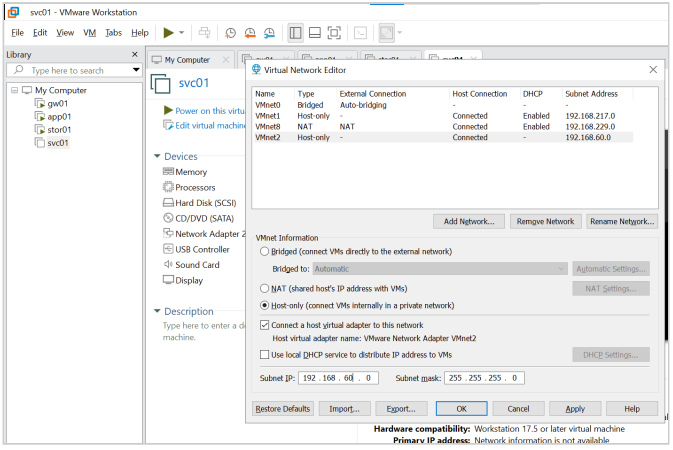
Family	Meaning	Examples
2xx	Success	**200 OK** – page delivered
3xx	Redirect	301 moved for good · 302 go to login first
4xx	Client error – look at the request or permissions	401 log in first · 403 forbidden · 404 not found
5xx	Server error – look at the logs, database, disk	500 app crashed · 502 bad gateway · 503 unavailable

7.5 My PC on the lab switch – the VMnet2 host adapter

`ipconfig` on Windows showed adapters for VMnet1 and VMnet8 but **none for VMnet2**, so the browser could not reach 192.168.60.40 (`ping` timed out). The Virtual Network Editor needs administrator rights (**Change Settings**); VMnet2 was not even listed, so it was added.

Setting (VMnet2)	Value	Why
Type	Host-only	Private lab network, no NAT of its own
Connect a host virtual adapter	✅	Gives the Windows PC a plug on VMnet2
Use local DHCP	☐ off	Servers have fixed addresses
Subnet	192.168.60.0 / 255.255.255.0	The lab network

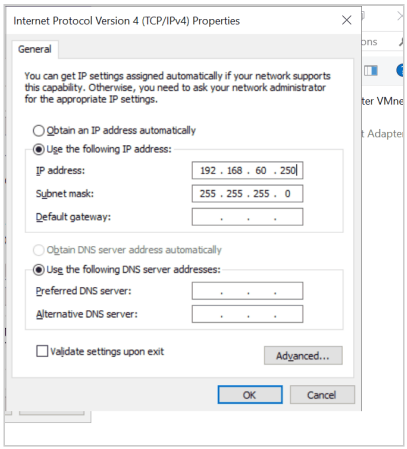
📸 Evidence – VMnet2 in the Virtual Network Editor:



VMnet2 host adapter

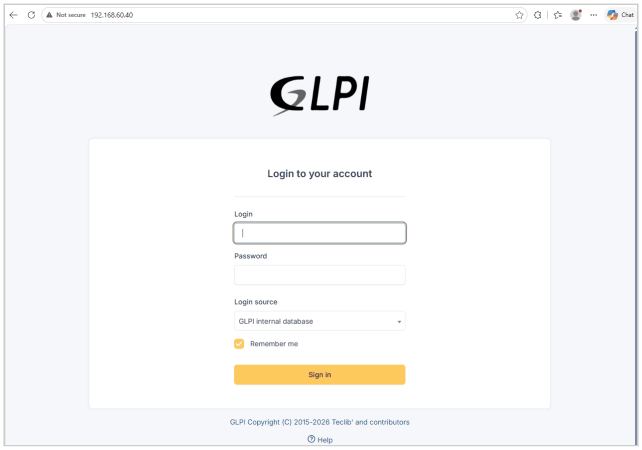
VMware gives the new adapter `192.168.60.1` – gw01's address – so it was set by hand to **192.168.60.250**, mask 255.255.255.0, **no gateway and no DNS** (the internet must keep using Wi-Fi; this is only a side door into the lab).

📸 **Evidence – Windows adapter VMnet2 set to 192.168.60.250:**



ncpa VMnet2 IPv4

📸 **Evidence – GLPI login page in the browser at http://192.168.60.40 ("Not secure" = plain HTTP, fine inside the lab):**

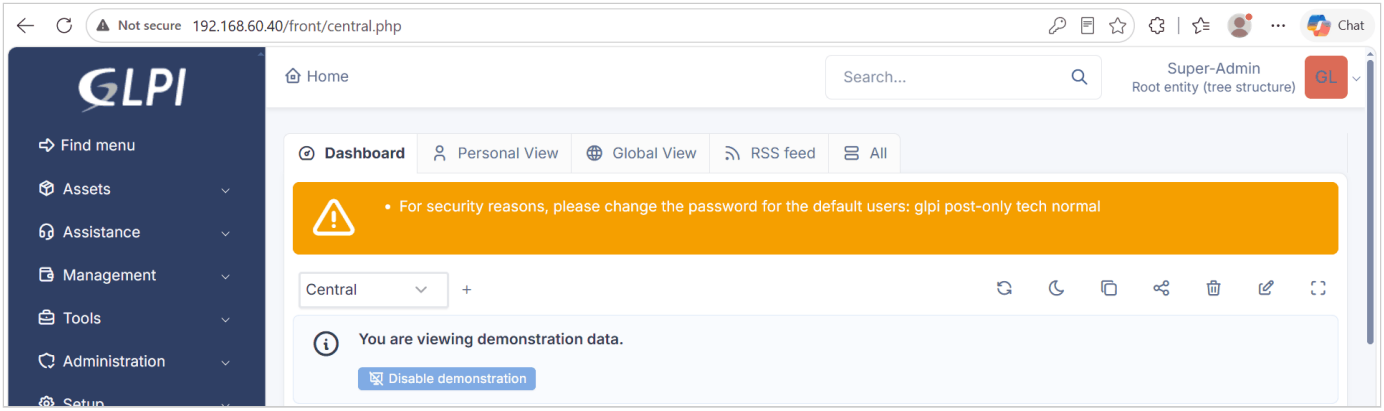


GLPI login

7.6 First login and default passwords

GLPI ships with four accounts whose passwords everybody knows: `glpi` (super-admin), `tech`, `normal`, `post-only`. GLPI shows a warning until they are changed.

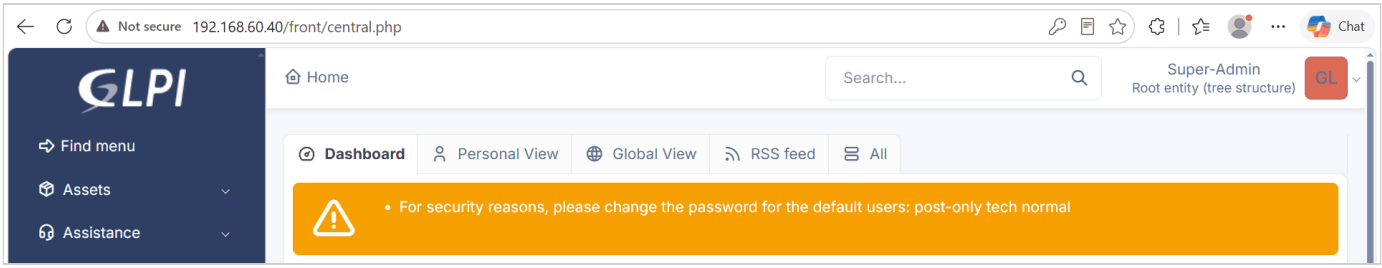
📸 **Evidence – first login as Super-Admin with the warning (the numbers are GLPI demonstration data, not mine – "Disable demonstration" removes them):**



first login

Administration → Users → `glpi` → **Change password** → **Save** (the form shows "Password change pending" until Save is clicked).

📸 **Evidence – `glpi` no longer in the warning; `tech`, `normal`, `post-only` to be disabled next:**



glpi password changed

Key understanding (in my own words)

> GLPI runs on svc01 as two containers – the GLPI web application and its MySQL database – described in one `compose.yaml`. Their data is kept in folders on svc01, so it survives updates. The first start failed because GLPI runs inside the container as user 33 and could not write to a folder owned by root; the container log showed it, and `chown 33:33` fixed it. GLPI then answered `200 OK` on svc01 and from gw01. My Windows PC had no plug on the lab switch, so I added a VMnet2 host adapter with the free address 192.168.60.250 and opened GLPI in the browser. The default passwords are being changed first, because everybody knows them.

8. Step 1A.4 – GLPI agent: automatic asset inventory – 2026-10-17

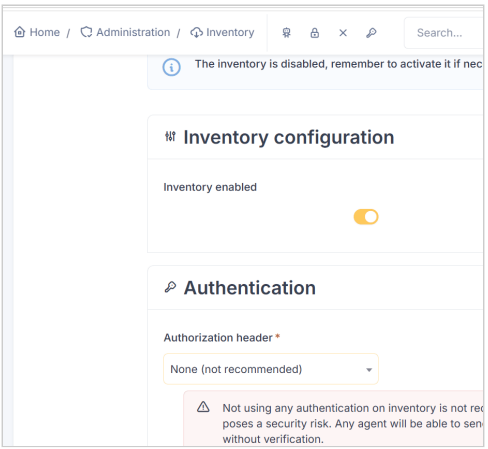
💡 **In plain words:** a small program, the **GLPI agent**, now runs on every server. Once a day it collects what the machine is made of – hardware, operating system, serial number, installed software, network cards – and sends it to GLPI on svc01. So the asset list fills itself and stays up to date; nobody types it in. The agent is not a person and creates no tickets. (The guide puts Step 1A.4 after 1A.3; I did the inventory first because it only needs GLPI running.)

8.1 Switch the inventory on in GLPI

Administration → Inventory → **Inventory enabled** → Authorization header → **Save**.

Setting	Value	Why
Inventory enabled	On	GLPI accepts reports from agents
Authorization header	**None (not recommended)**	svc01 is only on the private lab network – only the 4 servers and my PC can reach it. Keeps the first test simple.
Risk	Any machine on the network could send a fake inventory	Acceptable inside the lab
To do – Phase 6 (hardening)	Switch to **Basic Authentication**; re-run the agents with `--user` and `--password`	Before → after for the security report

📸 **Evidence – inventory enabled, no authentication (GLPI shows the warning itself):**



inventory enabled

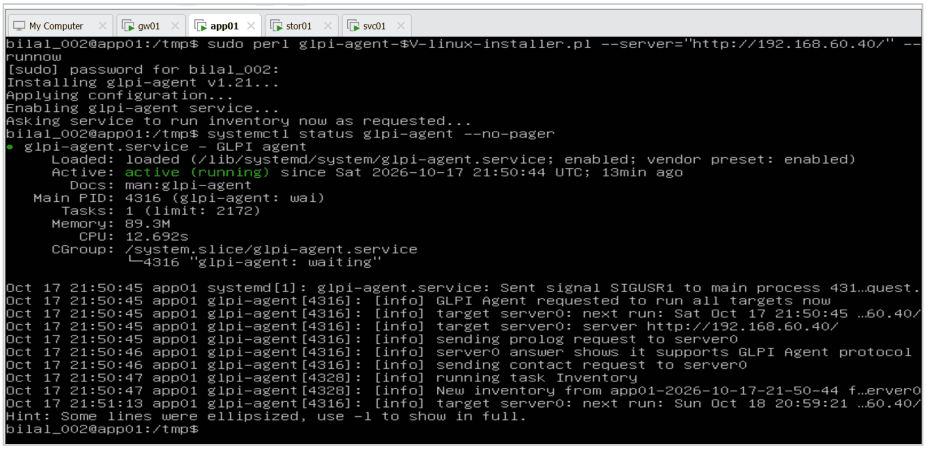
8.2 Install the agent on every server

The same commands on app01, stor01, svc01 and gw01:

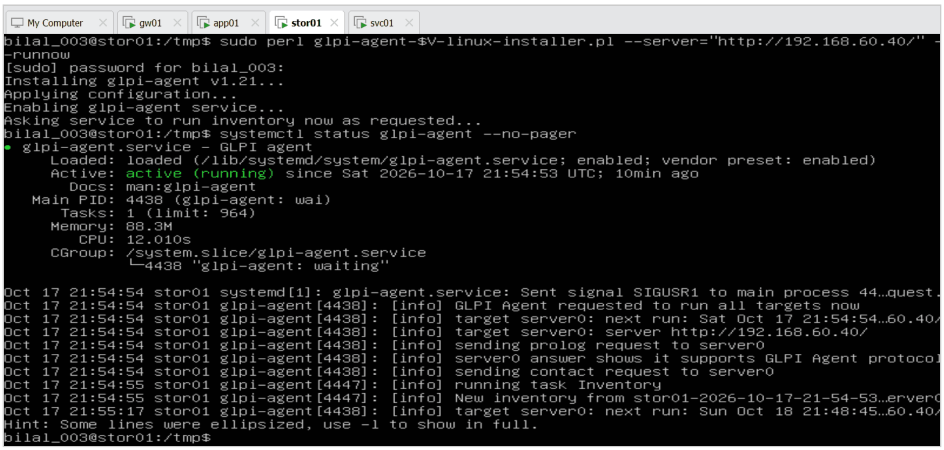
```
cd /tmp && V=1.21                                          # agent version
wget https://github.com/glpi-project/glpi-agent/releases/download/$V/glpi-agent-$V-linux-installer.pl
sudo perl glpi-agent-$V-linux-installer.pl --server="http://192.168.60.40/" --runnow
#   --server = where GLPI lives (svc01)   --runnow = send the first inventory immediately
systemctl status glpi-agent --no-pager                     # service running, enabled at boot
```

What a good run looks like in the log: *prolog request → server answer shows it supports GLPI Agent protocol → running task Inventory →* **New inventory from <server>**. The agent then waits and reports again about once a day (*next run: …*).

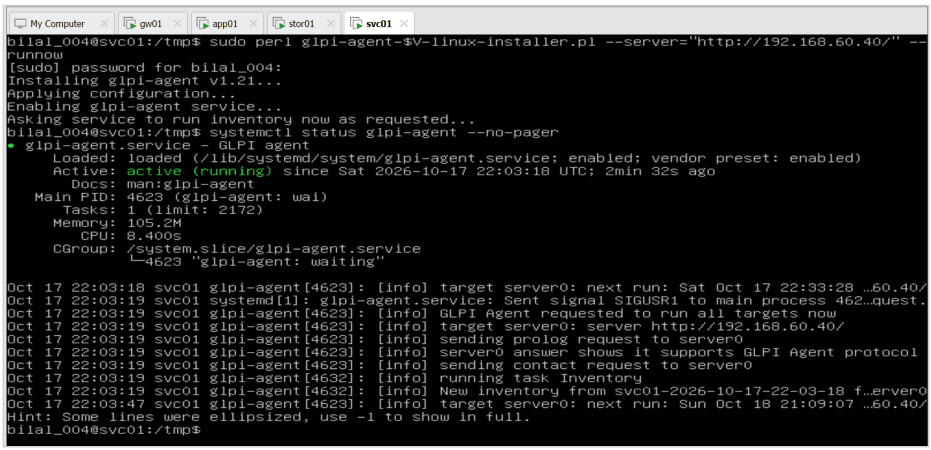
📸 **Evidence – app01, stor01 and svc01 sent their first inventory:**



app01 agent



stor01 agent

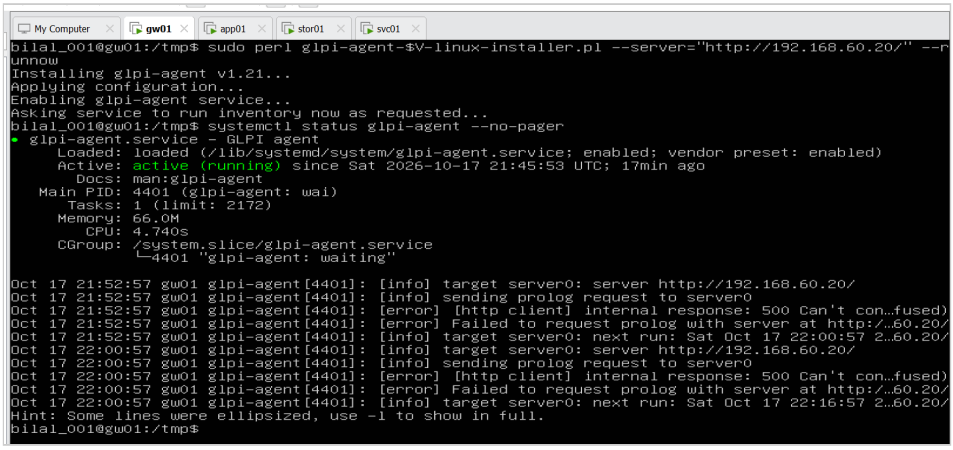


svc01 agent

8.3 Issue – gw01 sent to the wrong address

Seen	On gw01: `[error] [http client] internal response: 500 Can't connect … refused` – *Failed to request prolog with server at http://192.168.60.20/*
Cause	I typed `--server="http://192.168.60.20/"`. **.20 is stor01**, which has no web server; GLPI is on **.40** (svc01).
How the log helped	*Connection refused* = the agent reached a machine, but nothing listened on that port. So the first thing to check is the address.
Fix	Correct the address in the agent's settings file, restart, send the inventory now.

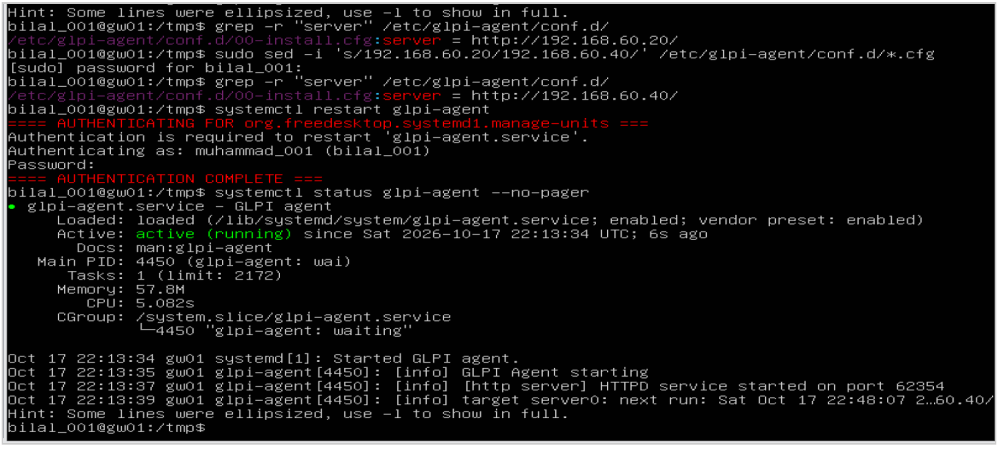
📸 **Evidence – the error:**



gw01 wrong server

```
        grep -r "server" /etc/glpi-agent/conf.d/                                    # shows server = http://
192.168.60.20/
        sudo sed -i 's/192.168.60.20/192.168.60.40/' /etc/glpi-agent/conf.d/*.cfg   # .20 → .40
        grep -r "server" /etc/glpi-agent/conf.d/                                    # check: now .40
        sudo systemctl restart glpi-agent                                           # load the new setting
        sudo glpi-agent --force                                                     # send the inventory now, don't wait
```

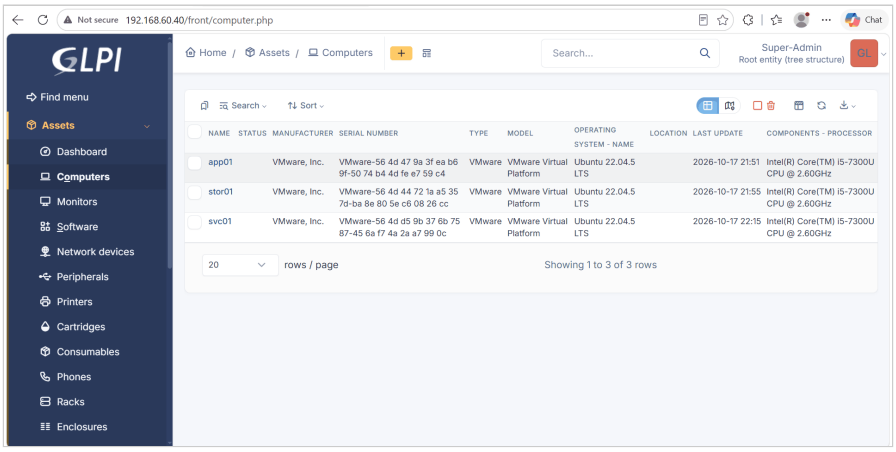
📸 Evidence – setting changed to .40, agent restarted:



gw01 fixed

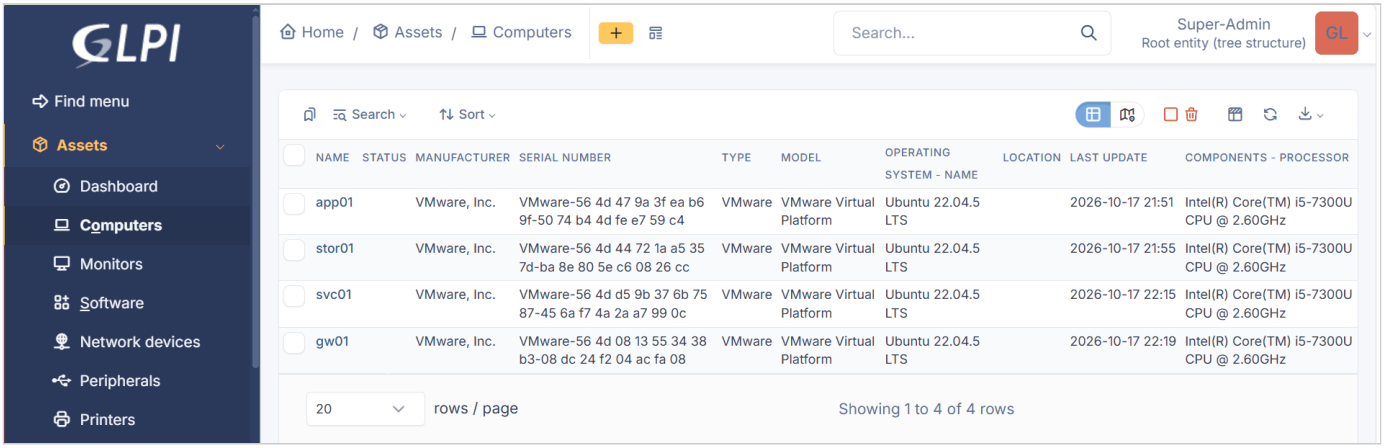
8.4 The result – Assets → Computers

📸 Evidence – first 3 of 4 (gw01 still missing):



3 computers

📸 Evidence – all 4 servers, after `glpi-agent --force` on gw01:



4 computers

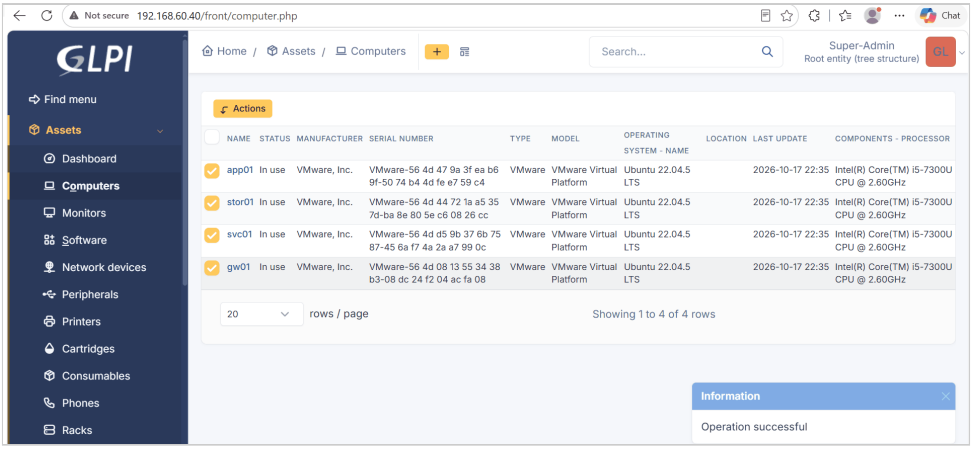
Filled by the agent (automatic)	Filled by a person
Manufacturer / model – *VMware Virtual Platform* (so GLPI knows they are VMs)	**Status** – is the machine in use, in stock, broken?
Serial number – each VM's unique ID	**Location** – where it is
Operating system – Ubuntu 22.04.5 LTS	(later: owner, group, contract)
Processor – my PC's i5-7300U, shared by the VMs	
Last update – when the agent last reported	

The agent can only know facts it can read from the machine. Business facts are added by people – and the agent's daily report does not overwrite them.

8.5 Status and location for all 4 at once

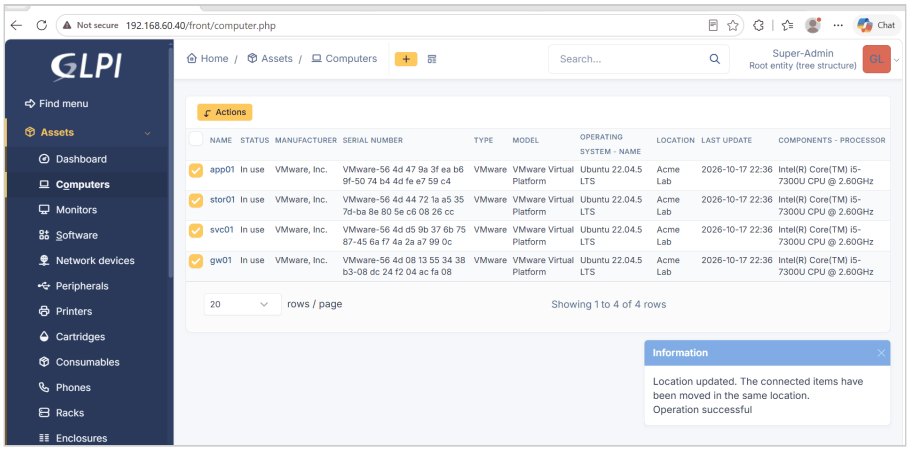
1. Setup → Dropdowns → **Common** → *Statuses of items* → **+** → `In use`; *Locations* → **+** → `Acme Lab`.
2. Assets → Computers → tick all 4 → **Actions → Update** → *Status* → In use → **Post**; again for *Location* → Acme Lab.

📸 **Evidence – Status "In use" on all 4 ("Operation successful"):**



status in use

📸 **Evidence – Location "Acme Lab" on all 4:**



location acme lab

8.6 Snapshots

All four VMs shut down with `sudo poweroff` (gw01 last – it is the router), then:

VM	Snapshot	Description
gw01	`25-service-desk-gw01`	GLPI agent installed, reports to svc01 (.40)
app01	`25-service-desk-app01`	GLPI agent installed, reports to svc01
stor01	`25-service-desk-stor01`	GLPI agent installed, reports to svc01
svc01	`25-service-desk-svc01`	GLPI + MySQL in Docker, inventory on, 4 computers In use / Acme Lab; default accounts still active

No risk overnight: the VMs are off, and GLPI is only on the private lab network. If this snapshot is ever restored, the default accounts must be disabled again.

Key understanding (in my own words)

> The GLPI agent is a small program on each server. It reads the machine's hardware, operating system, serial number and software and sends this to GLPI on svc01 at 192.168.60.40, about once a day. So the asset list fills itself and stays correct. I switched the inventory on in GLPI without authentication, which is fine inside the private lab; in Phase 6 I will add Basic Authentication. Three servers reported at once. gw01 failed with "connection refused" because I had typed .20 – that is stor01, which has no web server. The log showed the address, I corrected it in the agent's settings file, and gw01 reported too. Now all four servers are listed. The agent fills the technical facts; I added the business facts – Status "In use" and Location "Acme Lab" – for all four at once with Actions → Update.

9. Next steps

1. Start gw01 first, then the others.
2. Disable `tech`, `normal`, `post-only` (Active: No) and click **Disable demonstration** – screenshot both.
3. First ticket: a **Change** – *Introduce GLPI service desk and asset inventory* – with plan, rollback (`docker compose down`) and time spent.
4. Step 1A.3: set GLPI up like a real service desk – entity *Acme Analytics*, categories, SLAs, users, knowledge-base categories.